duty bound

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by FingerCracc

Summary

“Why do they throw flowers?”

“They’re well-wishes,” Phainon answers. “Crocuses are for new beginnings, cyclamen are for love, colchicum for fidelity. They’re blessing the marriage.”

Mydei’s hand shifts a little lower, warm fingers circling Phainon’s wrist. “Your traditions are terribly sentimental.”

“Romantic,” Phainon corrects. “Just call them romantic.”
|
To save his people, Mydei strikes a deal. Aid in exchange for two things: the coreflame of Strife and his hand in marriage.

Chapter 1

Phainon does not receive summons often. Today is strange. Perhaps it's the air, chilled and sweet with out of season rain, sky cast with clouds. Perhaps it's the silence on the overcrowded streets marking the entrance to Okhema. Or perhaps it's the frown on Lady Aglaea's face, her golden threads laced through her reception room in Marmoreal Palace, quivering as Phainon brushes past them. Before her, he kneels on cold stone and bows his head in deference. "My Lady."

"Rise, Phainon," Aglaea instructs, so he does slowly, lifting his eyes to look at her. Green-gold irises look back at him, and still, she frowns. Rarely does Aglaea ever seem troubled.

"I am honored to answer my Lady's summons," Phainon says, folding his hands neatly in front of him, unafraid but uncomfortable. He can smell incense trailing in from the other rooms, sage and myrrh. Aglaea's threads vibrate as if plucked, testament to his unease.

"I've received word from Castrum Kremnos," Aglaea begins. "Nikador has lost their Reason and Honor, and grows restless. Their insanity is tantamount to Kremnos' destruction."

Nikador would not be the first titan to lose their sanity. Nor will they be the last, as the black tide stretches across Amphoreus. By the day, Okhema floods with refugees, and the rest of the world falls bit by bit. Phainon's fingers curl into a fist. The threads buzz, and he squeezes harder. Forces himself to take a breath. "My Lady, if I may, we must aid them before it's too late—"

"Silence." She doesn't raise her voice, but he quiets without question. Her threads still. She sighs, dipping her head to rub her temple. "Their crown prince has spoken to me," she continues. "He comes seeking aid, as you are so willing to offer. A promise of his people's survival."

She pauses there, and Phainon knows there's more to it than that. There are threads to all things; Aglaea knows this better than he does. Nothing this important can be freely given. He parts his lips to speak. "And what do we ask of him in return?" *We,* though Aglaea is the one who makes these decisions. Phainon, despite his prophecies and the fates that try to point otherwise, does not have what it takes to lead an entire people. Aglaea is ruthless when need be. She is the best person for this job, and Phainon, almost, sometimes, hates her for it.

"The coreflame," she says, and Phainon nods, expecting this much. Her eyes trace him, though he's unsure what, if anything, she sees. "And something to ensure the longevity of the newfound alliance between our peoples." Again, she pauses. Hesitates, perhaps, though Aglaea has never been one to hesitate. She searches Phainon for something, threads humming with his unease.

"And that is?"

"His hand in marriage," Aglaea finishes, "bequeathed to you."

△

Phainon kneels in the plaza outside of Marmoreal Palace with his hands on his thighs and his head bowed for a long time. Voices stir around him, *about* him, but he doesn't care. Even when it begins to rain and the streets empty out, he stays, feeling himself get soaked through. His hair drips into his eyes. The stone ground steals the warmth from his legs and replaces it with stiffness. Soon, he is numb and unfeeling but for the cold and this emotion like grief but louder. Rage but quieter. He is furious and indignant and *sad.* Humiliatingly devastated.

He kneels here, and he feels like a child.

The rain patters. Over it, he can't hear a single footstep. The rest of the world has already gone inside, and there's no one to witness him do this. No one to care. Even so, he stays, whether out of stubbornness or a sheer loss of how to proceed from here. Phainon, married to someone he doesn't know, who doesn't love him, all for the sake of political nuances he couldn't care less about. A prince like a bargaining chip. Phainon himself, a pawn. How nice if things could just happen without ceremony.

His teeth chatter. His hair pastes to his skull and blinds him. The rain roars around him. He keeps his head bowed, and soon, the numbness lends itself to pain.

Time passes like this. Silent tears mix with the rain. Someone holds an umbrella over him, and the torrent, if only in this spot, ceases.

"She won't see you again," says a soft voice. It's Trinnon, her bangs covering her eyes, the crown of flowers in her red hair slightly crooked. She leaves herself partly uncovered to shield him from the rain, and there are tear tracks on her cheeks, noticeable only because her face is still dry.

Phainon sighs. His eyes sting. He's so cold, frozen through, and he's made a child cry. "I'm sorry," he says, and sniffs through a running nose.

"We weep for your pain," Trinnon says. "We wish we could ease it."

"You have," Phainon promises. Gentle, he takes her hand and pushes the umbrella to cover her the rest of the way. Again, rain pelts on him, but he's already soaked, and it hardly matters. He's struck by the warmth of her tiny hand. The feeling it brings him near to tears, and he realizes what this must look like. A tantrum. An heir unwilling to do one of the most important duties asked of him. He's been outside far too long. Aglaea will not come out and rescind her words. He's known this from the start, and yet he sunk to his knees here and hasn't been able to heave himself up. "Thank you, Trinnon."

"You're freezing," she says, shifting the umbrella over him again. Her face is expressionless, those tear tracks drying. "Let us help."

"There's no need for both of us to be soaked." Still, she remains unmoving. Phainon laughs a little, a sad, pathetic thing. It sends him into a sneeze, and then he's wiping his wet eyes and nose on an equally wet arm and struggles to his feet. He nearly falls, legs stiff and cramped

and unfeeling. Trinnon drops the umbrella to catch him. Again, this nearly sends him to tears, and truly, he feels like a child. He is a child, to react like this.

Between the two of them, they manage to hobble inside.

△

He sleeps fitfully, and wakes in the morning with a cold. A mild punishment, considering his stunt last night. His nose is stuffed and his body aches, but he isn't fevered or unable to keep his breakfast down. He bathes quickly in too cold water and dresses for the day in a blue coat with gold detailing because his white one is still drying from the night before. This one pulls too tightly at his shoulders, but he doesn't notice until he's already out for the day.

Tribbie glares at him when he meets her outside. The air still smells like rain. Too cold. The street is gray and puddled with moisture. "Snowy," she says, and then pauses, frowns harder. She's looking at his blue coat. "Yesterday. What was that?"

Phainon sniffles and then tries to laugh. It comes out fake, though he does his best. They walk, sticking to the side of the thoroughfare as a droma passes, shaking the ground in its wake. "A tantrum," he answers, sniffling again. "I've accepted the consequences. Think nothing of it."

She seems upset by this, whether by the actions themselves or how Phainon is attempting to write them off. Hands on her hips, she huffs. "Is it really so bad?" she asks. "Agy wouldn't ask you to do this if it were going to be terrible."

She can't know that, not really. None of them can. Aglaea isn't omniscient. Prince Mydeimos is a mystery to them all, though his prophecies entwine with their own. He'll be a powerful ally, certainly, but there's nothing to say he won't make a terrible husband.

Phainon feels a sneeze coming on. He pinches the bridge of his nose. "Lady Aglaea does what's necessary. I—" He cuts himself off, cringing as the sneeze comes and goes without any relief. He sniffs with a disgusting wet sound. "Yesterday was a lapse of judgement. I'm… prepared, now, to accept my duty. I'm sorry for worrying you, Tribbie."

"We've heard," she starts, still, endlessly, frowning, "that Prince Mydeimos is the best warrior Castrum Kremnos has. Strong and noble and just, and willing to do anything for his people."

"Yes," Phainon says, sucking in a breath. A good warrior, certainly. He's heard the stories of Mydeimos The Undying, the man with an immortal body and the bloodlust of an entire army. He sounds wonderful at small talk. "He must care about his people a great deal, to agree to this."

Resigned, he makes the turn to put himself on the path to Marmoreal Palace, glancing down to see Tribbie follow. He folds his arms tight to him, still cold, afraid he'll never be warm again, and sniffles. Tribbie hops over a puddle, dancing around another and running to catch up to him. Phainon almost wishes he were a child again too, with only dreams for the future, no fears. Finally, that sneeze comes, and he turns his face into his elbow, leaving an

unfortunate amount of snot smeared there. It stands out horribly on the cobalt of his coat. Tribbie reaches up to offer him a handkerchief.

“You don’t need to love him,” she says optimistically. “Only get along well enough to cohabitate.”

“Sure,” Phainon laughs, wiping his nose on the cloth first, then mopping up the mess on his sleeve. But he’ll never be allowed to give his heart to another. Not openly, not properly. Titans, he’s never even been in love. This is nothing. He sighs and folds the handkerchief. “I’ll wash this before I return it,” he says, tucking it into a pocket.

“Keep it,” Tribbie says. “We have others. Ones that haven’t been filled with your snot.”

“I’m sure.” Phainon smiles. Almost means it. He stops at the place where he’d kneeled the night before and turns to her. “Thank you, Tribbie.”

She smiles and reaches to take his gloved hand with both of hers, so much smaller. “No more goodbyes,” she says. “May you find your way with Janus’ blessings.” He bows his head to her. She lets his hands go and steps back, and when he looks, she’s smiling wide. “All stops are important to the journey. You’ll end up exactly where you need to be.”

“Thank you,” he says again, because it’s really all he can say, and then he watches her wave and skip away. When she’s gone, he turns back to face the palace. A heavy breath. He wipes his nose with the handkerchief again and makes his way inside.

Aglaea is waiting, expecting him in her reception chamber. This time, her strings are not strung about. There’s only the way she watches him as he comes in, neatly folding her needlework and setting her hands in her lap. “Lord Phainon,” she greets. A garment maker takes the fabric she’d been sewing and whisks away.

He bows his head. “Lady Aglaea.”

She stands from her seat and smooths her dress. “That was quite a scene you put on last night.” She steps closer, heels clicking on the stone floor. “I see you’ve made yourself ill.”

“Yes,” Phainon says, fighting the urge to sniffle and trying not to drown in his own embarrassment. *A child,* he thinks. *All these years and all this responsibility, and you still act like a child.* His fate has never been his own. He would do well to remember that. “I… apologize for last night. I’ve come to my senses and I’m ready to do my duty as a Chrysos Heir.”

Aglaea is quiet. She paces a slow circle around him, and it makes him inexplicably nervous. When she returns to his front, she stops, and he’s forced to face the green-gold of her eyes. “I wouldn’t force you,” she says firmly. “I asked you to consider. A marriage is the safest way I can think to secure an alliance, but I would never force you.”

“I understand,” Phainon says, gaze dipping to the floor. The relationship between Okhema and Castrum Kremnos has been strained for a long time. An alliance on the basis of desperation and death alone will be tumultuous at best. His people will pillage, theirs will

fight tooth and nail. He understands, he does, he just wishes it could have been someone else in his place. Aglaea inclines her head for him to continue. He presses his tongue hard into the roof of his mouth to suppress a sneeze. “And I…” His voice wavers. “...Am prepared to do whatever you ask of me.”

“Phainon,” she says heavily, “you sound near to tears. I—”

He sneezes hard enough to hurt his throat, barely managing to catch it in the pit of his elbow. “I—” Another sneeze, and he has to turn away from her, heat climbing to his face. “Apologize. I’m simply unwell, not—”

She laughs, softly, so he stops speaking. He keeps his arm over the lower half of his face as he turns back to her. A slender hand holds out a crisp white handkerchief. The second he’s had to borrow today. “To think,” she says, smiling when he takes it, “I thought you’d been about to cry.”

“No, Lady Aglaea,” he says apologetically, mortified beyond belief as he wipes his nose. “Only about to sneeze.”

“Wash your hands and face,” she dismisses him, “and then we will finish this conversation.”

He bows shortly and steps out, finding his way to water and clean cloths, where he blows his nose and washes up as instructed. He finds his own face, still flushed in the mirror, and tries to swallow down his embarrassment.

Aglaea smiles. “Come sit,” she invites him, gesturing to a spot on the stone bench beside her. When he does, she spreads her fingers and fills the space around them with her golden threads. “There is no need to be alarmed,” she says, closing her eyes as she does. “I would only know the truth as you speak it.” Still, the threads hum with his unease. They always do, just lightly. Aglaea knows they make him nervous.

“Are you comfortable?”

“Not quite, but it’ll do.”

Again, she smiles, eyes peeling open. Gently, she touches his left hand with both of hers, chilled slightly below body temperature, winding one of her strings around his pinky finger. It’s translucent and insubstantial but for a slight warmth that radiates from it. “What’s this?” he asks.

“Mnestia’s blessings,” she answers, releasing his hand. “An oath, should you choose to swear it.”

Phainon flexes his fingers and finds nothing different. Just the warmth, slight as it is. “I… see.”

“Are you willing?”

He takes a breath. The rest of the threads hum, glistening gold around them. “Yes,” he says, and the one around his finger grows a little brighter, less wispy.

Aglaea seems pleased. “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, are you willing to accept the hand of Prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos?” she continues. The threads around them buzz louder. She notes this and studies him. “I will not force you.”

“I am willing,” Phainon says, though his stomach flips on itself. The strings get louder, so he swallows thickly and tries to explain. “I am willing to do this to save his people, and to secure the coreflame for ours, but…” His throat bobs. “I am not willing to force myself to love a stranger.”

The buzzing quiets. “I understand,” Aglaea says. The string on his pinky finger solidifies a bit more. “You will marry him, but you don’t believe yourself capable of loving him?”

“Yes,” Phainon murmurs.

“That is enough.” Aglaea pulls the string taut and plucks it once, releasing a soft, resonant sound. “Will you make the oath?” she asks.

Heat wraps around his hand. Phainon takes a breath so deep it strains his lungs. “Yes,” he swears. Again, Aglaea plucks the string, fully substantial now. “I accept the hand of Prince Mydeimos in marriage.”

One more time, another sweet, resonant sound. Aglaea releases the string, and the heat settles into something soft and neutral. “Mnestia’s blessings,” Aglaea says reverently. “With this, you are bound.”

△

The thread remains on his finger. It’s invisible when he doesn’t think about it, but when he does it appears with soft translucence and a sensation like body heat. A tie to Prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos. An oath to an entire people in need of saving. Phainon sighs and, run dry, leaves the palace.

The clouds have cleared up by now. The path outside is lit by the sun and beginning to dry out. It smells like beginnings—even through Phainon’s stuffed nose—and he tries to be optimistic.

A noble man, he thinks, hands slipping into his pockets only to withdraw upon discovering two sullied handkerchiefs. He imagines a faceless stranger, someone broad and armored and bold. Someone desperate and full of vengeance, with the bloodlust of an entire army contained in an immortal body. And then he stops, because he doesn’t know this crown prince, and it doesn’t feel fair to use rumors to try.

“Lord Phainon.” He’s stopped by a voice. He turns to find Castorice there, hands clasped in front of her. She looks like she’d been considering whether or not to approach for a long time.

“Castorice,” he greets her, inclining his head.

“I… apologize, for listening in, but I wanted to offer my blessings.” She seems saddened, perhaps for him, though her expression is carefully neutral. “And… My congratulations as well.”

He smiles, and tries to mean it. “Thank you,” he says, and thinks of the souls he will prevent her from guiding. *This will save people,* he thinks. *Hardly anything will change anyway.* There’s no love to hold him back, and there’s room enough for another in his home. They’ll be powerful allies, and perhaps they’ll become friends.

Castorice bids him farewell, never one to linger, and he drags himself home to sleep the rest of the night away. His body aches and difficulty breathing makes it hard to rest, but he tries. Succeeds in pieces. He forces himself up for lunch and dinner and finds the time to launder his borrowed handkerchiefs, stuffing the pockets of his too tight cobalt coat with a few of his own.

Late, he finds himself toying with the string on his finger. It glows faintly as he lays in bed and wills it to appear. Translucence, and a sensation like body heat. He wonders what an oath like this spells for his impending future. It feels, he thinks, like something dangerous.

With a sigh, he slips his hands under the covers and resigns himself to sleep.

△

In the morning, he is marginally less stuffy. He blows his nose and washes his face, then subjects himself to a breakfast of dried fruit and bread. Today, his appetite deserts him, but he forces down as much as he can before he pulls on his white coat, freshly washed and dried, and makes his way to the baths.

According to a mother Phainon hasn’t seen in a long time, there’s nothing better for a sick man than a hot bath and a cup of apple cider vinegar. He’ll skip the vinegar, but the bath feels overdue. He rinses off in cold water first, and then sinks into the soothing, golden heat of the Chrysos Heirs’ bath.

It’s humid, smelling like salt and incense. Phainon is the only one here at the moment, so he leans back with his eyes closed and nothing to listen to but the sound of running water. The steam curling off the hot water helps to clear his sinuses and ease his aches. There’s nothing to focus on but this, nothing to worry about. Just this place and its peace, its comfort. This lasts for all of three minutes before the sound of another set of footsteps disturbs it. Phainon opens his eyes and is met not with Aglaea or Castorice or Tribbie or another of the Chrysos Heirs, but with an unfamiliar face.

“This is the Chrysos Heirs’ bath chamber,” he says, casual in his correction. This would not be the first time someone attempted to sneak in, and Phainon has never found it to be worth a fight. The newcomer looks at him with slanted eyes, the right lined in red, and an unkind expression, though perhaps that’s just his face.

“Yes,” he says, and strips out of his robe and trousers to sink into the bath a reasonable distance away. His entire torso has been made a canvas for crimson markings, another on his cheek that had been hidden by his hair. When he settles, his sigh is as heavy as if he carried

Kephale's burden of the world himself. There's something familiar about the way he melts into the bath, an exhaustion Phainon has been intimately familiar with after a drawn out battle.

He carries himself like a warrior, and just for that, Phainon doesn't care to kick him out. No one who fights in this long and bloody war should be denied a moment of respite.

There's a long silence between them. Phainon stretches his legs out and observes for a moment. A build like a soldier, tall and muscled. He's broad in the shoulders and chest, in the arms. Phainon tries to decide what kind of weapon he wields based on the distribution of his mass, but he comes up empty. Moments later, this stranger cracks an eye open. "I have an invitation," he explains, and then goes silent again.

Slowly, Phainon nods. He doesn't ask more, though he's curious. There isn't a single scar on this man to be seen. Curious. Phainon himself is covered in them, from tiny nicks to giant gashes. No soldier comes out of their service unharmed, and yet… "That's your cue to stop staring," the stranger speaks again, leveling Phainon with an amber gaze. He looks like a challenge. Phainon can't help tracing his red over again in search of scars, and still, he can't find a single one. Curious.

"That braid," Phainon starts, eyeing the strawberry blond plait behind the man's ear, "you're Kremnoan, aren't you? A refugee?"

A breath huffed like a laugh. The stranger props his jaw on his fist and stares lazily. "Kremnoan, yes," he says, and his voice is deep, a little gravelly. "A refugee… Well, I suppose you could call it that."

"I've heard Nikador has gone mad," Phainon says, turning to face the man properly now that a conversation has opened up. "How bad is it there? What of King Eurypon?"

Something like a scoff. The Kremnoan's lip curls. "Dead," he says. "And you, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, are considerably less bright than they make you out to be."

He only has a second to process the news before the sting of insult distracts him. Phainon's eyes narrow. "You know me?" he asks.

"Amphoreus' perfect vessel." His gaze dips to Phainon's chest, back up to the mark on his throat. "'The nameless hero embarking on a grand mission of deliverance.' The best hope Castrum Kremnos has left. I'd have to be an idiot not to."

He recites that piece of Phainon's prophecy like a curse. There's something hot boiling in his eyes, and Phainon finds his own anger kindled in turn. He bites his tongue and crosses his arms in an unintentionally defensive posture. "'The best hope Castrum Kremnos has left'," he echoes, raising an eyebrow. "And what of you, if you're strong enough to provoke me? Or are you just as stupid as you seem to think I am?"

This earns him a grin. This stranger, whoever he is, is *enjoying* this. He lifts his free hand out of the water, holding it out, and Phainon… Phainon is enjoying this too. Water drips from that

palm and spills down a muscled forearm, and there, extending from the man's little finger is a thread, thin and translucent, and everything starts to make sense.

The prince, then. Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, The Undying, Mydeimos. Phainon's… betrothed.

"I could take you in a fight, Deliverer." Mydeimos says, tongue as sharp as his teeth. His smile is cruel. "I might even win."

And Phainon, astounded, can only laugh. He runs a hand through his wet hair, the one with the matching string, and says, "you'll do well not to call me that."

Mydeimos grins wider, venom behind it, the bloodlust of an entire army. "And what would you prefer, future husband? Because I can think of a hundred things that you are, and not one lives up to your reputation."

Phainon scoffs, finding himself closer and thrilling with something hot and angry. "What a first impression you're making," he says, looking Mydeimos up and down. "That eager to test Okhema's fighting prowess? Or is ridicule how you always begin a courtship?"

"My apologies," Mydeimos says, looking wicked with wet hair and this look in his eyes. "Is prostrating in the rain a better way to make a man feel wanted? Okhema's culture is certainly a bit diff—"

Phainon's fists curl. "You—"

In an instant, they're on each other, grappling in the water. Phainon throws a punch that Mydeimos catches, using the momentum to pull him forward into his knee. Phainon twists and throws them sideways into the bath, hooking an ankle around Mydeimos' legs to take his balance. They land with a splash, spray in their eyes, and Phainon wrenches his wrist free and blindly shoves Mydeimos underwater. There's a brief struggle and he's bucked off. Mydeimos throws him under instead, pinning him with his weight, trying to get a hold of his wrists. Phainon thrashes. Liquid floods his nose and mouth. Adrenaline sings. He rams his knee into Mydeimos' stomach and throws himself back to the surface, vision blurred from the water in his eyes, blindly throwing a punch. Mydeimos slips away from it, catches the kick he sends next, and sends him stumbling backwards.

He blinks the last of the water away and tries to catch his breath, fingers slipping in a puddle outside the pool, over the edge, and in moments, he's backed into the wall of the bath with a thin red crystal at his throat. When his vision focuses, it's to Mydeimos gritting his teeth, a look in his eyes that could make a room full of children cry.

"You, future husband," he growls, water dripping into his eyes, panting hard, "fight dirty."

Phainon finally catches his breath, holding careful eye contact for a handful of seconds. He swallows, and the crystal at his throat almost pricks him. Then, a dagger, slipped from his discarded pile of clothes outside the bath, rests just above Mydeimos' naval. "You do too," he says, watching Mydeimos realize it's there. Whatever this is, it's petty and immature and it's the youngest Phainon has felt in a long time.

Slow, Mydeimos grins. “Ruthless,” he breathes, and it sounds like praise.

Phainon grins back. “Bloodthirsty,” he replies.

After a breath, Mydeimos withdraws, pulling away and plunking back into the bath at Phainon’s side. It’s with reluctant respect that he says, “Perhaps you are half as strong as they say you are.”

Phainon laughs and tosses the dagger back on his clothes. He shoves dripping hair out of his eyes and slides down, slinging his arms across the edge of the bath. “Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos,” he says, cocking his head, “I think I quite like you.”

Half-lidded eyes study him in return. “Mydei,” comes the correction. “Mydeimos is far too long.”

“Mydei, then,” Phainon assents. He leans back and shuts his eyes, takes a deep breath of humid air. “Here’s to a successful partnership.”

△

“You’ll have to court him,” Aglaea says, needle and thread between her fingers. She’s swift as she stitches. “There are rules you must follow.”

“Yes,” Phainon says. “Only… I’m afraid I’m unfamiliar with these things.”

Aglaea sighs and lowers the fabric to her lap. “Gifts come first,” she says, holding up one finger. “Fruits and wine, then finery. Clothing, jewelry. Weaponry, if you think he’d be keener. You will write to each other—letters, poetry if you can find the inspiration—and spend at least some amount of time in each other’s company. Your house will need to be prepared for him to occupy it immediately after you marry.”

“And when will that be exactly?”

“Reasonably, six months from now. Realistically, one. We cannot afford to dally when Nikador runs amok.”

“I… see.”

“Lord Phainon,” Aglaea says, firmer than before. “I understand this is inconvenient, but this is important, and you must treat it as such.”

“I know,” he says, and suppresses a curse. “I am, I was just… thinking, I guess. I apologize.”

She lifts her work again so he won’t be subjected to the intensity of her gaze. “Do you regret this?” she asks, untangling her thread.

Phainon wets his lips. “No,” he says, and means it. “It’s just strange. The thought of myself… married.” He thinks of Mydei and the word *husband* feels out of place. That wicked grin and the soft domesticity Phainon associates with marriage are irreconcilable with each other. Not that their marriage was ever going to be a soft, domestic thing.

Aglaea considers this, humming softly. “If it’s any solace,” she begins, “I don’t believe he will be a terrible husband to you.”

“No,” Phainon breathes. “I don’t suppose he will.” A sigh, and he straightens up. “Thank you, Aglaea. I’ll look for suitable gifts immediately.”

“Good,” she says, and levels him with a stare. “Are you prepared for the engagement to go public?”

Phainon takes a deep breath, then nods, pursing his lips. “Yes,” he says, more to himself than to her. “I’m ready.” And suddenly this feels very, very real.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> gdocs counts △ as a word and ao3 doesn't, and gdocs counts two words connected by an em dash as one, while ao3 counts it as two. adding a new chapter doesn't let me see the word count when I hit preview. in short: achieving nice word counts is far more difficult than usual and it's making me maddddd

Okhema is a far more welcoming place than Castrum Kremnos. Mydei notes this immediately upon entering the city. The day he arrives is rainy and gray, but the city is still golden, and the streets are still full, and the people still smile. It's fascinating, heartening, and disconcerting all at once.

So he enters this smiling city with a purpose, and hours later, he sells himself to it as a bargaining chip.

Lady Aglaea outfits him with his own guest chambers. He's given a soft bed, a warm bath, and a breathtaking view of the city. The sheets are crisp and smell like cherry laurel, and Mydei hates this cage of a room like he hates little else. He feels like a thistle in a garden of flowers, and a handful of days after his arrival, he's already set to leave.

After breakfast, he packs his scant amount of things and makes a final stop to speak to Lady Aglaea before his departure. He finds her at the Hero's Bath, standing before the golden water that cascades from above. Her back is turned to him, so he can't see her face, but her posture is upright and strong. Aglaea the Goldweaver is not a monarch, but she holds herself like a queen. Bearer of the Romance coreflame, Mydei doesn't doubt that she's one of the most powerful people in Amphoreus.

One of her threads sits on his finger, beneath his gauntlet. It warms when he's reminded of it, and he wonders—not for the first time—how exactly it binds him.

"Crown Prince Mydeimos," Aglaea greets, though the water is loud enough to cover his footsteps and he has yet to speak. Her back stays turned as he approaches, but her power of perception means she likely doesn't need to look at someone to know their every move. "To what do I owe the pleasure?"

Her voice is smooth and impartial, and Mydei is wary of her in a way he is rarely wary of anyone else. She makes conversation into a game of strategy. Mydei was raised a warrior, not a diplomat.

"I must return to Castrum Kremnos to share the news," he answers, crossing his arms over his chest. Hesitating briefly, he adds, "Many will seek asylum. The longer I stay, the more

lives are lost."

Aglaea's shoulders rise with her breath. "Yes," she says, and finally turns, her eyes leveling with his. "Do you know why the water in the Hero's bath shines with gold?" she asks, gesturing behind her with one open palm.

The string on his hand again makes itself known. Mydei tenses. "No," he says, and she waves him forward. With a few reluctant steps, he's faced with the pool, glittering in uneven patterns as the stream from above disturbs it.

"It's a blessing from Phagousa," Aglaea explains. "The Hero's bath is steeped with their lifeblood to cleanse the black tide from the Chrysos Heirs' bodies." She bends to dip her fingers into the water, and when she straightens up, the water that clings to her holds a faint shimmer. "Parts of Castrum Kremnos have already succumbed to the tide, haven't they?"

Mydei stays carefully silent.

"You came alone," Aglaea continues, "without anyone to wait on or advise you. You don't want to send a messenger with the news and instead wish to go in person. Your father, according to rumor, is dead."

The hair on the back of Mydei's neck stands on end. Nothing she says to him is a secret, and yet. "What are you getting at, Goldweaver?"

"You spent a long time away from home, Undying prince." She smiles slightly and lowers her hand. "Do you truly believe you can prevent Castrum Kremnos' fall?"

She is a terrifyingly perceptive creature. "Whether or not the city falls," Mydei says, "my people will not."

Based on her expression, this gives away more than enough. "Okhema is a refuge with open doors," is all she says. He already asked for this before any other negotiations were made. Safe haven for the people whose homes have been turned to rubble. Sunlight, for those trapped in the dark. Mydei's hand, this scant amount of freedom lost, is hardly a price at all in the wake of that.

He bows his head in respect and says, "You have my thanks."

"Would you join us in the rebuilding of the world?" Aglaea asks.

"Nikador's coreflame already belongs to your cause." The last pieces of his crumbling god. Mydei has nothing left to give.

"Yes," Aglaea agrees. "But who better to bear it by our side than you?"

It's a horrible feeling that the words give him. Ink on his tongue, staining his teeth. "No," Mydei says with a low laugh. "Your perfect vessel will bear it. You have no need for me."

Slowly, she nods, but her smile is a small, knowing thing as she turns back to the water. "Phainon has been waiting a long time to fulfill his destiny," she says, and leaves it at that.

She has more to say, this much is obvious, but she won't say it. Mydei remains quiet.

"Will you meet him before you go?" Aglaea asks lightly, and Mydei remembers a challenge of a smile. Blue eyes and soaked white hair. A sun on the side of a pale throat and the tip of a dagger to his belly.

"I can," Mydei says, instead of *I have,* because he thinks better of lying to a woman like this, and he doesn't think the kind of meeting they had is one for the history books. The string on his finger heats, and Aglaea isn't looking at him, but he feels as though she sees right through him.

△

Phainon—dressed to be out in public—wears a white coat and a blue and gold half cape. His hair sticks up in a handful of places when dry, and he obscures the sun on his neck with a high collar and a choker fitted tight to skin. He looks every bit the hero he's said to be, and Mydei does his very best to pretend they have never spoken.

Aglaea introduces them, playing the role a parent might in a marriage between people who have those. Mydei makes all the proper pleasantries, and Phainon plays along. When they bow to each other to complete the act, he quirks one eyebrow, lips curling up, and Mydei looks away.

"You're pretending you don't know me," Phainon notes later when they're seated beside each other at the dinner Aglaea had prepared for this. The room is packed full of Okhema's most important people, and he leans in close enough that Mydei can smell the olive oil and pine resin scent of him. He's terribly indiscreet, and Mydei does not look at him.

"Yes," he agrees, keeping his voice low. "Unless you would rather everyone here know we accosted each other in the baths?" Across the table, the Holy Maidens of Janusopolis pluck grapes from a bunch as they talk to a girl with pink hair and a delicate crown. She wears a dress adorned with flowers and a tired expression, and she gives the people around her a wide berth. The Maiden of War, he thinks, but he's forgotten her name. She meets his eyes when she notices him looking, and there's an odd flash in her expression.

Beside him, Phainon interrupts his train of thought. "You're just afraid they'll find out you lost," he whispers, far too cocky, goading.

Mydei inhales and flicks his gaze to him. "I had you by the throat," he hisses.

The smile it earns him is far too pleased. "And I had you," Phainon says. He cocks his head a little. "So I suppose we can call it a stalemate."

The way he carries himself—he is a fledgling hero still waiting for a chance to fulfill his destiny. Mydei holds his ice blue gaze and says with surety, "You wouldn't hold a candle to me in a real battle."

Phainon squints. "You speak rather confidently for someone who's never seen me in a 'real battle.'"

“Is that an invitation?”

"Do you want it to be?"

Mydei studies him. The honest challenge in his eyes, the fluff of his hair that makes him look like some over eager dog. In Castrum Kremnos, a test of strength is standard before a betrothal. The groom to be will challenge the father of the bride, and the outcome determines whether or not he earns her hand. Neither of them has a father to speak of, and neither of them is much of a bride. "Perhaps," he says. "I'd like to know whether or not I can regard you as an equal."

Somehow this makes Phainon laugh, taking the insult with far too much ease. "They say you have the bloodlust of an entire army," he says. "Is someone’s fighting prowess directly proportional to the respect you give them?" He's too close. Olive oil and pine resin. Mydei narrows his eyes.

"Respect," he says, "is earned, not given."

"Respect," Phainon counters, "is given so it can be earned."

A brief pause. Mydei considers the earnest way he says this. Phainon, he thinks, must be merciful on the battlefield. A virtue, or a vice that could get him killed. "You're fascinating, Deliverer."

"What did I say about calling me that?" Phainon asks, voice low, leaning in a little more.

"Beat me," Mydei challenges him, grinning, "and maybe I'll stop."

"Is the food to your tastes, Your Highness?" Aglaea interrupts, looking between them with an unreadable expression. Mydei can never tell what she's thinking. Perhaps she finds their behavior improper or wants to prevent a conflict. The Maiden of War is watching again. Mydei meets her eyes and dips his head slowly.

"Yes," he says, and turns back to Aglaea. Beside him, Phainon has returned to his own space and is picking at his plate, chastened. An over eager dog with his ears drooping. Mydei doesn't know what to make of the switch. "My compliments to your cooks."

△

"This is for you." Phainon catches him before he can slip away at the end of the night. He presents Mydei with a small box under the watchful eye of Aglaea on the other side of the room. Mydei feels her gaze on him like a tangible thing. The sensation is like a pair of too tight boots. The hair on the back of his neck prickles.

Slightly wary, he takes the box and asks, "What is it?"

Phainon blinks. "A gift," he says, like it's obvious. "For you."

"I see." Mydei lowers his gaze to the box. Courting gifts are not customary in Castrum Kremnos. He does not relish the thought that he'll have to give one in return. "Thank you."

Again, Phainon blinks. He glances at Aglaea, almost anxious. "Aren't you going to open it?"

Managing not to sigh, Mydei does. He lifts the lid and peels back the paper on the inside. The box holds bottles of rust solvent and armor polish, no doubt expensive, and entirely, unexpectedly practical. “Oh,” he says, inspecting one of the bottles.

Phainon shifts, watching carefully for his reaction. “You didn’t strike me as someone who likes flowers or jewelry,” he explains. After a brief pause, “Feel free to correct me if I’m wrong.”

“No,” Mydei says, gaze lifting to him as he puts the bottle back. “You’re correct; I appreciate things I can actually use. Thank you.”

Phainon lifts a hand to rub his neck, fingers hooking beneath his choker. He’s relieved, obviously. He wears every emotion openly—that or he’s an exceptional pretender. Mydei still can’t make sense of him, can’t decide what he is and what he isn’t. He thinks of a fight in the bath and a challenge at the dinner table. And then he thinks of the man kneeling in the rain and finds him completely at odds with the one in front of him. Their marriage is a massive inconvenience at best. At worst, it will upend Phainon’s life and rob him of a chance at real, earnest love. He doesn’t want this, Mydei knows that, and yet here he is.

And yet here he is, smiling somewhat nervously, saying, “You’re very welcome,” and giving Lady Aglaea the smallest glance. Perhaps that’s it, her orders, her instruction, her idea of a courting gift.

Something like guilt churns in Mydei’s stomach as he slips the box in one of his trouser pockets.

“Lord Phainon,” he says, stiffly formal for fear that their banter earlier may have gotten Phainon in trouble. For fear that this may too. “Could I speak to you alone for a moment?”

Something strange crosses Phainon’s expression, his smile faltering. “Yes,” he says, glancing again at Aglaea. “Of course, um.” He gestures rigidly and leads the way out and down the hall to one of Marmoreal Palace’s cold bath chambers. The pool is empty, closed to the public this late, and dappled with light. Phainon stops them here, turning to face Mydei, cast in blue. “Is something wrong—?”

“Is she forcing you?” Mydei asks.

“What?”

“Lady Aglaea. Has she forced you into this?”

“I—” Phainon’s eyebrows furrow. “Huh?”

Mydei makes a frustrated sound. “You knelt in the rain for hours,” he says. “I know you don’t want this, and now you’re giving me courting gifts after dinner while she watches like a hawk. What changed?”

The confusion on Phainon's face shifts into a frown. His gaze floats around Mydei's face for a moment before it slips off him like water. "I apologize for that," he says softly. When Mydei grunts, he adds, "Kneeling out there. Making a spectacle out of it. I was…" He sniffs, the tail end of a cold sounding with it. "Upset, at first. I didn't think you would see it, I was just…"

Mydei sighs. "I need to know if you're unwilling," he says. "I can't exchange your wishes for the fate of my people, but perhaps—"

"I'm not," Phainon says. Again, "I'm not. Unwilling, that is. I was upset at first, but anyone would be. I'm not going to abandon an entire people just because I hoped I'd get the chance to marry for love." He purses his lips and laughs a little. It's bittersweet, that laugh. Mydei has never dreamed of marrying for love, but he gets it. The discomfort of being bound like this. Phainon will have to open his home, and Mydei will have to accept it as a cage.

"Aglaea is only advising me on how to conduct the courtship," Phainon continues. "She gave me plenty of outs; I swear to you I wouldn't be here if I was truly unwilling. That night in the rain was a tantrum, and I'm frankly mortified that you saw it. I'd ask you to forget about it, if possible."

Mydei studies him for untruth. He doesn't have the power of perception like Aglaea does, but Phainon has his heart on his sleeve. He meets Mydei's gaze again, and he must mean this. And so, Mydei laughs. "Forget Okhema's perfect vessel in the rain like a wet dog? Not a chance."

"I'm going to excuse that," Phainon says, raising his eyebrows and rocking on his heels, "because it's nice to know that the person I'm bound to for the rest of my life cares, at least a little bit, about my wishes."

Mydei folds his arms and stares at him, unimpressed.

"I meant it," Phainon tells him, grinning. "I like you, Mydei. We could build quite the partnership out of this, as equals."

"You're far too certain that you're my match."

"And you're far too stubborn in denying it."

△

The return to Castrum Kremnos is anything but grand. Mydei is sure to keep it that way. He dresses to cover up the markings on his torso and slips through the city gates without procession or fanfare.

The streets are crowded with people, cacophonous with raised voices and chaos, and there are droplets of blood spilled on the ground in his path. This section of the city is one of many that haven't yet fallen to rubble and eternal night. Many have been forced to relocate, but there's little space and fewer resources to share. Castrum Kremnos has no shortage of fighters and few, if any, peacemakers.

He makes it to the palace and removes the cloak he'd been wearing. A shocked servant stumbles over himself to bow. "Your Highness," he gets out, tripping over his tongue. "We. You—"

"Send for Krateros," Mydei tells him. Faced with high walls and the sharp smell of crushed indigo stones, he finds himself bending under the weight of his exhaustion. This place is no home, but it's the closest he has, and when the servant bows again and leaves, he finds his way to his chambers.

They're kept carefully clean in his absence. Have been, even since before his original return, kept carefully by a handful of his mother's trusted servants. Free from dust, the bed made with fresh sheets, clothing hanging neatly in the closet, armor and weaponry lining the walls, with a spot to sit and polish.

There's a window stretching from floor to ceiling on one wall, the drapes pulled open to light the room. Mydei comes to it and is faced with the view of his ruined city. Much of it looks the same as it always has—neighborhoods lined with densely packed houses, grand architecture tipped with gold, wide market streets filled with people. Castrum Kremnos has never been happy the way Okhema seems to be, but Mydei's memories have always painted it as strong and prosperous. There's one that sticks out. Candied pomegranate and a rough hand in his hair belonging to a scarred, smiling woman.

He sighs. At the far edges of his city there are buildings reduced to dust, homes shrouded in darkness, roads patrolled by titankin. Day by day, they take more and more from his people.

From the pocket of his trousers, he tosses the gift from Phainon on top of one of his trunks. It lands without breaking and he backs into the bed to sit on crimson sheets, spine bowing forward, elbows resting on his knees. He wrestles the pauldron off his left shoulder and removes his gauntlets, letting them crash to the ground. He lets out a long, heavy exhale. It's a bitter kind of nostalgia he's overcome with. This place hasn't been his home in a long time, and yet. His sleeve slips off and pools with the rest of the fabric at his waist and he just… breathes for a moment. Tries, shutting his eyes and rubbing his temples.

He's interrupted by a knock on the door, quick and loud and frantic. "Your Highness Mydeimos," comes Krateros' urgent voice. Mydei huffs the closest to a laugh he can muster and opens his eyes to the hard floor and his own palms. His body aches as he stands. "You will open the door this instant or so help me, I will—"

Mydei pulls the door open. Krateros cuts off, mouth open, and then his expression shifts to something seething. "Where have you *been?* It's been *days,* and we've been left without a leader! What was so important that you had to disappear without a moment's notice? We are at *war,* in case you haven't—"

"I was busy securing options," Mydei says, biting the inside of his cheek and moving out of the doorway so Krateros can come inside.

"Options?" Krateros echoes, incredulous. He shuts the door behind himself, looking Mydei over. "Nikador's Strife, you stink like cherry laurel, where *were* you?"

After an inhale, turning his back and retreating further into the room, Mydei answers, "Okhema."

Krateros follows, still standing as Mydei settles into one of the armchairs amidst his armor collection. It smells like oil and polish over here, ever familiar but not quite comforting. "You…" Krateros trails off, suddenly contemplative.

Mydei hesitates, frowning, and then clears his throat to continue, settling into the chair with his legs wide and his cheek on his fist. "They're willing to lend aid," he says, "and their gates are open to our refugees."

"Okhema," Krateros says under his breath. He sits, finally, folding his hands in his lap and nodding slowly. "You're thinking like a leader, Mydeimos, so when will you take the throne and make yourself one?"

"We've already discussed this," Mydei says, straightening up.

"You know better than anyone that nothing good comes from trying to prevent a prophecy."

Mydei stares coldly at him. Remembers, against his will, the rush of frigid water filling immortal lungs. The way it feels to die, over and over again. "The prophecy says I will guide Castrum Kremnos to its fall," he growls.

"And yet you still lead them," Krateros says. "A king in everything but name."

"I tire of this."

A sigh. "Fine then," Krateros says, waving a hand. "Okhema then. What of their terms?"

"They ask for Nikador's coreflame," Mydei tells him.

"The authority of Strife is no small price to pay," Krateros notes. He purses his lips and shakes his head, and Mydei remembers the last thing he has left of his mother. *You can trust Krateros. He's my chosen guardian.*

"I have no want for it," Mydei replies as evenly as he can. "They will take it for their flame-chase journey to rid the world of the black tide."

"And you believe in them?"

"Krateros," Mydei says. "It's as simple as this: I do not care."

Krateros studies him with a frown but does not press. "The coreflame, then," he sighs. "Is that all they ask?"

And this part, Mydei thinks, will not go over well. "A marriage between their perfect vessel and myself to solidify our nations as allies," he answers.

Krateros' eyes flash. *"What?"*

“Peace, Krateros,” Mydei says. “I believe we may be an even match.” He thinks of the stalemate in the baths. Phainon’s eager expression when it comes to testing that theory properly. Even if they’re not, it’s clear that Phainon is a fine warrior. He carries himself like it, confident in his own ability, and anything he lacks, there’s still time to learn. Regardless of whether or not he’s actually Mydei’s match, he’ll be a strong ally.

Mydei knew he would never marry for love. This is the best he can hope for. “I’m fine with it.”

“If you take the throne—”

“I *won’t* take the throne,” Mydei cuts him off. “You have no need to worry about me elevating an Okheman to king.”

Krateros leans forward on his elbows, holding Mydei’s gaze. He takes a deep, punctuated breath and shuts his eyes. “You’re free to do as you please,” he says, “but I wish you wouldn’t take on everything alone.”

“I trust you to watch the city,” Mydei says. “Saving the people is my responsibility.”

△

Days later, Mydei returns to the palace bloodstained and battered after an assault on the battlefield that has become Castrum Kremnos’ outer edges. His soldiers were heartened to see him on the front lines again after his absence. The battle went well, every titankin in sight crushed, but that piece of the city is only a small part of a very large problem. But Mydei can’t take on Nikador alone, and it feels good to do *something.*

When he pushes through the doors, hair messed, the hems of his robes tattered, gauntlets stained in dried blood, there’s a servant waiting for him. She clears her throat and bends at the waist. “Your Royal Highness,” she says stiffly.

“Rise,” Mydei tells her, and when she straightens, she holds out an envelope to him. It’s crisp, creamy white paper, and it bears Okhema’s seal.

“A letter has arrived from Okhema,” she says, “addressed to you.”

Mydei plucks it from her hands and turns it over. T *o Be Delivered to Crown Prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos* is written in careful penmanship, and it’s sealed with gold wax stamped with Kephale’s visage. Mydei has already left crusted blood on the paper just by taking it.

“Thank you,” he says, dismissing the servant, and trudges to his rooms for a bath.

Castrum Kremnos doesn’t have them like Okhema does. He has his own tub and a tap with hot, running water, but nothing blessed by Phagousa themself. As it fills up, Mydei pulls off his armor piece by piece, setting it on the table amidst its stand to be cleaned later. He does this himself as he does most things. His experience with luxury had been short lived, and now

he's unaccustomed to—and uncomfortable with—the thought of having servants for everything.

Washing his hands in a small basin and drying them, Mydei takes the letter again and uses the dagger he keeps hidden at his waist to open it. Inside are two sheets of smooth paper. It's a letter from Phainon, though it's only been a handful of days since Mydei returned to Castrum Kremnos. His handwriting is different from that on the envelope. Denser and somewhat loopy, his letters bleeding into each other. Mydei sits on the side of the bathtub and unfolds it to read.

Mydei,

I hope that isn't an overly familiar way to address you in a letter, considering you told me to call you that yourself. Although, I suppose courtship is overly familiar by nature. If you'd rather use full titles and formality in our correspondence, feel free to say so.

I'm writing to you because you disappeared far sooner than expected and I thought you might want the news. The reception to our engagement has been nothing but positive since Aglaea announced it. The people are curious about you; you should have heard some of the things said at the procession. They have you painted as a beautiful, delicate maiden rather than one of Amphoreus' strongest warriors. Only a handful have anything to say about the fact that you're Kremnoan, which leads me to be optimistic about the future of our alliance. Hopefully Okhema can be the safe haven that your people need.

Briefly, Mydei pauses to check the temperature of the water. He dips his fingers in it and finds it near to scalding, just how he likes it. In goes a handful of salts, and as he stirs the water, he notes the soft glow of the string on his pinky finger. It only ever makes itself known when he wills it to or when he thinks of Phainon. It's an unsettling, disconcerting thing, a thread from the Demigod of Romance.

" *Think of it as nothing more than a matchmaker's whims,"* Aglaea had told him as she tied it to him. " *You have my word that it can't be used to harm or surveil you in any way."*

"Then why tie it at all?"

"If one day it turns gold, you will find it important," is all Aglaea provided as an answer.

Now, it's a soft, translucent silver, hardly there but for a soft warmth it radiates. It'll fade if Phainon dies or is in particularly perilous danger, which, if nothing else, would be useful to know if need arises. Until then, Mydei supposes he can do nothing but wait to see if it'll turn gold. He wipes his hand dry on his pants and returns to the letter.

When you return, we'll have a short celebration here. Aglaea wants to set the wedding for the third day of the harvest month—rather soon, I'm aware, but sooner may be better with the fate of your people in mind. If you have a need for me in Kremnos, whether for some tradition preceding a marriage or anything else, don't hesitate to send word. Until then, Aglaea and I are preparing everything here.

Unfortunately yours,

Phainon

Mydei turns off the tap. The water ripples, then stills. He flicks his gaze to the last line of the letter.

P.S. Hopefully my courtship hasn't been terribly underwhelming. Aglaea advised me to send romantic poetry, so I've tried my hand. Do tell me if it's to your liking.

Warily, Mydei turns to the second page in the envelope, shifting it in front of the first as he shuffles half out of his clothes to prepare for the bath.

Beautiful maiden or Undying warrior

I have yet to see

With you parted from me

I wait for your return so we can decide

A powerful soldier on the battlefield

Or a delicate bride

I am not one to gloat

But it will not be me again

With your knife at my throat

△

Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,

It pleases me to hear that your people are open to welcoming me and mine. I have released a decree sanctioning migration to Okhema for those who have lost their homes to Nikador and the titankin. Most are resistant at the moment, as mine are a stubborn people, but you may be able to expect an influx of refugees soon.

I approve of the wedding being at the start of the harvest month if that means Castrum Kremnos can be aided sooner. My army has kept the titankin at bay these past weeks, but Nikador themself has yet to show their face, and I anticipate a great deal of destruction when they grow restless. If wedding you sooner can put a stop to that, I'm willing to oblige.

I advise you to stay where you are for the time being. Bloodshed is custom to legitimize a wedding in Castrum Kremnos. Should you show your face, my people will demand you defeat my honor guard as well as any challenger that chooses to step forward to prove that you are worthy of my hand. There will be no celebrations or joyous processions.

I will return soon,

Crown Prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos

P.S. Poetry is not a talent of yours. I ask that you refrain in the future.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> I've been out of town and haven't played 3.1 yet so if anything seems weird with new lore, that's why.

Mydei,

As you've said nothing regarding how I can address you, I'm going to continue like this, even if you've chosen to be stiffly formal in your reply.

Okhema has made preparations for refugees already. With the Black Tide getting worse and worse, we're prepared to provide sanctuary for as many as we possibly can. May Kephale's light shine on anyone who lost their homes to Nikador's insanity.

With the wedding rapidly approaching, I'd like the chance to meet your people as you've met mine. Aglaea and I both worry about the reception of our marriage in Castrum Kremnos if I'm to be completely absent during the duration of our courtship. I'm not against a contest between myself and any challengers if that's what it takes to gain approval. Is there a preferable time for such a thing?

I await your reply,

Phainon

△

Nikador's blade stands above Castrum Kremnos like an executioner's axe. This is Phainon's first thought upon approaching the city on foot. Kremnos is a proud city, with resplendent gold towers and lit braziers lining the long path up to the gates. Behind these walls, Phainon knows there are homes wreathed in darkness and reduced to rubble, but at least from the outside, Castrum Kremnos stands strong.

These, he thinks as he arrives, are angry, fighting people. Each person he passes is solemn-faced and armed to the teeth, and they watch him in his blue and white coat like he doesn't belong here. He knows he looks like an outsider. Everything from his hair to his clothing stands out. Regardless, he stands tall.

"Halt, traveler," says a woman in military dress at the gate. She wears her hair in a braid over her shoulder and wields a spear, which she tips diagonally to block his path. Her eyes—medium green—are cold. "State your name and purpose."

Phainon looks past her at the gate, and then around at the warriors adjusting armor and sharpening weapons. Their eyes land on him in turn. He's heard, in passing, that there have been groups challenging Nikador and their titankin. Men and women turning a disaster into a contest of strength. A chance to become heroes and save their homeland. So far, none have succeeded. He wonders how many lives have been lost. How many have fallen to Strife. How many will yet.

Now, he straightens up and pushes away the discomfort of uncertainty. "I am Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," he introduces himself. A murmur runs through the crowd. He lets silence stretch. He knows little of Castrum Kremnos, but when he thinks of Mydei, he guesses these people are best met with confidence and strength. “I come on account of my betrothal to your crown prince.”

"Prince consort to be," the woman in front says. She studies him, gaze falling to the sun on his throat, then back to his eyes. Finding no fear there, she dips into a small, reluctant bow. "You come out of respect for our rites?"

Bloodshed, as Mydei warned. Phainon knows little of Castrum Kremnos, but they value strength above all. Mydei warned him away, but they'll never accept Phainon if he doesn't meet them halfway. To form this bond, Kremnos needs to accept Phainon just as much as Okhema needs to accept Mydei. It would certainly have helped if Mydei had responded to his letter. He’ll have to ask after him once he enters the city. "I do," Phainon says.

Another ripple sweeps through the crowd. The ice in this woman's gaze eases. Slowly, she nods. "Can you prove to be his equal?" she asks. Medals adorn a cape at her shoulder, crimson and gold, Kremnos' colors. She must rank highly to wear them, to speak to him without care of insult.

Phainon keeps his back straight. "I can," he asserts.

After a moment, she gestures for the gates to be opened. “Very well,” she says, shifting her spear out of his path. “Welcome to Castrum Kremnos.”

△

Instead of being led to the palace for a chance to rest from the journey and speak to his husband to be, Phainon is brought to the very center of the city. A wide clearing is forcibly carved out by a group of soldiers, fringed by crowds and market stalls. The air is warm, and Phainon is expected to fight without repose. A hundred eyes watch as he peels off his coat, bundling it protectively around the courting gift tucked into one of the pockets.

“Will you fight unarmed, or would you prefer to duel with weapons?” The woman from the gates asks. Erynis, she introduces herself, a retired sergeant turned guard and recruitment officer. She prepared an assortment of weaponry. Spears, javelins, xiphos and longswords. Phainon has his greatsword, a dagger at his waist, and his own two hands.

“I will do whatever is custom among your people.”

At this, she laughs. “Custom would be a fight to the death, or near to it,” she says. “But we can not leave you for dead, would-be hero, or we would start a war.”

Phainon holds his ground, and his temper. Respect, he remembers Mydei saying, must be earned here. “Nor will I kill today.”

“‘Valorous death before glorious return…’” She scoffs. “Very well. Unarmed it is. Ptolemy is your first challenger.” She gestures at a tall man with cropped brown hair. His arms are folded across a broad chest, expression impassive, draped in a tan chiton tied with crimson. “Do you accept?”

Phainon removes his dagger and leaves it with his coat. “I do,” he says, shrugging his shoulders to warm them up. He worries, briefly, just what exactly he’s getting himself into.

“I hope you’re as strong as they say you are,” Ptolemy says, considering him as they step up to one another. Around them, the bystanders begin to chant something in the Kremnoan language. A cheer or a battle cry. Their tongue is sharp and clipped, and it sends Phainon’s blood rushing through him. “They call you a perfect vessel with a destiny of deliverance. Is it true?”

His hands flex, ankles rolling in his boots. He tests the ground beneath him, feeling the support of hard, textured stone. It’s hardly a good place for a casual spar, but this, he thinks, is anything but that. He takes a deep breath of the city—catching the scent of blood, indigo, and refuse—and says, “no man can claim to know the future in whole. I do not know my own destiny.”

“I see,” Ptolemy says. “You are flawed, then.”

Phainon smiles and shifts into a fighting stance. “What man is not?”

“This is true,” Ptolemy agrees, and throws a punch.

Phainon ducks under it, slipping smoothly into his combat training. The next he stops with a forearm, ducking in to aim a jab at Ptolemy’s ribs. He’s blocked with ease, so he aims a sharp kick to Ptolemy’s other side, this one connecting with a painful sound. Briefly, they part.

“You’re swifter than I expected,” Ptolemy notes, smoothing a hand over the injured spot before he raises his hands again.

Phainon shoves his hair back and falls into step as they circle each other. “It would be an insult and a lie to say your strength is a surprise.”

Ptolemy chuckles, closing back in. “After I win,” he says. “I will treat you to kykeon.”

“Arrogance gets good men killed,” Phainon warns, and strikes first. He aims for the throat, then swings with his knee when Ptolemy goes to block. The impact earns him a hiss, and then Ptolemy catches his leg and tries to use his momentum to throw him down. Phainon wrenches free and doesn’t waste a second, aiming a kick and grabbing Ptolemy’s wrist to guide him forward when he lunges. He doesn't stumble, just catches himself and elbows

Phainon in the chest. The pain is sharp for a moment, but Phainon doesn't have time to focus on it as Ptolemy aims a hit at his face.

He throws himself to the side, gaining space, finding his gaze sweeping unfamiliar faces in the crowd. They're loud, these spectators. Cheering and taunting and watching him, assessing him. Deciding if he's worth it. Phainon throws his next punches in quick succession, clipping Ptolemy in the jaw, then the clavicle. The impact of flesh rings out. The adrenaline floods him, blood roaring in his ears.

Ptolemy charges, and Phainon doesn't manage to dodge. It only takes moments before he's caught and taken to the ground, and then they're trying to fight each other off. Phainon takes an arm to the throat before he manages to throw Ptolemy off, grunting as they roll. Then, with a carefully timed knee to the stomach, he manages to pin one arm behind Ptolemy's back, wrenching it back until he's forced to surrender.

Next, he fights a man named Georgious, then Herklas, then Leonidas. Phainon starts to tire, and then to ache as he collects hit after hit. First it's his chest, then his ribs, his jaw, his tongue when he bites it taking a punch. Still, Phainon fights each challenger in turn, and when he comes out triumphant for the fourth time, the crowd affords him a cheer.

They don't care who wins, Phainon notices. They only care for the spectacle or the thrill of the fight, but he knows it makes him less of an outsider, into someone they can root for. The way to this city's heart is through its blood. Phainon sits on a stone half wall for a short rest when a hand holds out a chalice of red liquid to him.

"You're bruised terribly," an older man says. He's outfitted in brown and red, as most of them are, built strongly with chestnut and silvering hair. He wears scars like medals and seems to be blind in one eye. He notices the trepidation in Phainon's face as he stares at the cup, because he chuckles as says, "It's pomegranate juice."

"Oh," Phainon says, and accepts it. His jaw protests as he speaks, likely bruised. He'd taken a hard hit from Leonidas, growing sloppy in his fatigue. Now, he's allowed a rest, but the challenges will resume in time. "Thank you." He spares a glance around the crowd and finds, still, nothing.

"You're welcome," the man says. "Where are your servants?"

"I came alone."

He hums, considering this, and then turns to lean on the wall at Phainon's side. "You're like him then. Too independent and impulsive for your own good."

Careful, Phainon studies him. The weather in his face. The slight, tired fondness. He stares into the pomegranate juice. "You know him well, then?"

"Mydeimos?" A chuckle. "Better than most."

"And you are?"

“Krateros,” the man answers. “His teacher. Guardian, perhaps. Or perhaps not; he wouldn’t like me to call it that.” He gestures at the cup expectantly, so Phainon raises it, carefully scenting it before he takes a sip. It’s a bit sour, but mostly sweet, stinging the sore on his tongue. Krateros smiles. “He’ll be livid when he finds out you’re here.”

“I wrote.” Phainon pushes up his sleeves and again searches for strawberry blond hair or a red painted chest. Those colors don’t stand out in this crowd, but even after a careful search, Phainon comes up empty. “Where is he?”

“In the bath,” Krateros answers. “Probably will be for a while.”

Phainon hums, prodding around his jaw. It’s hot, swollen, and sore to the touch.

“You’ll want something cold for that.”

“Yes,” Phainon agrees. “But I still have business here.”

Krateros straightens up and smooths out his clothes. “You’ll be here for a hundred days and nights if you try to take on every challenger that wants you to prove you’ve earned his hand. My advice: fight someone more important.” And then he strolls away, leaving Phainon to lick his wounds. Phainon stares after him, then down at his wobbling reflection in the juice. He sets the chalice aside.

“Wait,” he calls, standing and jogging after Krateros, who halts and turns with something almost like a smile in his expression. “Someone more important,” Phainon says, gaze flicking between his eyes. “His teacher. *You.”*

“You exaggerate my importance,” Krateros says, falsely modest.

“Will you do it?”

“Should I consider that a challenge?”

Phainon takes a breath. “Yes,” he says.

Krateros guffaws. “Then I accept,” he proclaims.

Erynis steps between them. “A challenge has been issued,” she announces to the watching crowd. “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae to Krateros of the Golden Brigade elite.”

Murmurs. This, more than anything so far, has the crowd excited. He looks at Krateros—half a head shorter but no less muscled, carrying himself with the confidence of a long practiced warrior—and feels a flutter of nerves. Still, he stands his ground. Krateros unclips his sash and tosses it, a flash of red, and the crowd cheers. Phainon follows him into the middle of the clearing, and then they start chanting, louder than before, that same Kremnoan battle cry.

“‘Courage, honor, reason, tenacity, sacrifice,’” Krateros translates. “They speak of Nikador’s virtues.”

Lips pursed, Phainon nods. Nikador. Still their god and their idol, even as they descend into madness and turn homes to dust. A hundred voices speak in time as a bead of sweat drips down the back of his neck. This, he thinks, is the one that matters, the one that will secure his place as someone worthy of their crown prince's hand. Phainon takes a deep, deep breath.

"A friendly match, " Krateros says.

"I hope that doesn't mean you'll take it easy on me," Phainon says, shifting on his feet. Slow, they walk a circle together. The crowd backs up a handful of steps, still chanting. The sun beats down, and Phainon's jaw still aches.

"I'm an old man past his prime," Krateros says.

"They seem to think you're one of their best," Phainon tells him, gesturing vaguely.

"They respect me," Krateros agrees, settling into a fighting stance. "But perhaps they're rooting for you as well." Erynis stands between them, lifting a hand for the crowd to quiet. They do, silence stretching, every eye trained to the two of them. "Mydeimos could use a strong partner at his side. They want that from you. Don't assume they're thinking the worst."

"I don't come from here," Phainon points out.

"Kremnos doesn't care for foreigners, true," Krateros concedes, "but strength recognizes strength. Prove your worth and they will sing your praises to the sky."

Castrum Kremnos has a reputation for bloodlust, barbarism, and a lack of care for human life. Krateros speaks of them as if they just want someone to root for. As if the hardness and anger in them comes purely from care. Parents toward their children, friends and lovers toward each other. At the heart of it, perhaps these people just want someone to show them that their fight to survive is worth it after all the pain. Phainon exhales. "If possible," he says, "I will be what these people need."

"Earnest lad," Krateros says, nodding. "Show me what you can do."

The first strike is his, a quick lunge that ends with his' fist in Phainon's side. It's unexpected; Phainon hisses through his teeth as he jumps back and raises his guard. Krateros presses his advantage, one arm swinging into a hook that Phainon blocks with his forearm. They trade hits back and forth, each swapping between offence and defense.

There’s cheering when Krateros lands a hit. More when Phainon does. As the fight stretches, it seems the audience hasn’t taken sides. That, or they’re caught up in the thrill of a good battle.

Phainon slips into Krateros’ space just swift enough to catch him off guard, snatching a wrist in one hand and using the other to push the back of his head down. His knee comes up for a strike just as Krateros uses the momentum to headbutt him in the stomach. They both groan and tumble, rolling as each tries to pin the other down and fails. Krateros gets his wrist free and manages to get a forearm around Phainon’s neck before he’s thrown off. Phainon tries to

wrench Krateros' arms behind his back before he's twisted and forced to let go or be crushed into the stone.

They catch their breath briefly. Phainon wets his lips before he takes another shot, punching and kicking and scrambling in the dust. He takes an elbow to the face that splits his top lip and has his nose unbroken but bleeding, and he's fairly certain his shirt tears, but he fights with everything he has, with everything he knows he owes these people, and at the end of it, he comes out on top, pinning Krateros with his body weight and pulling one arm and shoulder back to immobilize him.

A deep voice speaks from within the crowd. "You have some nerve coming here, Deliverer."

Beneath him, Krateros mutters something in the Kremnoan language. "I yield," he wheezes, so Phainon releases him. They're both covered in dust and sweat, and when Phainon rises, he offers the other man a hand. He takes it, and they turn, not quite chastened, toward where the sea of people parts for a man patterned in red. Blood drips down Phainon's chin and stains his clothing. He's certain he makes quite an image.

"Son of Gorgo," Krateros greets him, lowering his head as he bows deeply. Around them, the circle of Kremnoans bends too.

Phainon wipes his mouth with the back of his hand, likely only making a mess of himself, and says, "I've come to respect the rites of your people."

"You've come to make a fool of yourself," Mydei corrects him, coming closer. He wears his robe open on one side, displaying his marked chest and smooth contours of muscle. "And you, teacher, are no better. I have sanctioned no contests between the people and my betrothed."

The crowd is eerily silent, every face tipped down. The command Mydei holds, even without a formal seat on the throne, is palpable.

"I challenged him," Phainon says, pulling one sleeve down to hold it to his nose. He swallows the blood in his mouth, the metallic taste clinging to his tongue.

Mydei crosses his arms. "I'm sure," he says, eyes narrowing. He lifts a hand toward the crowd and orders, "Disperse."

A moment passes, then two, and then the people reluctantly obey.

"You're bleeding," Mydei says, and turns his back. "Let's go." He leaves without waiting for a response. Phainon curses and tries to wipe the blood on his pants so it wont get on his coat as he gathers it off the floor, hiding his dagger back at his waist and throwing his greatsword onto his back.

"Kephale's light," he pants, jogging to catch up, a fresh line of blood slipping down his chin as he has to remove his hand from his face. "You act like it'll kill you to wait a little."

"I'm not the one gushing blood out the nose, now am I?"

Phainon slows when he comes close enough to catch Mydei by the elbow, which he does with his cleanest hand. *"Wait,* Mydei."

Mydei stops. An amber gaze hands on Phainon's hand—the one with the translucent string, now manifest.

"Are you truly upset?" Phainon asks.

After a moment, Mydei looks back at his eyes. "Why are you here?"

"You never wrote back," Phainon says, licking the blood from his lips just for more to replace it. "I intended to come speak to you, but was swept up in this. Regardless, it doesn't make sense to ignore your traditions, not if anyone here is going to take this— *me* —seriously. I—" Again, he tries to clean up the blood as it dribbles into his mouth, but his sleeve is already soaked.

"Strife," Mydei curses, he makes a deeply unhappy noise in his throat and digs in his pocket. "Would you just—" He pulls out a handkerchief—the third Phainon has had to borrow in the span of a few weeks—and shoves it into Phainon's hand.

It's creamy white and embroidered with the Lance of Fury, and Phainon can only stare for a moment.

"You're getting blood everywhere," Mydei admonishes. His gauntleted hand grips Phainon's wrist, pushing his hand up to his face. "Use it, damn you."

His gauntlet is warm with body heat. Phainon presses the handkerchief to his nose and lets out a laugh. "Thank you," he says, "sorry." As the adrenaline slows down, all of his aches return with a vengeance. His jaw throbs, and he can feel his heartbeat in his nose. His clothes are a terrible mess, and this, the absurdity of it all, has him grinning hard enough for a fresh stab of agony to run through the tear in his lip.

"I can't decide if you're foolishly brave or bravely foolish," Mydei says, and it sounds halfway like a praise and halfway like an insult. He releases Phainon and turns again, storming in the direction of the palace. Eyes follow them the entire way, but no one dares to speak or interrupt them.

"A fool feels no fear," Phainon says, nearly stumbling to catch up on weary legs, "and thus can't show courage."

"That had best not be the beginning of another poem," Mydei says. His expression is as hard as his voice, but there's something about him that gives Phainon the impression that he isn't as gruff as he seems. It makes him laugh again, cut short for the pain.

"No," he says, "certainly not. That's just... something someone I once knew used to say."

Finally, Mydei slows to a reasonable pace. "A fool feels fear," he says, "they just fear the wrong things."

They're about the same height, Phainon notices. Neither has to look up or down to meet the other's eyes. He pulls the handkerchief back to find that the bleeding has stopped. He uses a clean edge and wipes up what he can as they walk. "Maybe," he considers, trying to sniff and finding his nostrils horribly clogged. "So what does that make me?"

"That depends on what you're afraid of."

They pause briefly at the doors of the palace as they open. Mydei steps aside for him to enter first, an odd gesture based on what little Phainon knows about him. But there it is again, the sense that he's not quite what he makes himself out to be. Something a little warmer. The bloodlust of an army but the compassion of a man.

"A lot of things," Phainon says. "Whether or not they're the right ones, I don't know."

Mydei nods and resumes leading the way. "It takes courage to admit fear," he says as they walk down a hallway with high ceilings and warm lighting.

"A compliment?" Phainon asks. "From you?" Mydei gives him a dry look. Phainon laughs, lip stinging. He tongues at the cut and dabs it lightly with the handkerchief, turning the fabric over and eyeing all the bloodstains. "I'll wash this," he says, a bit awkwardly as he tucks it away in his pocket. "The blood should come out."

"Keep it," Mydei tells him, not bothering to look. He stops at the doorway and pulls it open, again stepping aside for Phainon to go first.

"A token of your love?"

Another dry, unimpressed look. "Yes," Mydei says, and follows him in.

This room is something like an infirmary, though it's much smaller and more private than the ones Phainon is used to. This is quiet, with a single padded bench and a counter with a wash basin and boxes of supplies. Phainon sits on the bench, draping his coat over the far edge as Mydei wets a cloth.

“Patching me up, husband-to-be?” Phainon asks as he comes closer, excess water dripping from his fingers as he brandishes the cloth like a weapon. Mydei grimaces as he makes himself still and pliant, the perfect patient, and then the cloth connects with his face, frigid and wet and jarring.

“Do it yourself,” Mydei says disdainfully, turning his back. “I'll get a change of clothes.”

Phainon catches the cloth from where it fell to his lap, eyeing the blood spilled down his front. “Thank you,” he says, the corners of his mouth twitching. Mydei shuts the door behind him.

When he's gone, Phainon lets loose a deep sigh and undoes his shirt, letting it fall to the floor. His eyes fall shut. He breathes, once, twice. Forces himself to straighten up.

There isn't a mirror here that he can see, so he picks a spot and starts cleaning himself up from there. His chest, throat, chin. He's careful as he wipes down his face, attempting again

to breathe through his nose. The clot stays firmly in place, so he blows lightly, then a little stronger, clearing up an airway. He takes three triumphant breaths, and then starts bleeding again.

“Titans above,” he curses, pressing the cloth to his nose. It stops quicker the second time around, for which he’s grateful. Mydei comes back just as he’s cleaning up the last of it, mouth breathing for fear of setting it off again. He tosses a tunic at Phainon, blood red with a deep vee in the front. “Your colors,” Phainon observes.

“You’re in my homeland. My colors are to be expected.”

“I know,” Phainon concedes, pulling it on. “I know, I just don’t look very good in red.” Mydei turns and looks him up and down, gaze holding weight like hands, though he doesn’t speak. He lingers somewhere around Phainon’s throat and then turns, wetting a fresh cloth before he steps forward.

“You missed a spot.”

Phainon holds a hand out. “Where?” he asks. “I’ll get it.”

Mydei says nothing, just sighs and steps closer. He reaches for Phainon’s neck, but his hand is stopped along the way by Phainon’s around his wrist. Surprise flashes briefly in his expression, but he doesn’t pull away.

“What are you doing?” Phainon asks, voice low. His pulse jumps. He’s still in fighting mode, though he doesn’t need to be.

“Helping,” Mydei says, drawing back. “Unless you’d rather I didn’t.”

Phainon clears his throat, embarrassed, letting go. “It’s here, then?” he asks, tipping his head back. Mydei looks at him for a moment before he accepts this for the permission that it is. With a kind of care that doesn’t seem common from him, he slips one armored finger beneath the choker around Phainon’s neck.

“Here,” he says, keeping the sharp parts of his gauntlet from touching skin. With his other hand, he wipes blood from the space beneath the leather, then the choker itself. He’s exceedingly careful, and when Phainon swallows, his adam's apple brushes armored fingers. It tickles, and he’s torn between a nervous laugh and a full body shudder.

“Why did you come, Deliverer?” Mydei asks, wiping a final spot above Phainon’s clavicle before he steps back. The damp spots left by the cloth chill in the air, and Phainon fights the urge to rub at them.

“I already told you,” he says. “I didn’t mean to get caught up in that.”

Mydei looks unimpressed. “And yet.”

Phainon sighs. “I’ll admit, I wanted to prove my worth to them,” he starts. “If we’re to be wed, it should be by the standards of both our nations, not just mine.”

“There’s no glory to be found in an accolade only obtainable through bloodshed,” Mydei tells him. “I am not a bride to be won. The only person you must prove your worth to is me.”

“But your traditions—”

“Will be honored,” Mydei interrupts him. “The people are overeager. Gorgo fought Eurypon and no one else. Hold your own against me, and that will be enough.” His expression offers little, but Phainon gets the sense that Mydei means this very deeply. Compassion, more than bloodlust. Curious.

“Why didn’t you write back?” Phainon asks.

“I’ve been on the front lines,” Mydei says, raising an eyebrow. “You’d have received a reply sooner or later, if you’d been patient enough to wait.”

“Has my coming here upset you?”

“No,” Mydei says, but he collects the rags and turns toward the counter so Phainon can’t see his face.

“And yet,” Phainon echoes. The silence stretches between them. “Were you…” He hesitates. “...Worried?”

“About the man who turned a knife on me in the bath?” Mydei scoffs. “Hardly. It’s simply…” More silence. Mydei’s shoulders tense before he sets himself to digging through a container of medicines.

“Simply…?” Phainon prompts. After a moment, he stands, coming to Mydei’s side. All he catches is the hint of a red ear before a jar of ointment is shoved into his chest. He startles, catching it.

“Humiliating,” Mydei answers, turning on him. “You embarrass me in front of my people, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

He stares. The red in Mydei’s face. The scowl. The way his eyes flick from one place to another but don’t ever meet Phainon’s. He’s…

“Oh,” Phainon says. “I’m sorry.” A laugh startles out of him. “Seriously, I—”

“Cease,” Mydei orders, scowling harder. Phainon does not. Mydei grits his teeth and gestures at the jar in Phainon’s hand. “Put that on your lip. Or don’t. I’m leaving.”

“Wait!” Phainon laughs. He presses his lips together to stop it, but a smile still creeps around the edges, even through the pain. “Wait,” he says again. “I’m sorry, I really am.”

“Somehow I doubt that.”

Finally, Phainon is able to smooth his face into something sincere. “I mean it,” he promises, turning to face Mydei fully. “I’m sorry.”

“Fine,” Mydei says.

“Fine,” Phainon echoes. They look at each other, Mydei still frowning, and there’s a sudden knot in Phainon’s stomach. This is unprecedented between them. He’s afraid he’s made a horrible mess of things. Swallowing, Phainon admits, “I fear that you must dislike me.”

A pause.

“Then I think you’re a fool,” Mydei answers.

“I—” Phainon pauses. “Oh.”

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> throwing canon to the wind from here on out. also,,, sorry for breaking the exactly 5k streak :(

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A servant gets guest quarters ready for Phainon. He cleans up alright, despite the bruise blooming on his jaw and the cut on his lip. Red, as he told Mydei, does not look good on him, clashing with the color of his hair and his eyes. But he tucks the red shirt into his trousers, open part way down his chest and outlining the width of his shoulders, and it doesn't look terrible on him either. Mydei notes this but takes care not to linger on the thought.

Later, when the quarters are ready, Mydei offers to walk Phainon, though he wants to do anything but that. He could have a servant do it, but a part of him cringes at the thought of Phainon interacting with his people more than he has. Irrational, he knows. Phainon will have to speak to many Kremnoans during his stay, more once they're married, but right now Mydei just wants him tucked away to deal with later.

"Ever the gentleman," Phainon says, folding his coat over his arm. Mydei scoffs and opens the door, holding it open for Phainon to walk through first. As Phainon passes him, he raises a brow, pointed, and Mydei realizes what he's done. Heat rises to his face. He clears his throat and starts leading the way.

The palace has wide hallways and tall ceilings, lit by fire and smelling faintly metallic. It isn't beautiful in the way Okhema is, isn't warm and welcoming. Mydei wonders what Phainon must make of it. He doesn't comment much, not on the place itself, not on the people, not on anything at all. From someone as seemingly open as Phainon, it makes Mydei itch. They walk in silence uncharacteristic for them, and things keep replaying in Mydei's head.

Oh, in Phainon's voice. Over and over. The look on his face. Mydei isn't sure if he got it, and he doesn't know if he wants him to. The sight of him, holding his own against Krateros, brow furrowed, blood smeared across his face. For a too long moment, he's imprinted on the backs of Mydei's eyelids.

"You'll want to see the state of the city," Mydei notes.

"Yes," Phainon says. "Whenever it’s convenient. The battlefield too."

"Tomorrow," Mydei says, and leaves it at that. They pause at the door to the housing wing of the palace, and this time, Mydei goes first. Behind him, Phainon huffs a laugh.

So when will we have that spar?" he asks, catching up. Their shoulders brush, fabric against skin. Goose flesh prickles up Mydei's arm. "Sounds like tomorrow will be too busy."

His jaw is purple and he can hardly smile for the way his lip is cut. Mydei shoots him a look. "How many of my men did you just fight?" he asks. "And you're already eager for another spar?"

“Against you?" Phainon grins, blood welling on his mouth before he licks it away. "Yes."

"It's the adrenaline talking," Mydei tells him, coming to a stop at the prepared guest room. He pushes the door open and stands aside for Phainon to enter. "Your body isn't immortal; you'll be aching soon enough."

"I heal fast," Phainon says, peeking inside. He surveys the room: the seating area, the wide window along one wall, the bed made with cream colored sheets and red blankets. He takes a breath, smelling the faint odor of indigo that lingers everywhere in Castrum Kremnos, and turns back to Mydei. “Besides, if a warrior can’t fight sore, perhaps he shouldn’t be on the battlefield at all.”

“A fool,” Mydei mutters. Phainon studies him.

“I’m not a hundred percent sure what you meant by it when you said that earlier,” he says, soft and contemplating, and this strange, uncomfortable jolt thrills through Mydei. Silence stretches, then he steps back, out of the entryway so the door is free to shut between them. For now, Phainon holds it in place.

“It’s nothing to concern yourself with,” Mydei says. “Goodnight, Deliverer.”

△

The next day, Phainon’s bruise has worsened significantly in color. Still, he’s in bright spirits. The have breakfast, during which Phainon teases Mydei unnecessarily for taking milk in his pomegranate juice, and then Mydei takes him to the highest part of one of the palace towers, a room with broad windows that overlook the entire city.

“We can walk the streets,” Mydei says, standing next to Phainon in front of the glass. “But this is the best place to see it all.”

“Titans above,” Phainon breathes. He’s looking, most certainly, at the places shrouded in eternal night, at the way the destruction is visible at the edges of the city even from so far away.

“We’ve lost six percent of the city,” Mydei says, voice a knife’s edge, “Projected to become seven percent in the next week. The attacks are worsening in size and frequency. The people are angry and scared, and I struggle to console them.”

For a long moment, Phainon is silent, just staring at the city. The untouched sections are grand and laudable—the indigo quarries and the main streets, the markets and gilded

buildings. This is a city worthy of pride, and there is something in Mydei that trembles like a child at the thought that he might be the thing that lets it fall to ruin.

“Mydei,” Phainon finally says. He turns, solemn-faced, and asks, “How did King Eurypon die?”

The whisper of silence. “He had gone mad,” Mydei answers. There is a saying among his people. *The kingslayer be king.* “I ended his life with my own hand.” Prophecy come true. Patricide succeeding patricide. A mother’s voice: *he will be the one to end the cycle.* Blood on his hands. A spear in a concave chest. The feeling of failure, even after a necessary job done right. *The son of Gorgo will be crowned in blood.*

Slowly, Phainon nods. He doesn’t ask questions, whether out of respect or horror, Mydei doesn’t know. “I’ll see the battlefield now,” is all he says, “if you’d be so kind as to take me.”

“Very well,” Mydei says, trying to shake the curdling feeling that sticks in his chest.

△

Along the way, Mydei shows Phainon the markets, the quarries, the neighborhoods. He buys candied pomegranate to eat as they walk. They get gawked at, more than a little bit, but it seems that both of them are adept at not caring about this sort of thing. Slowly, the streets grow less and less populated, the sky darker and darker. There’s something strangely cold about these parts of Castrum Kremnos. Eerily silent, but for the sounds of their footsteps.

“You’ll hear Nikador’s war cries the further in you go,” Mydei says. “It’s best we steer clear to avoid getting caught in their bloodlust.”

“They fight?”

“No,” Mydei answers, stepping over a cracked, fallen pillar. “But their voice makes it difficult to control oneself.” He stops, the remains of a temple toppled before him. In front of him, there’s a distinct line in the dust where the world goes from light to dark. “Here,” he says, grabbing Phainon by the elbow. Together, they take a handful of steps forward, crossing into the darkness. “Listen.”

Faintly, a chant rings in his ears. Even so quietly, it stirs something in his blood. A desire for action, and itch to fight. This feeling—this thrill—has been both a help to him and a horror in battles these last several weeks. It’s so easy to tear things limb from limb under its influence. It makes him worry that there could come a point when killing titankin isn't enough.

“This feeling,” Phainon breathes.

“Dangerous,” Mydei tells him. “The soldiers lose themselves. At times, I nearly do too.” Wasting no time, they draw back into the light, Nikador’s voice fading out. Mydei takes a breath to settle his spirit.

“Do they fight each other?”

“Not yet,” Mydei answers. “I hope it never comes to that.”

△

The rest of the day is spent with diplomatic blather. Mydei's councilmen, joined by Krateros, sweep the two of them up for a discussion. A clear cut outline of Okhema's plans to aid them, details on the wedding, and an overly thorough briefing on, well, everything about Castrum Kremnos' situation later, Mydei is finally free to retire for the night, exhausted in this heavy, bone deep kind of way.

He's stopped caring so much what Phainon does. He's free to embarrass himself as much as he likes, considering he's already, unfortunately, won a good portion of Kremnos over. Mydei may have to face some humiliation upon becoming his spouse, but he's decided enduring that is preferable to policing his every move. So as soon as he finds an opening, he stands and unceremoniously leaves the meeting room. No one so much as calls after him, until, moments later, the sound of footsteps chases him down the hall.

"You're just leaving?" Phainon asks, slowing to a walk at his side. He walks too closely, too familiarly, as he always does. Mydei can almost taste the olive oil and pine resin scent of him. It must cling to his coat, because he'd smelled of nothing but sweat when he'd been dressed in Kremnos' reds the day before.

"We had nothing left to discuss," Mydei says tersely. It makes Phainon frown, a small, petulant thing.

"And you didn't even consider walking your dear husband-to-be to his quarters?"

This earns him an eyebrow raise. "Is your sense of direction so terrible that you need me to?"

Phainon huffs, partway in jest. "It wouldn't kill you to be kinder," he points out.

"There is no word for kindness in the Kremnoan language."

"Funny," Phainon says, letting their shoulders brush before Mydei takes a pointed step to the left. "You know what they say about your people?" Phainon continues. "That you have no word for love in your language either, but that can hardly be true." Mydei remains silent. They pause at a doorway, and as they wait for it to open, Phainon turns to him. "Look, would you come with me? I won't take more than a minute or two of your time."

Mydei narrows his eyes. "What need do you have of it?"

"Have I upset you?" Phainon asks, very earnestly, and it's— Mydei grits his teeth, nauseous at the thought of making him worry he's done something wrong. Moreso, at the thought of offering a reassuring word.

"Fine," he says, and waits—before he realizes what he's doing—for Phainon to pass through the doorway first. "Your chambers are this way," he adds, catching up and gesturing to the left.

Phainon chuckles lightly. "Yes, I know," he says. "I can find my way perfectly well; I just… have something for you that I forgot yesterday, and I thought now would be a good time.

Unless you'd really rather retire already. I won't blame you if you do."

"Let's get this over with," is all Mydei offers as a reply.

"Don't sound too excited now," Phainon laughs.

When they reach his door, Phainon pushes it open and pauses. "Would you like to come in?" he offers. There's a table and chairs, as well as a balcony looking out at the city, but he doesn't have a proper sitting chamber, only the one room and attached bath. Mydei wasn't raised in the court but even he knows better than to accept.

"That wouldn't be appropriate," he says, and holds his ground in the hallway. He watches Phainon's lip quirk, the horrible, soft thing it does to his face before he steps the rest of the way inside and lets the door shut briefly between them.

He's only gone for a matter of moments before he returns, stepping back into the hallway with something wrapped in shiny blue cloth and tied with gold thread. It's small, about the length of his palm and half as wide, and he holds it out with both hands. "This is for you," he says, smoothing a fold in the fabric.

"Another courting gift," Mydei observes, though he'd figured it couldn't be anything else when Phainon said he had something for him. Something complicated twists in his stomach —discomfort at this or the obligation to give something back. He reaches out and accepts the bundle, loosening the strings with an armored finger. "You'll have to wait as I prepare something suitable to give back."

"What?" Phainon blinks. "Oh, no, you don't have to. It's— Gifts are Okheman tradition, I don't expect you to participate. Court me the Kremnoan way."

"I hardly think Lady Aglaea and the Council of Elders would take kindly to me dueling half your city," Mydei says dryly. The knot comes undone, so he pulls the strings free. Phainon laughs, a little awkwardly, folding his arms and watching as Mydei unwraps the gift.

Inside the silky fabric is a comb, ivory carved in the shape of the Lance of Fury, neatly and expertly done. It's a beautiful gift, expensive too, and there's an odd sensation that goes from Mydei's spine to the tips of his fingers as he lays eyes on it, because this gift, though coming from an Okheman, is deeply Kremnoan.

Phainon watches as he turns it over. The detailing is fine and delicate, identical on both sides. "I had it made by one of the best carvers in Okhema," Phainon says. "Hopefully it isn't— Well, considering the situation, maybe the Lance of Fury was a bit— And I'm sure you already have a comb, but—"

"Sometimes I wonder," Mydei interrupts him, tracing each even prong, "whether you're clueless about Kremnoan tradition, or if you know more than you let on."

"Clueless," Phainon answers, embarrassingly breathy. "I attempted to research, but there are very few translations from the Kremnoan language into the common one, and Ohkema's

histories are biased against your people. It's... well. As I mentioned earlier, they say there isn't even a word for love in your language, which can hardly be true, you're people aren't—"

"It is," Mydei says. At Phainon's blank expression, he adds, "True. We don't have a word for love. Our courting rituals are based on proving strength more than affection."

"Oh," Phainon says. He backs himself into the door, leaning against it, seeming to sense a conversation. So much for only taking a minute or two of Mydei's time. Firelight from the sconces on the walls dances on his face, and the ceiling is far too tall for just the two of them. "I hope... a comb doesn't signify anything offensive, does it?"

Laughable, the earnest concern on his face. "Offensive, no," Mydei answers. A smile pulls at his mouth, despite the exhaustion of the day and the ache beginning to pound at his temples. "Just terribly presumptuous."

Phainon cocks his head, looking no less concerned. "Pardon?" he says. "Presumptuous?"

"You'll notice that many of my best officers have long hair," Mydei says. Slowly, Phainon nods. "It's a hindrance in a fight, so only the best warriors are allowed to wear long hair to battle. To a Kremnoan, hair is a status symbol and very personal. Only close family and partners are allowed to touch it, and traditionally, in gifting a comb, you ask for permission."

He sees Phainon's attention turn toward his hair, the reddened ends of it, the braid behind his right ear. He brings a hand to his mouth and looks, somewhat sheepish, at the comb still in Mydei's hands. It's a beautiful thing, really. The closest he could possibly come to a traditional Kremnoan courting gift, and yet he stumbled upon it entirely by accident. That titans-damned string on Mydei's finger thrums with warmth.

"That's…" He watches Phainon fumble for the right words. "That wasn't my intention," he says, "I apologize if I've made you uncomfortable. I should have gone more in depth in my research."

"Hardly," Mydei says. "I know just as little of Okhema's traditions. Even less of… Aedes Elysiae's."

"Then you're not offended?"

"No," Mydei assures him, and watches as something almost like a smile drift onto his face.

"Then I must say that that's a terribly romantic tradition," Phainon says, smiling fully into his fist as he watches Mydei handle the comb delicately, turning it over once more before he rewraps it in the blue cloth to protect it until he finds a suitable place for it.

"I remind you we have no word for romance," Mydei corrects him.

"And yet," Phainon says, lowering his hand and pushing himself away from the door to stand up straight. "Is there anything else I should know about your traditions before we wed?"

Mydei purses his lips into a thin line. They will have an Okheman wedding, he knows. Something with a grand ceremony and feasts and dancing. Kremnoan weddings come with

little fanfare, but, perhaps…

He swallows, this odd nervousness filling his belly. Another thing he doesn't have a Kremnoan word for. The warmth around his finger threatens to distract him. He clears his throat. "You'll have to learn to braid, if you don't know how already," he says.

Phainon's eyes are ice blue but horribly warm as his expression changes. "Braid?"

"Yes." Mydei watches the shadows the sconces paint on the walls rather than look at him. "It's a tradition," he says, flicking the braid behind his ear. There's an odd inhale. He glances at Phainon, finding him looking mildly constipated. Mydei frowns. "What?"

"Nothing," Phainon says weirdly. "Nothing at all." He swallows. "I'll learn to braid before the wedding."

"...Very well." Mydei pockets the wrapped comb and crosses his arms. Stiffly, "Thank you for the gift. I will… take my leave."

"Of course," Phainon says, exhaling. "Then… Goodnight, Mydei."

"Goodnight," Mydei echoes. He turns and takes a handful of steps before something possesses him to pause. When he does, he catches Phainon with his eyes squeezed shut and a palm to his forehead in shame. Curiously, it makes the corners of his mouth tick up.

Chapter End Notes

I'm a bit on the fence about how slow/quick burn I want this to be, as well as how explicit... if you have a compelling argument for any side, you're welcome to convince me

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> I wrote some of this in my notes app on my work computer, then had to take pictures and paste the text from those into the doc... sometimes it converts weird and adds accents on vowels or changes Mydei to Mydej so if you see any strange typos I didn't manage to catch... sorry... pls don't tell my boss I was slacking...
>
> note the rating change (no I did not write That Scene at work)

It's no surprise that Castrum Kremnos has a proper arena. It's a massive, circular thing, with terraced seating for an audience thousands strong. The entire thing is paved in stone, railings along the steps, the ground worn and dusty. Grand braziers are lit in a half circle around the seating, and Phainon stands at the bottom, watching the seats fill up with so many people it feels like they blot out the sun. He smells dirt and sweat, hears the chorus of hundreds of voices, and feels, for the first real time, nauseous with anticipation for a fight.

To have something to do with himself, he goes through a thorough warm up. Static and dynamic stretches, sword forms. He shrugs out of his coat when he gets too hot. A deep breath, and the din quiets. On the other side of the arena, Mydei steps out, his strides long and purposeful. He stops in the center, all these eyes on him but his attention on no one but Phainon. "Are you ready, Deliverer?" he asks, a gust whipping the fabric of his robe around his armored legs. Dust stirs at his feet.

Phainon steps up, his sword steady and solid in his hands. A breath in, then out. "I've been ready for weeks, Your Highness," he says, standing tall, forcing himself to smile.

"Kremnos!" Mydei raises his voice, strong and commanding. His next words are in the Kremnoan language, clipped and rough on his tongue as he turns in a slow circle to address each side of the audience in turn. Quieter, turning to Phainon, he translates, "You witness a contest," he says, "between myself and a would be suitor."

"Would be," Phainon laughs, "as if this isn't mostly your doing."

Mydei's eyes narrow as he raises his voice again, addressing the crowd but holding Phainon’s gaze. "He hawks himself as one of Okhema's greatest warriors," he continues, "and has come to prove his might."

A chant or a cheer resounds from the crowd. Five words, spoken in time, each punctuated with a hard stomp on the stone. Courage, honor, reason, tenacity, sacrifice. Nikador's virtues. The silence echoes when they finish. Phainon gets chills.

"No pressure," he mutters to himself. Mydei smiles a terrible, feral smile. He delivers a final line in Kremnoan, raising his fist, and there's another cheer. When he lowers it, all goes silent, hundreds of eyes trained to them, hundreds of breaths held. No more than a handful of moments pass, and then Mydei lunges at him. He's swift, unarmed but for his gauntlets, but every bit of him is filled with lethal power. Phainon blocks him with the flat of his sword, the force making him lose ground. He presses back, side-stepping to Mydei's flank and shifting his grip on the hilt of his sword to swing it where he sees an opening—a flash of rib, a red mark that serves as a target. He feels more than he sees the way Mydei shoves the blade away with his forearm, growling as he aims another blow, uncaring of the way he's lacerated himself with Phainon's blade, golden blood crystallizing in an instant, the wound healed. Phainon skips back.

"Well that," he says, switching back into a standard grip, falling into stance, "is rather unfair, isn't it?"

Mydei doesn't bother to respond, advancing again, twisting around the next swing of Phainon's sword, knee lifting, trying to land a kick to Phainon's open side before he shifts to avoid it. Somehow, the move walks him straight into Mydei's opposite fist, which collides with the space between his chest and armpit. His sword swings, catching Mydei in the side, cutting flesh with frightening ease before it crystallizes and gets stuck. Wrenching it out earns him a grunt, and they both stumble back, Mydei running a hand over the rapidly healing wound, Phainon caught somewhere between awe and horror.

He doesn't cut like that during a spar, not ever, but Mydei will push himself into Phainon's blade if it means gaining the upper hand. He's reckless, entirely unconcerned with injury.

"Doesn't it hurt?" Phainon asks, hands sweating on his sword.

There's no answer. Mydei ducks back into his space, throwing a punch that Phainon narrowly dodges, bringing his sword up, only for Mydei to catch it, letting the tip tear into the inside of his elbow as he uses his momentum to ram his knee into Phainon's side. It connects, sure to bruise, Phainon hissing through his teeth, distracted by the gold of blood and the red of crystal. It's... he loves the thrill of a fight, the sweat, the adrenaline, the physicality of it, but this does nothing but scare him. He gets the sense that Mydei would let Phainon run him through a hundred times, live that agony over and over, and not give it a second thought if it means winning.

Phainon grapples for the space to breathe, spinning his blade to hit Mydei in the chest with the pommel, stepping on his foot, if only to make him back up a step. Then Phainon drops his sword, shifting into a hand-to-hand stance instead. Mydei follows the motion with his eyes, skin sealing back up, unscarred and intact, and says, "Are you going to pick that back up?"

"No," Phainon answers, going so far as to kick it out of the way. "I don't particularly enjoy stabbing you."

"My flesh is immortal," Mydei reminds him.

"Yes," Phainon agrees, "but I'm not convinced you don't feel pain."

He watches Mydei's eyes narrow, the corners of his mouth tipping down. And then his fist is directed straight for Phainon's face, fast enough that he barely sees it, barely manages to slip away from it. A breeze brushes his cheek, brought by the force of Mydei's hand. His eyes go wide, and it's only by pure reflex that he manages to block Mydei's next blow with his wrist, then the three that come after that in quick succession. Next is a kick, but he manages to catch Mydei by the leg and unbalance him, landing a hit to his gut, another to his cheek. And then Mydei is grabbing him around the waist and butting hard into his already bruised jaw. Together, they topple, Phainon biting his tongue, pain in his entire face as they grapple.

They roll in the dirt, a tangle of limbs, each struggling to gain the upper hand. Phainon claws Mydei in the face rather than be pinned, accidentally shoving a finger up a nostril before turning them over, scraping his knees, pulling hair before he's elbowed in the throat and jabbed in the ribs where it already hurts.

The pain nearly blinds him. He coughs up spit and blood from his bitten tongue, vision blurry as he's rolled over again, feeling the dig of stone against his back, grit under his palms, ears roaring. Mydei tries to punch him straight in the face, but by some miracle, he avoids it. His senses struggle to return to him, but as they do, he bucks wildly, flinging a handful of dirt into Mydei's face, shoving his foot into Mydei's stomach, giving him the leverage to shove him off and maneuver him into a chokehold. He gets to bask in having the upper hand for no longer than ten seconds before he's thrown—with no small amount of strength—over Mydei's shoulder.

It ends like this: Phainon on his back, Mydei astride him. He hits his head on the way down, stunning and dizzying him, knocking the breath from his lungs and leaving spots dancing in his vision. Everything aches, from his bruised jaw to his beaten sides to his forearms where they'd caught a few too many blows. The blood roars in his ears, and blurring in and out of focus, there's Mydei, one hand pinning Phainon's wrists to his chest with enough force to make it hard to breathe, the other resting with one armored finger in the bowl of Phainon's throat.

"Yield," he orders, because the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos does not ask nicely for anything. His weight pins Phainon firmly to the ground, knees spread at either of his sides. It hurts. Titans above, it hurts. Body heat comes with the pressure along Phainon's hips. For a moment, Mydei comes into focus, that copper-tipped braid of his hanging between them as he bows over Phainon, the rest of his hair mussed, robe threatening to slip off his other shoulder if not for the pauldron keeping it in place. His chest heaves, he's covered in sweat, grit sticking to his clothes and his skin, and he's *grinning.*

Heat, horrible heat makes its way south.

Phainon shuts his eyes, vision imprinted with red and gold, still dancing with black. Pulse pounding in the veins of his exposed throat, he parts his lips. "Titans," is what comes out, hoarse and breathy and entirely inappropriate for an arena with the entirety of Castrum Kremnos watching. He swallows, Adam's apple bobbing, feeling the tip of one of Mydei's fingers slip under his choker, pulling it tighter.

Phainon tries to catch his breath, blinking the last of the spots from his vision to find Mydei still there, impossibly solid and impossibly strong, enough to match him blow for blow, to

beat him, by even the tiniest margin. Scant few have pushed Phainon even half this hard. They'll need a rematch, he decides then and there, because he'd pushed Mydei too, and that grin holds the accomplishment of a battle hard fought. They're evenly matched, Phainon thinks. Perfectly, wonderfully matched, and next time the victor will be him.

"Kephale above," he tries again, breathy, still a little dazed, "you're beautiful."

"Yield," Mydei only repeats, finger digging right into Phainon's pulse point. His gaze holds steady, eyes narrow, that smile smoothing out. So much fight tucked into one man. Phainon is helpless, lit like a match.

Loud, so the rest of the world, forgotten outside this tiny bubble of just the two of them, can hear, he shuts his eyes again in surrender and says, "I yield."

The arena erupts with cheers.

△

The door to Phainon's guest room is sharp in places where Mydei has him against it. A ridge between his shoulder blades, another at the small of his back. The palm of one hand pushes into it to steady himself as they're pressed chest to chest, hip to hip, a mouth on his throat, teeth sharp as a blade, tongue between the straps of his choker, tracing the sun there.

There's one hand curled in Phainon's hair, another on the outside of his hip. Mydei's touch—his mouth—works anything but softly, and he is impossibly solid, like he had been, impossibly warm. Phainon has fingers splayed on his ribs—taut, molten skin, not a hint of softness, still covered in grit—and loses each thought as it comes, strings in the wind. "This," he pants, even as he lets his head be wrenched back, neck bared, "is a catastrophically bad idea."

The smear of lips along the place where his neck and shoulder meet. The prick of a tooth. Mydei pauses, the sensation of his breath sending sparks up Phainon's spine. "Second thoughts, Deliverer?" he asks, close enough that Phainon can feel it. The heat of him, the realness. He's rigid between them, against the inside of Phainon's hip. One armored thigh sits between Phainon's, the promise of pressure, the question of it.

"I just…" The end or beginning of a red marking beneath his fingertips. It's perfect and surreal and entirely inappropriate. He's too hot in his coat, still sweat soaked and covered in dirt from their spar. He presses himself into the hard metal of Mydei's thigh and finds this frighteningly reckless. An exhalation, a sensation like pleasure-pain, the crack of his head against the door and the smooth, forge-hot flesh beneath his palm. "...Worry that this won't end well."

Mydei presses his thigh back into Phainon, grinding himself against the inside of Phainon's hip, tangling his hair. "What does it matter?" he asks, his voice a little bit rough, deep in a way that does wretched things to Phainon's wavering will. "We're to be wed regardless."

"Yes," Phainon says, breathless, and through it all, something anxious still bubbles up in his chest. *Too much,* he thinks. They'll make a mess of things, and drag Mydei's people with

them. “But this is… abrupt, isn’t it?” It’s good but it’s too much, too fast. Phainon hadn’t considered Mydei this way until that last moment during their spar. He doesn’t love him, doesn’t—

Mydei’s hum vibrates right into skin, and then he takes a deep breath, breathing *Phainon* in, or just—breathing. And then his hand slips out of Phainon’s hair and fixes the open collar of his coat. Briefly, he rocks forward, pressing them together, chasing Phainon’s thoughts away like butterflies, giving him that same dazed, white-out feeling from when he’d hit the floor in the arena. The hand on Phainon’s hip slides up his waist, side, chest, and then there’s a firm hand on his sternum, pinning him in place as Mydei steps back, away, leaving nothing but a flood of cold air in his wake.

“You’ll say yes or we won’t do this at all,” he says, and Phainon can do nothing but stare at his spread fingers, the red of his mouth, the heaviness of his eyes. He can smell the sweat, the want, and a part of him regrets terribly, wants him back, but he’s hyped up on the adrenaline of a good fight, and for once he knows better than his impulses.

“That’s…” Phainon wets his lips and tries to forget the feeling, the heat, the insistent throb between his legs. “Yes, that’s… A good policy.”

Mydei huffs a laugh, breath lifting the longer hair in his face, lips quirking up. “Yes,” he agrees, and pushes off Phainon’s chest to stand up straight, then brushes him out of the way of the door. “Goodnight, Phainon.” And then he’s gone, and his voice is echoing in Phainon’s ears. *Phainon, Phainon, Phainon,* over and over.

△

Aglaea will smell it on him. The way his thoughts race. The part guilt part incredulity part *Phainon, Phainon, Phainon* thrumming through him like blood. The memory of a body against his own. A mouth. An armored thigh.

Phainon arrives in Okhema an utter mess.

“You reek of bloodshed,” Aglaea tells him. She circles him when he comes to report to her, taking her time, her threads vibrating in the air. Their resonance is frightening. Phainon is much too high strung.

“Bruises, all over. Just what exactly did you do during your visitation in Castrum Kremnos?”

Bruises. Can she see the one on his neck? It’s a tiny thing, mixed in with the one on his face and his black and blue ribs. Barely noticeable at all, really, and Phainon heals fast. Two days and it’ll be nothing more than a whisper. He can feel the sweat drip down his back.

“I was proving my worth to the people,” he answers.

“By fighting them?” Aglaea scoffs. “What folly.” Her strings silence. “Rest, Phainon, you can report to me later.

“I…” His body aches. His mind is still racing. His head bows. “Very well.”

So he rests. A long soak in the Hero's bath, a full meal. He rubs ointment on his bruises and changes into fresh clothes, sending his old ones to be laundered. By the time he's dressed and sated, the sky is dark. His sleep is anything but dreamless. In the morning, he pens a letter.

Mydei,

I'm to be fitted for my wedding robes tomorrow. They're going to be red, did you know? Red is a wedding color in Okhema. I thought you might find that funny. Red like the blood of mortals or the symbol of strength for your people. Here it represents transition and the warding of evil. As you've seen, red does not look good on me. Please make due with this ugly bride.

As I left for Okhema from your city, there was a man that tried to speak with me. I don't speak the Kremnoan language, and he knew little of the common one, but he called me "king" and tried to gift me a garnet set in a gold ring. I wonder if this means your people have accepted me. I hope mine will welcome you with arms just as open.

There's a bruise on my neck. Did you leave it intentionally? I don't like that you've succeeded in making me think of you. I—

He stops there and sighs, dropping his pen, rubbing his temple. With his other hand, he crumples the letter up.

Later, he gives Aglaea the full report he owes her. He tells her of his reception, the state of the city, Nikador's war cries on the battlefield. He tells her about the fighting, the arena, battling Mydei. She listens intently, stopping him now and then to ask questions, nodding and bringing a hand to her mouth in thought.

Finally, she says, "And when will Mydeimos return?"

"Two weeks from now," Phainon answers.

△

"Lady Tribios, would you teach me to braid?"

Bright eyes look back. "Trianne does ours. Do you want to learn?"

"Yes, please."

His fingers are clumsy. He practices with lengths of rope that remind him of fishing nets and twined flower stems. Later, he tries on a child's silken hair. She laughs when it comes out uneven and permits him to try again and again until the plait is neat and smooth.

△

Three weeks until the wedding, celebrations in Okhema begin. Banners of white and gold are strung through the city, fresh flowers tied to every post. There are preparations for feasts and festivals and the formal ceremony once Mydei arrives. Phainon is congratulated in the streets.

He catches whispers about the beauty he's to be wed to, and feels sick with laughter and something like guilt.

He knows these people don't know Mydei. If they did, they'd find him beautiful in a way poets don't write about and people don't brag about on the streets. His beauty is in his strength, his will, his impossible compassion. These people imagine him as beautiful in the way thin stemmed flowers are beautiful, but he isn't, not at all. They'll be surprised by the hardness of his gaze and the downturn of his mouth. Phainon looks forward to it.

He pens another letter, and this time he sends it.

Mydei,

Did you never speak to any of my people during your stay in Okhema? The rumors get worse and worse in your absence. I heard a group of women calling you "fair-skinned and delicate of face" when out today. We'll need a rematch when you return, if only so I can see the expressions of shock on their faces when presented with the truth of your immortal body.

We've begun to mobilize forces for the reclamation of Nikador's coreflame already. Many of the Chrysos Heirs are eager for a chance to prove themselves and continue the flame chase. Morale is high, and with their might combined with that of your soldiers, I'm optimistic of the outcome.

Regarding the wedding, the city has been decorated in anticipation of your return. Be prepared for dramatics when you arrive; your walk to Marmoreal Palace will be something, to put it plainly. Dress nicely and prepare to be gawked at. Later, there will be three days of celebrations surrounding the wedding. The day before, day of, and day after. Do you dance? Expect dancing.

Your would-be suitor, one of Okhema's finest warriors,

Phainon

P.S. Aglaea would like me to remind you that your wedding robes need to be altered.

P.P.S. Another poem, because I know how much you loved the last one.

If poor sportsmanship is an ailment then I am well

Bruises will heal, time will tell

But defeat slightly injures my pride

Strong soldier, my delicate bride

This travesty nothing can soothe

I'm left with something to prove

That clash of fists was just the prequel

Mydeimos, I swear, I am your equal

△

Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,

During my initial visit I was careful to avoid the attention of your people. I had little desire to be seen in a difficult spot, and unlike some of us I am not overly obsessed with winning over every soul on Amphoreus. It's as simple as this: so long as they are willing to aid my people, I care not what Okhemans think of me. So yes, aside from Lade Aglaea and yourself, I spoke to very few of your people. As for the things they're currently saying about me, I find it insulting that you take their compliments in jest.

We've lost another percentage of the city since you left. Please remind Lady Aglaea in my stead that I have no intention of inheriting the authority of Strife.

I'm prepared for whatever your city tries to throw at me. What kind of fool doesn't know how to dance? I'm certain I'll be fine.

The victor of our every contest,

Crown Prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos

P.S. Your insistence upon making everything rhyme is greatly hindering your poetic ability. Again, I ask that you refrain from subjecting me to these in the future. If you want a rematch, ask normally.

△

Two weeks until the wedding, Phainon's bruises are healed. His ribs don't ache when he breathes, jaw when he speaks. His throat is unmarked but for the sun there. Still, when he checks in the mirror, head tilted, choker removed, he's still plagued with the thought of where that healed bruise came from.

He's less stuck on it now. It, the raw physicality. The body heat, the damp of Mydei's tongue, the pleasure-pain. Now, he's only afraid of the implications. The mess it might make. They're to be wed, sure, but Phainon wants to make the best of things. He's afraid that sex will muddy the waters, that attraction will squash whatever comfortable dynamic they've managed to cultivate.

Yet Mydei already knows. He felt the way Phainon has ended up wanting him. He wants Phainon too.

Titans above. The string on Phainon's finger proves to be a nuisance at times like these. He forces himself to stop thinking about it.

He wears his wedding robe for Aglaea to pin and alter. She's making it personally, as the Dressmaster of Okhema. It's a beautiful thing of red, white, and gold, colors of transition and

triumph. Aglaea adjusts the fit of the fabric around his shoulders, folding the hems of the sleeves and pinning them around his wrists. She pulls the waist a bit tighter, adjusts the collar so it mimics that of the coat he favors.

When she's satisfied with the alterations she's made, she steps back and circles him one last time, very slowly. Her garmentmaker brings a full length mirror, placing it in front of Phainon. His breath stills as he studies himself.

The fit is perfect. He looks regal and resplendent enough to marry a crown prince, even in red. Aglaea has somehow managed to keep it from clashing with his complexion with just the right shade or the right placement of the color. Phainon looks… like someone he never really imagined himself being. "You do beautiful work," he says.

Aglaea smiles slightly and steps up to his side. She smooths the fabric around his chest. "What do you think of a half sun here?" she asks. "Embroidered in gold."

"Like a new dawn," Phainon says. He looks at himself a little longer. The groom in the mirror, marrying not for love but for life. He wonders if he's ruined things. Maybe Mydei doesn't care at all. "Why not? It's lovely, Aglaea. Thank you."

"You seem unhappy."

"That obvious, huh?" He sighs. "It's just… real now, in a way it hasn't been, but I'll get over it."

Transition, triumph. Phainon isn't afraid of this. He just thinks back to life in a small town and can't help but wish—just every now and then—that things were simpler.

"Do you dislike him?" No strings hum. Aglaea asks him as person to person.

Somehow, this makes Phainon laugh. "No," he says. "No, not at all. That's the strange part. I just…"

Aglaea picks an invisible piece of lint off his shoulder. "You just…?"

Phainon stares himself in the face. "I don't know."

△

At sunset, a week before the wedding, Mydei comes back. Phainon makes the trip to meet him at the gates dressed in his finest blue and white.

Mydei comes in red, as expected, dressed neater but no less boldly than Phainon is used to. The top half of his hair is pulled back, the bottom down, that thin braid still behind one ear. His eyes are low lidded and impassive as he watches Phainon approach, his mouth a smooth line, the markings on his body standing out even in the dying daylight.

He's beautiful, in all honesty. Beautiful in a way the poets don't write about, but attraction is dangerous, and Phainon has already made that choice for them both.

He slips, gracefully, into a formal bow. There's a crowd gathered to watch them meet, to see the soon to be husband of their city's perfect vessel. How Phainon hates that title. He rises steadily and holds out an arm for Mydei to take.

He does, gloved instead of gauntleted today, though he still wears armor on his legs. His fingers curl around Phainon's forearm, watching him carefully with one red lined eye as they begin to walk.

The path to Marmoreal Palace is lit with votives, some on the ground, some held in the hands of people who line the street to watch. The way is clear in front of them, warm with the tail end of golden hour and the flicker of candlelight. Phainon leads the way, one slow step at a time. He can feel Mydei's gaze on him. They make eye contact for a brief moment before it sends something uncomfortable stinging through him.

"You warned me of dramatics," Mydei says, voice low, rough as it always is. "Is this it?"

This hairstyle exposes his temples. The tips of his ears. Each group they pass sparks a wave of whispers. A young girl tosses a handful of crocuses at their feet.

"Every able person in Okhema has come just to see you walk," Phainon murmurs. "There are thousands of eyes on you. Is that not dramatic enough?"

Their shoulders brush with every step, body heat bleeding through fabric. Mydei runs warm, impossibly warm. Phainon remembers that, knows the feeling of touching him like touching flame.

"I suppose I was expecting singing and dancing and flower petals thrown in my face, with how you made it sound," Mydei says. The sun starts to dim, the myriad of colors in the sky fading to blue. Now, the candles stand out. Hundreds of them, thousands, all to light their way.

Phainon smiles, laughs a little, soft for fear of the eyes on them. Too soft, because as a wave of whispers runs through the crowd, he catches a voice saying something like, *maybe they really are in love.*

"I think they like you," Phainon murmurs. Mydei isn't the sweet-faced, delicate bride they've somehow come to expect, but no one wears displeasure directly, and all are riveted as they watch. It seems they still find him beautiful.

There's a sea of nymphs in Phainon's stomach. His heart climbs up his throat.

"Where'd you get that from?" Mydei asks, conscious to keep his voice low and his eyes forward. "They're all just gawking."

He's quite handsome, isn't he?

"They're complimenting you," Phainon says. The path slopes into a soft turn as they continue, the sky growing darker. It's a long walk from the gates to the center of the city.

More children toss flowers, and Mydei is careful to step over them instead of on them, his expression kind of soft.

“I suppose they are,” Mydei concedes. A girl whispers, too loud, *aren’t they lovely?* “Why do they throw flowers?”

“They’re well-wishes,” Phainon answers. “Crocuses are for new beginnings, cyclamen are for love, colchicum for fidelity. They’re blessing the marriage.”

Mydei’s hand shifts a little lower, warm fingers circling Phainon’s wrist. “Your traditions are terribly sentimental.”

“Romantic,” Phainon corrects. “Just call them romantic.”

“There’s no such word in the Kremnoan language.”

A soft laugh. They spend much of the rest of the walk in silence, watching as the sky darkens the rest of the way, the street lit by softly flickering candlelight. When their path comes to an end, he walks Mydei inside. At the door to his guest quarters, their arms slip free from each other.

“Rest well, Mydei,” Phainon says, feeling achy and strange, unable to help studying him. “It’ll be a lot from here on out.”

The eye contact they make is strange and intense. “You as well.” After a moment, Mydei slips something from his pocket and holds it out. A pouch of coarse, burgundy fabric. It crinkles when Phainon takes it.

“What is this?” he asks.

And Mydei answers, “something small. Excuse my lack of creativity, but I didn’t think you’d be the type to care for flowers or jewels either.”

Phainon laughs, more air than sound, and opens it. Inside is a handful of hard candies in waxed paper. He takes one out, unwrapping it and finding it blood red and a bit transparent.

“Pomegranate,” Mydei tells him, “since you seemed to like it back in Kremnos.”

“I did,” Phainon says, trying the candy. It’s sweet and tart, and he likes this too. “Thank you.”

“You’re welcome,” Mydei says, and sets a hand on the door. “Goodnight, Deliverer.”

Heart still in his throat, looking at him, tucking the candy in his cheek, Phainon says back, “Goodnight.”

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

boss makes a dollar, I make a dime, I post fanfiction on company time

Mydei gets his wedding robes fitted first thing the next morning. He'd already been measured and prodded before he left, so they already fit, but Aglaea still pins tiny half inch alterations here and there as if it makes any kind of difference. Mydei stays still and silent through the entire process, patience thin but knowing better than to pick a fight.

He observes himself in the full length mirror held by Aglaea's garmentmaker. The robes are red, gold and white. Wedding colors in Okhema, as Phainon said. It's a palette that suits him, not too far off from his usual clothes. The sleeves are full length and he's given one glove, the hand with Aglaea's string bare. The top opens at the chest, dipping low enough to show some of the markings on his chest. It's comfortable, the fabric soft and designed in a way that doesn't impede his movement. He'll be able to dance in this, as promised.

Aglaea quits fiddling with the fabric at his waist and steps back. "There isn't much time left until the wedding," she says, "but if there's anything small you would like added to the ensemble, I will do my best."

The draping fabric of the robes is split at the legs, revealing red trousers and gold-trimmed boots. He feels bare without armor, but he doubts full plate on his legs would be appropriate at a wedding. The clothing is as nice as he could have imagined it, all things considered. Perhaps he should care more, considering this is what he's to wear at his wedding, but he finds himself largely impartial.

"This is fine as it is," he says, crossing his arms and noticing the way nothing pulls at his shoulders. They're comfortable and fit well, and that's really all he can ask for. "Thank you, Lady Aglaea."

"You're far less picky than most of my customers," Aglaea muses. She paces around him, standing next to her garmentmaker and considering him up and down. A hand comes to her mouth in thought. "More gold, perhaps..."

"Don't trouble yourself," Mydei says.

Aglaea smiles slightly. "You're quite resistant to being waited on for a crown prince."

"I simply tire of this."

A soft hum. Aglaea waves her garmentmaker away. "Be careful not to pull out any of the pins as you take those off. I won't make any significant changes if you're satisfied as is."

"I am," Mydei says. Aglaea steps out to give him privacy as he strips out of the wedding robes and pulls his own back on, armor and all. He folds the clothing neatly over his arm and returns it to her outside, careful with the pins. "Thank you," he says again.

She studies him for a too long moment after she accepts the bundle of fabric. "Thank you," she says back. "You're a very cooperative customer. Are you certain there's nothing I can improve for you?"

No," Mydei tells her. Her expression is so calm. She unsettles him still. "But... there is something I'd like to ask."

She doesn't look at him, just smooths the cloth in her hands, adjusting a fold, a pin. "Most things I can answer."

He takes a breath. "Many of my people will want to attend the wedding. There's a small Kremnoan tradition I'd like to include if possible."

Now, she looks at him. "That, I can arrange." A small, knowing smile. "So long as it doesn't involve another vicious spar between the grooms."

△

On his way back to his rooms, Mydei nearly bumps into someone in the hallway. She's short and slight, a blur of whites and purples as she stumbles out of his way with far more force than anyone ought to. They don't touch. She clutches her hand to her chest with wide eyes before she gives a short bow.

"My apologies, Lord Mydeimos," she says. The Maiden of War, destined for the coreflame of Thanatos. Mydei still forgets her name, but remembers the feeling of her gaze following him.

"Servant of Death," he greets, nodding to her. Slowly, she lowers her hand, smoothing her skirt and clasping both in front of her.

“Castorice, Your Highness.”

“Castorice,” Mydei repeats.

She nods back, then shifts on her feet. She parts her lips, then closes them, glancing down the hallway like she means to leave. And then she hesitates, finally setting on saying, “How are you enjoying Okhema, Your Highness?”

“It’s… bright,” Mydei answers. Castorice doesn’t seem to know how to reply to this. She opens her mouth again, closes it. Mydei waits for her to find the words for a moment longer, then says, “I’ve noticed your gaze. Do you have something you want to say to me?”

Her eyes widen, if only slightly. “I apologize if I’ve caused you discomfort—”

Mydie raises a hand. “Speak plainly,” he tells her, and then attempts to soften his voice. “I only wish to know what you want to say.”

“I…” She pauses. “You carry the scent of the River of Souls.”

Years later, she can sense that. Perhaps it’s his curse of immortality that she smells, or perhaps she’s really that keen. “Yes,” Mydei agrees. “I drifted there for nine years before I dragged myself out with this immortal shell.”

“I… see.”

Left to die by his father’s hands. Mydei remembers the feeling of a caved-in chest. The scent of blood in the air. The son of Gorgo will be crowned in blood. This girl doesn’t know him, not really, but that’s okay. “If you seek Thanatos,” he says, “I’m afraid I am of no help. I saw no sight of them.”

“I understand,” she says, and bows again, one long tail of hair slipping over her shoulder. She stands far, but she smells like hyacinth. Her hands, clasped in front of her, curl so tightly it must be painful. “Thank you.”

△

All too early in the morning, there's a knock on the door. Mydei is awake, though he's still unarmored and half-dressed, caught in the middle of redoing his braid. He waits until he's finished, fastening off the end before he stands and goes to the door. Phainon is on the other side, hands clasped in front of him, messy haired and a little bit flustered. He's begun to turn away, but turns back when he hears the door open.

"Hello," he says, and his eyes dip to Mydei's bare chest before they snap right back up. "I hope I didn't wake you." He's dressed head to toe in his usual coat, a flush beneath the collar.

"No," Mydei tells him. For some reason, Phainon laughs a little, flashing the points of his teeth. One finger hooks in his choker. Mydei remembers what it tastes like. Salt and leather. The scent of pine resin.

"Good," Phainon says. His gaze goes somewhere over Mydei's shoulder, then to his face, then the floor. "Great. Would you like to get breakfast?"

"You'll have to wait," says Mydei.

"That's fine." Phainon nods. "Take as long as you need."

Mydei holds his gaze for a moment, then steps out of the doorway and shuts it between them. Phainon waits outside as he pulls the rest of his clothes on and armors himself, as he lines his eye in red and puts his earring in. There's a strange feeling that it gives him, thinking of Phainon leaning against the wall, hands clasped, soft haired and warm bodied and far firmer than he looks. Mydei is unused to being denied a person he knows wants him too.

When Mydei steps into the hallway, Phainon straightens up and smooths out his clothes. He smiles, and something about him looks like he's been in the wind, young like fresh grass. He holds out an arm, then seems to think better of it, fingers flexing and dropping back to his side. "Shall we go?"

Mydei takes a breath and shuts the door behind him.

They leave Marmoral Palace instead of heading to the dining chamber like Mydei expected. Phainon leads him onto the streets of this golden, sunny city. It seems to get brighter every time Mydei sees it. More banners, more flowers tied to posts, ribbons hung between buildings in shades of red, white, and gold. A city in celebration. He thinks of Castrum Kremnos: homes turned to dust, sky overcome with darkness, people left bleeding on the streets. For years after Mydei dragged himself out of the River of Souls, he would feel the sickening rocking of waves when he closed his eyes at night. The feeling he gets now is similar to that.

"Where are we going?" he asks.

"I thought you might like to try more authentic Okheman food," Phainon explains. "There's a stall not too far from here."

"Street food," Mydei notes.

Phainon looks at him. "Yes," he says. "Is that a problem?"

Mydei grew up closer to a common soldier than a king. "No."

"Perfect," Phainon says, and leads them around a corner. Mydei watches his back and thinks, for the first real time in a month, that this is the man he's going to be married to in less than a week.

He's strong enough, certainly. Had Phainon not put down his sword when they fought, Mydei isn't certain he would have been the victor. The next time they fight, he may very well lose. He thinks of the stories he'd been told of Gorgo and Eurypon. The way they fought time and time again, never ending up with a clear victor. There is no word for "lover" in the Kremnoan language, but there is one for "equal." That stupid poem comes to Mydei's mind, unbidden. Mydeimos, I swear, I am your equal.

Just like the comb, Phainon probably hasn't the slightest clue about the significance of such a statement. Dense as a rock, but Mydei remembers the feeling of him, skin under his lips soft as—

"Snowy!" One of the Holy Maidens of Janusopolis skips up to them. She's easily half Mydei's height, with red hair and chopped bangs swept out of the way of her eyes.

"Lady Tribbie," Phainon laughs. His hand reaches back, catching Mydei's forearm and squeezing, whether consciously or not. "Mydei and I were just going to get some koulouri. Are you hungry?"

She blinks, then turns her attention to Mydei, noting their positioning. Phainon's warm, staying palm. "We spent a long time searching for you, De," she says. "It's nice to see you in Okhema."

Searching for him. "'De?'" Mydei repeats.

She perks up and says, “A nickname! Snowy is Snowy, Agy is Agy, and you’re De!”

He frowns, imagining Lady Aglaea answering to “Agy.” And aside from the shade of his hair, there is little snow-like about Phainon. “I… see,” is all Mydei can muster.

Phainon squeezes once more and lets go, fingers skimming skin as his hand drops. He laughs, a little awkward. “Are you hungry, Lady Tribbie?” he asks. “Can we get you something to eat?”

“We ate,” she answers, “and now we have business with Agy and Cas, otherwise we would love to stay.”

“Of course,” Phainon tells her. “Have fun then, Lady Tribbie. We’ll see you later.”

She smiles and lingers a little, looking between them. “Congratulations,” she finally says, then starts to turn away. “See you later, Snowy, De!” She skips away in a matter of moments. Mydei watches her go, still frowning.

“She’s…” He’s uncertain how to finish that sentence.

Phainon sighs. “Child-like?” he offers, rolling his shoulders as they begin to walk again. Slowly, Mydei nods in confirmation. Childlike, though he knows Lady Tribios is older than all the rest of them. “She ages in reverse,” Phainon continues. “It’s part of her… blessing, from Janus. She split herself into a thousand pieces, but each one lives on borrowed time.”

“Just call it a curse.”

Phainon looks at him. “No,” he says, and shakes his head. “She’s a blessing to all of us.”

They walk the rest of the way in silence.

The stall Phainon takes them to is run by a woman with graying hair and smile lines on her face. She serves them koulouri far bigger than anyone ought to eat at once, covered in sesame seeds and smelling warm and bready. The way she smiles is proud and bittersweet.

“You’ve grown up, Lord Phainon,” she says, and she refuses when he tries to pay. “Congratulations. Mnestia’s blessings upon your marriage.”

“Do you know her?” Mydei asks as they find a spot to sit, pretending not to notice the eyes that follow them.

“She’s been running that stall since I was more boy than man,” Phainon says. “Maybe longer than I’ve been in Okhema.” He lifts his koulouri, the ring of it as big as his head. “She makes good food, though.”

Mydei takes a bite of his and finds that he can’t refute that. His eyes close at the flavor before he catches himself and opens them again. The corners of Phainon’s lips curl when he does, but it’s small, subdued. Mydei would have expected some kind of teasing. When there’s none, Mydei studies him.

“Your hometown,” he says. “Aedes Elysiae. What’s it like?”

“Small,” Phainon answers. “Destroyed, now, and taken by the black tide. That’s why I’m here now, like everyone else.”

“Like everyone else?”

Phainon takes a bite and chews slowly. Swallowing, he explains, “Most Okhemans aren’t really from here, what with the black tide. Most of the Chrysos Heirs aren’t… The Ladies Tribios come from Janusopolis, Castorice comes from Aidonia, I’m from Aedes Elysiae…”

“And the actual Okhemans, how do they feel?”

“They’re welcoming people,” Phainon says, turning his gaze back to the woman running the cart. She passes pastries wrapped in paper to a couple of parents and their children, patting the mother’s hand as she does. One of those girls, with mousy brown hair and the straps of a hand-me-down dress trying to fall off her shoulder, had tossed flowers when he arrived. Mydei turns his gaze up, toward the blazing sun and the streamers strung over every inch of the city, all for them, and gets something different than that cold water feeling.

“I’m sure some aren’t happy,” Phainon continues. “But most of them…” Flowers and well wishes and strange but kind rumors floating through crowds. Not once has Mydei witnessed a fight in the streets. These people don’t flaunt bloodshed, don’t dismiss the value of life, even those of strangers. They don’t throw their children in the River of Souls, and they don’t drive spears through their fathers’ chests.

The koulouri is the slightest bit sweet. Laughter comes from across the plaza. A boy gapes at them and hides behind his mother when he’s caught staring.

“Are you worried about the Kremnoans? I know Okhema and Castrum Kremnos haven’t exactly had the best relationship in the past, but they’re welcome—you’re welcome—just like anybody else.”

Mydei has seen children cry when asked to swallow medicine. This is the feeling he gets now. A bittersweet taste in his mouth and a helplessness toward what he must do to save himself. His people. Like a dog in a cage, he makes the choice to lay down and accept it.

“This,” he says, squinting at the sky, “is a terribly bright city.”

Phainon laughs. “Isn’t it? We’re so close to Kephale. It takes some getting used to.”

“Yes,” Mydei says, and leaves it at that.

△

The day before the wedding comes with two separate feasts, one for Phainon, another for Mydei. They’re kept apart as per Okheman tradition. Mydei’s dressed in a robe other than the one Aglaea made for him, though the colors are the same. Red and white tied at the waist with a gold belt.

Guests are free to visit each feast as they please, stopping by either or both for bites from tables stocked generously with breads, meats, cheeses, fruits. There's wine that Mydei indulges in perhaps more than he's meant to, but he needs something to keep him from going insane from the small talk he's forced to engage in with more strangers than he can count. Each one is kind, welcoming, and congratulatory, but Mydei has never been much of a people person.

After perhaps four hours of this, there's a headache pounding behind Mydei's temples, and Lady Aglaea deigns to visit.

"In a half hour the feast will come to a close," she says. "You will be expected to thank the guests, and then you will be led outside for the festival."

He's already been given the rundown a half dozen times. Energy leaving him like the little honey pastries on the dessert table, Mydei can only nod. Aglaea studies him.

"Is there anything you'd like to ask of me?" she asks. "Now would be the time."

"No," Mydei says, sounding just as tired as he feels. "Only that you keep your word once all of this is seen through."

"We may make the charge as soon as three days from now, if you wish," Aglaea tells him. Solemnly, Mydei nods. Thin, golden threads hum between them. "You're ready, then?"

"Yes."

"Marriage, in Okhema, is a sacred thing."

Mydei inhales, nostrils flaring. "And in Castrum Kremnos it's not?"

There's a sharp, resonant sound like one of the strings has been plucked. "I mean to ask if any part of you is uncertain," Aglaea says, cold as ice, "not to insult you."

"A bit late for doubts," Mydei says. Aglaea's expression does not change, more stern than favorable. He sighs. "As far as prospects go, your Deliverer is far from the worst." The string around his finger heats. Aglaea's voice dips low.

"You will treat him well," she murmurs, as soft as the touch of a blade on skin. It's the most hostile she's been to him, and Mydei does not appreciate anything she's insinuating. In his lap, his hand curls into a fist.

"I would not take him as my—" The word he almost uses is a Kremnoan one. The one they have for lack of "lover" or "spouse." "Husband," Mydei finishes, "had I any intention of neglecting or mistreating him. One would think, in offering me his hand, you would be sure of this as well."

Aglaea's gaze falls to the thread on his finger, his hands bare and unarmored in the outfit he'd been dressed in for today. The silvery, translucent thing goes hot once more, and then her gaze goes back to his face. "You do not love him," she says.

“There is no word for love in the Kremnoan language.”

Something changes as she examines his expression. She goes from hostile to calm, unbothered as the surface of a still pool. “Yet surely you feel,” is all she says, and then she stands, smoothing out her skirts. “Mnestia’s blessings upon you.”

△

Thanking the guests apparently means standing in the doorway and shaking the hands of each one as they leave to join the festival. His headache intensifies the longer he’s asked to smile.

On their way out, each guest lights a candle for him, until there’s a pathway leading him out of Marmoreal Palace that resembles the one that led him to it days earlier. A symbol of passage. As the last guest clears out, a servant comes by and lights the unlit candles.

He’s made to wait, and he does so with his eyes shut, basking in the small bit of silence he’s been allowed. One deep breath, two, three. When he opens his eyes, it’s to the warm flickering of candlelight lining either side of the hall, curving around the corner and out of sight. It smells, as much of Okhema does, of cherry laurel. After a handful of moments, Mydei is waved forward, so he sets off on the path. One step at a time. One foot after the other.

As he goes further, he starts to hear the din of the celebrations outside. People talking, laughing, music playing. It reminds him of the moments before stepping into the arena. The roar of the crowd as they wait. The heat of the braziers, the feeling of the ground under his feet. But there’s no fight at the end of this path for Mydei, and somehow that's so much worse.

The doors to Marmoreal Palace are wide open, the candles continuing through the doorway and leading outside to where there are hundreds of faces. Cheering erupts as he rounds the corner, and he squints as he steps into the light. Again, flowers are tossed at his feet. Brightly colored, sweet smelling things. He's careful to step over them.

The path turns into a loop that curves back into Marmoreal Palace. Mydei stops at the bottom and watches Phainon come out, stumbling a little as he trips over the seam between the door and the ground outside. The cheers are deafening, even as he straightens up and laughs a little, rubbing his neck. Mydei is too far to hear him, but somehow knows exactly what that laugh must sound like.

Moments pass in a flurry of cheers and flowers, the scent of cherry laurel and candles and people staining his nose. There's a strange sensation in Mydei's stomach. It's light and fluttering, like sickness but soft, and he doesn’t know what to do with it. Phainon joins him at the end of the path, dressed in white and gold with red accents here and there. His robe opens up at his chest, the collar folding down to show his neck devoid of its usual choker. His throat is smooth and bare, the sun displayed starkly on his skin, and a breeze fluffs up his hair and makes him look... bright, maybe. Enough to have to squint at. Enough for Mydei to feel a little bit nauseous.

"You walk slow, Deliverer," he says as Phainon comes to a stop. It earns a laugh, and then they're facing each other, more flowers thrown at their feet.

Phainon's eyes are anything but icy. "Who's to say you didn't start before me?" he asks, lips curled up. "Or maybe my path was longer." It takes a handful of moments, but the cheering dies out.

Somewhere in the crowd, music starts. Phainon holds out a hand. "Are you ready?"

Mydei takes it and steps closer to him, setting his other hand on Phainon's shoulder, feeling the heat of the one Phainon puts on his waist. It's the closest to each other they've been since the day of the spar, since...

The scent of pine resin. Phainon's eyes flick between his, tongue peeking through a half smile to wet his lips.

"Ready for what?" Mydei asks. Their hands adjust, palms sliding together. They stand for just a moment, waiting for the music to pick up. It does with a soft arpeggio on a lyre, and then Phainon leads him into the dance. All eyes are on them. "This dance?"

"I forget you mentioned having skill in this area," Phainon says, taking a step forward in time with Mydei taking one back. "Watch your feet," he adds, flower stems snagging on their shoes. Another step back, his palm slips an inch up Mydei's back, steering them away from the candles. Their eyes meet. Too close. "Coordination on the battlefield often spells out coordination on the dance floor too. I should have figured."

"Is that two compliments in one?" Mydei asks dryly.

"You'll find I'm far more generous with those than some of us," Phainon tells him. That smile. "They've dressed you quite nicely today." His hand on the center of Mydei's back. "Can I twirl you?"

Mydei's eyes narrow, but he doesn't object as Phainon spins him and draws him back, catching his waist again. A soft "ooh" comes from the crowd. Phainon looks far too pleased with himself.

"You walk on thin ice," Mydei warns as Phainon's hand slides to his hip. He's far too comfortable, casual.

"It's a good thing I don't mind the cold."

Cocky. Where did that come from? "I should know, having seen you in the rain."

Phainon's face goes from smug to incredulous. "You—" He spins Mydei again like he means this as a punishment. "Will you ever let that go? I was reasonably upset, and— How did you even see that anyway?"

"The window to the guest chambers Lady Aglaea assigned me looks directly out on the plaza," Mydei says, and flicks him in the chest. His palm flattens and slides from chest to neck, skimming skin, cupping the sun. "You practically put yourself on display."

He can feel Phainon's startled breath. Again, they turn to avoid the candles. "Did I?" Vibration against his palm. Phainon's neck is warmer than the rest of him. His pulse thunders. Mydei puts them a half step closer, enough that they almost brush with the next step they take together. The hand on his waist flexes.

"You are terribly easy to turn the tables on," Mydei murmurs. He trails his hand over Phainon's shoulder, rests it on his upper arm. Keeps their eyes fixed on each other.

A blue gaze flicks to a red mouth. "I—"

"Thin ice," Mydei reminds him. "You made that choice, not I."

The song comes to an end. They part amidst crushed flowers under their feet. Phainon bows first, deeply at the waist, then Mydei back. A hundred faces watch, but they're nothing more than the sound of sandals on stone and whispers of breath. This time, when the next song starts, Mydei holds out a hand. The string, thin, translucent silver, gold at a trick of the light, dangles between them. Phainon's palm slips back into his, his other hand on Mydei's shoulder, Mydei's on his waist.

Their second dance is Mydei's to lead. He does as Phainon did, guiding with soft pressure and clear, telegraphed steps. They twist through the carnage of flowers, eyes on each other. He spins Phainon close to the edge of the crowd, the candles flickering as his robes swish by them. Someone gasps softly.

Phainon comes back in close, catching himself on Mydei's chest, looking thoughtful. "I didn't say no," he murmurs, and nearly steps on Mydei's foot. He chews on his lip as he corrects himself, then swallows and adds, "I said not yet."

The music builds into something that feels like a crescendo. Mydei spins Phainon into a shallow dip and says, "What are you afraid of, Deliverer?"

Their faces are close. Eyes wide with surprise, Phainon clings to him as they snap back up. He spares a laugh for the crowd, falling back into step. To Mydei, he whispers, "Risking the alliance. Your people. The coreflame."

They almost trip over crushed flowers. Neither is looking at the ground. Mydei can smell the sweet scent from their bruised petals with each step they take.

"And what makes you think any of those things are at risk?"

"You can't be with someone like that and not change things," Phainon answers. "I don't want —"

Punishment: Mydei twirls him twice in a row. He comes back a bit flustered, lips parted. "Fool," Mydei admonishes. Softer, firmer, "Husband-to-be."

"'Fools fear the wrong things,'" Phainon breathes.

"Yes."

“I said I was afraid you disliked me, and you called me a fool. I understand now.”

“I don’t love you.”

Phainon gives a wry smile and plays with the folds at Mydei’s collar. His fingertips trace a bit of skin, by accident or on purpose. He feels like the stars that come when you hit your head hard. “No,” he says, “there’s no Kremnoan word for that anyway.”

Mydei squeezes his waist, slides his hand around his hip. “Someone’s finally catching on.”

“What happens if one day you do, and I don’t?” Phainon wonders. “Or if I do and you don’t? Can you honestly tell me nothing’s at risk then?”

It’s a terrible time for a conversation like this, hushed low so the crowd can’t hear them. What does it look like they’re saying? Sweet nothings? Provocations? They must make such a strange pair.

“Would you drive my people out of your city over such a thing? Would you rescind your aid against Nikador?” Mydei gives him a look. “Perhaps you overestimate your own importance; would Lady Aglaea even let you do such a thing?”

“Thin. Ice,” Phainon says, enunciating each word clearly. Mydei watches the way his tongue flicks his teeth. The sharp points of his canines. He grins back, and, sensing the end of the song, dips him again, holding him there, flushed and glaring.

“I have no interest in coercing you,” Mydei tells him as the final notes ring out. “Figure these things out yourself, and in the meantime, refrain from attempting to seduce me.”

If not for the setting, Mydei is sure that would have earned him a punch in the face. Phainon fumes for no longer than three seconds before they’re straightening up and bowing to each other once again. The applause that comes is uproarious.

“Thank you for joining us in celebration!” Phainon shouts as the crowd quiets. He stands at Mydei’s side, warm where they brush shoulders, grinning like this is the happiest day of his life. Perhaps a better pretender than Mydei initially thought. “Any who are able and willing are welcome to join us in song and dance.”

On cue, the people in front bend for the candles, each taking one and shuffling to the back of the crowd for the next person. Somehow, together they manage to widen the circle into a ring big enough to hold hundreds. The next song begins, and they’re swept up in a wave of bodies, each one in tune to the rhythm, crushing the last of the flowers into the street. When Mydei turns, Phainon is no longer at his side, swept along or slipped away, out of sight.

Someone taps him on the shoulder, smiling and asking for a dance, and he realizes this is going to be a terribly long night.

Chapter 7

Phainon does not run from the party so much as he… takes a break from it, making his way through clumps of smiling people calling his name and offering small talk. He smiles at each one and exchanges handfuls of words before he claims a need for the restroom and wades a little further through the sea of faces. Each beat of his heart is an audible thing. When he makes it back inside, he's too warm and out of breath, stumbling into a quiet corner of Marmoreal Palace and taking a seat.

One breath in, big enough to make his lungs ache. One out, slow through his teeth like the sound of an ocean wave. The smell of grass, a soft voice telling him to breathe. *You'll be a hero someday, I'm sure of that. Remember it.* His heart calms. He rubs his fingers into his temple. Sighs. Curls in on himself at a sudden shock of embarrassment. Knocking his head into his knees, he mutters to himself, "Kephale above. What is wrong with me?"

Phainon is not often bold—not without a bit of wine in him—but something must have possessed him in the moments before this.

"That was quite the spectacle," comes a voice. Phainon bangs his head on his knees once more before he looks up. Aglaea stands there, an almost smile on her face

"Lady Aglaea," he greets, standing up and smoothing out his robes. The heat in his face never has a chance to cool before it's coming back full force. "I was just, well…"

"I'm not here to drag you back to the festivities," she says, and finds a railing on the wall to half sit on. "I saw how they swarmed you as soon as you were free."

"Yes, it's... a lot," Phainon agrees tentatively. He folds his arms, then wonders if he looks like he's curling in on himself and drops them. Aglaea's gaze follows the movement, but she does not send out her strings to read him.

"How do you fare?" Aglaea asks him. Person to person again. Just asking. Strangely, this arranged marriage thing has humanized her.

Phainon blinks. Gingerly leans against the railing too. "Well," he answers. "I... Well, I suppose. Or, as well as I can."

Slowly, she nods, studying him, scrutinizing. "Are you prepared for tomorrow?"

"For the ceremony?" Phainon asks. "Or for the fact that I'm going to be a married man?"

"Both," Aglaea says, "either."

"How prepared can I really be?" He laughs, tries to. "I have to just… face this head on. But I'm alright, Lady Aglaea. I'm not… Mydei's a good man. I'm…" Happy is not the right word. Relieved, perhaps. Glad, fortunate, satisfied. "...Content, that it's him."

Aglaea is quiet for a moment. “The people are enamored.” She holds a hand out for his, which he tentatively offers. The one with the string; it appears in her cool palms, glowing faintly with a soft, warm light. She looks at it for a long while, expression unreadable but a little bit soft. “They believe you’re in love.”

“I’m…”

“Contentment,” she interrupts, “is far more than many in your situation could hope for.”

Phainon hesitates. “Yes…” he tries. Their eyes meet, green gold to blue, sobriety to confusion.

“I will not tie you where you are unhappy,” Aglaea says, squeezing his hand in both of hers. “This is the last time I may ask. Are you certain?”

A breath. He thinks of sparring in the baths and taking turns leading a dance. He thinks of the way they bicker but don’t quite fight, the way they both take the care to listen. The strange thing that sits between them now, the ease of companionship, the heat of attraction. He finds that, perhaps, he isn’t just resigned to or accepting of a marriage to Mydei, but a small part of him, a small, irresponsible, brash, reckless, and impulsive part of him actually *wants it.*

Phainon tends to move fast when it comes to action, slow when it comes to people. He hasn’t known Mydei long, but maybe if they’d known each other outside of this, been given months and years instead of a handful of weeks for a courtship, maybe…

Figure these things out yourself. Phainon exhales. Maybe he needs to be braver. Maybe he needs to trust that not every good thing eventually goes up in flames. And even if it does, maybe those risks are worth taking. “I am certain.”

Aglaea searches him for truth or falsehood. And then she nods and steps back, her hands slipping from his, her mouth curled into another one of those almost smiles. “Very well,” she says. “Mnestia’s blessings.”

When she leaves, he takes a look at his hand, the heat and the glow coming from the thread tied to his pinky finger. It’s different than before. Still translucent silver, but if Phainon really looks, he can see flecks of gold.

△

He spends most of the rest of the night dancing. He’s swept around by friends acquaintances, and strangers. Here and there, he’ll catch a glimpse of Mydei through the crowd, sometimes looking back, sometimes not. It’s a while before they end up in each other’s hands again. The final dance of the night. Every person in the crowd finds a partner. By Okheman tradition, Mydei is Phainon’s.

No words are exchanged between them. Mydei simply holds his gaze, the orange of his eyes intense as flame, and takes his hands. He lets Phainon lead, pulling his hand to his waist. They wait for the music to start. Phainon’s fingers flex against the heat of a body, the hardness of muscle. Mydei’s attention lands on his throat as he swallows.

And then they dance. One step after the next, in sync with the crowd. This time, the eyes are not on them, or at least not quite so many. And yet not a bit of the pressure is off.

“This is the last chance we’ll have to speak until the wedding,” Phainon points out. “Have you nothing to say?”

“I don’t think I’m the one that needs to,” Mydei tells him. “There’s nothing I have to say that can’t be said just as well after the wedding as before it.”

Phainon looks at him. Searches him for doubt, or the same realization he’d had moments before. But he finds neither of those things, just the conviction that’s always there. “We’ll be married this time tomorrow,” Phainon reminds him. “No thoughts about that? No concerns?”

“Any worries of yours are things that we do not share.” The steps of the dance call for a twirl. When Mydei comes back, they are closer than before. Nearly enough to share air. “I am sure of this in a way I am sure of few things.”

“For your people,” Phainon says, and finds his gaze affixed to a red mouth.

“Yes,” Mydei agrees.

“But how do you…” *feel?* Phainon thinks. Mydei would marry a stranger to save his people. He would give up everything he has. *But how do you feel? You would marry anyone, but what do you think of* me? This is not the time or place to ask such a thing. Perhaps that isn’t the kind of thing that should ever be asked at all. Phainon turns Mydei with gentle pressure, letting his hand slip around his back, resting at the center of it. Beneath his palm, there’s slight, sudden tension. Mydei takes a breath, relaxes again, and Phainon is at a loss. “Are you not afraid of the things you’ll have to give up?”

“There is no word for fear in the Kremnoan language,” Mydei tells him. “I am not afraid. It’s as simple as that.”

A handful of moments pass without conversation. Just the music, the swish of fabrics, the feeling of the ground underneath their feet. When they turn, Castorice is at the edge of the crowd, though she isn’t dancing. She smiles at him when he catches her eye. Nearby, there’s Aglaea and Tribios. The rest of the Chrysos heirs; Hyacine and Cipher and Professor Anaxagoras, all gathered just for this. Because Phainon is getting *married,* and that’s—

“You are a better match than I was hoping for,” Mydei says, voice low over the music. “Is that what you need to hear?”

“I…”

“Though you aren’t quite my match in strength, I will not be tormented by a marriage to you.”

The music comes to an end. They’re meant to part and bow to one another, but Phainon just stays, still holding him, still looking. Should he be flattered, he wonders, or is it fair to be a little bit offended?

“Does that help?” Mydei asks him. “When it comes to figuring things out?”

Now, Phainon steps back. As he bows, his hair falling into his face, he laughs a little. “What a convoluted way to say you like me,” he says, straightening up. “Why can’t you ever just say it outright?”

“You strike me as someone with a very large head, and little sense to fill it.”

“I think I could say the same,” Phainon retorts, almost losing the words in the chatter of the crowd. “You just wait until that rematch, Mydeimos. We’re equals, at minimum. I may even be a bit stronger.”

△

In the morning, Phainon bathes in water blessed by Phagousa and Mnestia both. It is perhaps the most luxurious bath he’s ever taken. Hot and swirling with gold, the tub deep enough to drown in. He’s given sweet smelling oils, a stirgil to clean himself, and soft towels to dry with. After he’s sufficiently raw and pink from cleansing, hair still damp, dressed in a silken white robe, he’s attended to by a handful of servants. They powder, perfume, and prepare him, and when he looks in the mirror he’s a bit startled by his own face.

They’ve done something to smooth out his complexion, and his eyebrows have been shaped and filled in above eyes lined with gold and lips stained a half shade pinker than they normally are. His hair is softer and shinier than he’s ever seen it, styled slicked back on one side, combed neatly on the other. He looks… handsome, he supposes. Like a groom on his wedding day. His stomach roils.

“A bit like magic, isn’t it?” the servant standing at his shoulder asks him.

“Yes,” Phainon says, and it sounds like he’s underwater. “You’ve done an excellent job with this. Thank you.”

“Just doing my job, Lord Phainon. Congratulations on your marriage.”

“Yes,” Phainon repeats, still staring himself down. “Thank you.” That gold around his eyes, the way it makes the sun on his throat stand out. He’s afraid, suddenly, of what they must’ve done to Mydei.

They dress him next, helping him into the freshly altered and perfectly tailored wedding robes Aglaea made him. Red, white, gold. A high collar, a newly embroidered sun, graceful fabric draping to the backs of his knees. Maybe he looks like someone who’s ready for this.

He stands as final adjustments are made to his clothes and hair. And then all the hands retreat. He’s left alone in the mirror. A groom, a man, a hero, a Chrysos Heir, a prince consort. Someone who is entirely unprepared for the future, any bit of it. One breath in. Another out.

“Are you ready, Lord Phainon?”

He can’t count how many times he’s been asked that question. The answer will never be anything but *no, not even a little bit.* He smiles and says, “as I’ll ever be.”

△

The wedding stage is decorated with swathes of white and gold fabric and long chains of flowers. Candles light where Phainon and Mydei are meant to walk onto the upraised platform in front of all of the city of Okhema and anyone else who came to attend.

The ceremony is held at Kephale's feet. It's so bright Phainon has to squint. His stomach still churns. As the music plays and he begins walking up the steps of the stage to the altar in the center, he feels a nervous kind of nauseous, or a nauseous kind of nervous. He wonders, briefly, if this is what all grooms feel on their big day. Dressed and made up as nice as they've been in their life. A thousand eyes on them. Soft music and the sounds of hundreds of people trying to keep quiet. The wood of the steps creaks softly.

Mydei is just as resplendent as he feared. There's far more red on him than on Phainon. Full sleeves and a low dip in the chest. Some of his markings are on display, disappearing into fabric, and somehow it feels far less appropriate like this than it does when he has his entire chest out. One of his hands is gloved, one of Phainon's too. The ones with the strings are bare on both of them.

When they come to a stop, face to face, Mydei holds his gaze. They've made him up too, with his lower eyelids lined in red and a thin dash of gold, his brows filled in, his mouth stained a slight, subtle red like the touch of wine or pomegranate juice. They've done nothing at all to soften the intensity of him. Phainon feels far too warm standing here bearing his attention under a sun practically within reach.

Mydei's hair is undone, unstyled and unbraided. Phainon knows for a fact that not a single attendant would have been allowed to touch it. Mydei would have combed it himself, unravelling the braid with his fingers until the strands hold nothing more than a faint wave in its place.

A breath. A heartbeat pounding in his ears.

Aglaea officiates, as the bearer of the Romance coreflame. She guides them in prayer to Mnestia to bless the marriage. They take turns lighting candles twined with ribbon and olive branch. Phainon's hands shake as he lights his. Mydei is steady as ever. When he steps back, twin flames stand between them, flickering lightly.

Again they pray, this time to Nikador's virtues, as is custom in Castrum Kremnos. Phainon is careful not to stumble over the words, though his tongue is unused to the sharp sounds of the Kremnoan language.

After, Aglaea presents them with two thin gold hair cuffs. Mydei is calm and unreadable as he lifts one between his bare fingers. His nails are trimmed square and clean. He takes a step closer. His gaze against Mydei's, Phainon bows his head.

Mydei picks a section on the non slicked side of his hair. Phainon can't feel how much he takes, or see what it must look like, but he feels the way he divides the hair into three. The slight tickle as he braids it. Steady as ever. Careful not to pull.

Whether consciously or not, Phainon finds his breath held as he waits, nymphs in his stomach.

Mydei's hands fall to his sides when he finishes the braid. It's a small thing, likely no bigger than the width of one of Phainon's fingers and only as long as his hair is. The gold cuff has been warmed by Mydei's palm. It brushes Phainon's cheek.

His turn, now. He accepts the other cuff from Aglaea. Tries not to be blinded by the sun as he raises his head. A small glance, a thousand faces tipped in his direction. One more right here, amber eyes trained to him, softened but anything but soft.

He thinks about gifting Mydei that comb. The accidental intention behind it. Phainon may not be the first to braid Mydei's hair for him. He spent a long time away from home; maybe he doesn't see quite as much significance in this as he claims his people do. Maybe this is just another ritual like the prayers and the candles, but Phainon still imagines the way this might feel for him too. The nerves, the slight, almost wistful feeling of it. Again, his hands shake. He finds that he isn't as practiced at braiding with the cuff in hand as Mydei is. He can't quite decide how to hold it.

Mydei's hair is one step back from soft. Phainon finds the pieces that still hold the impression of a braid behind Mydei's ear. The back of his hand brushes a warm throat. As he sections the hair into three he can feel the slight brush of breath. Strands slipping through his fingers. He could be sick with feeling.

He's careful. One section over the next, pinky and ring fingers of one hand tucking the cuff to his palm. Mydei is silent. His attention says enough. When Phainon secures the braid and steps back, his chest caves with a breath. Their eyes meet as Aglaea resumes the ceremony.

A third time, they pray. This one is to Kephale to bless them with the light of a new dawn. Phainon knows this one by heart, by soul. He turns his face to the sun on Kephale's back, eyelids red against the light of it, and tries his best to trust in this.

They turn, side by side instead of face to face. Phainon takes Mydei's ungloved hand, or maybe Mydei takes his. They clasp, strings entwined, silver flecked with gold on both ends, and hold their joined hands out. Aglaea ties them together with a long white ribbon. She ties it thrice, once beneath the elbow, once at the forearm, and once at the wrist.

A goblet is offered to Phainon. He takes it, drinks deeply of the ambrosia inside and passes it to Mydei without so much as a brush of their hands. He drinks too, presents Aglaea with the empty goblet. She takes it and sets it back on the altar, and then her cold fingers are folding over theirs. She murmurs a prayer over their tied hands and says, "Mnestia's blessings." She lets them go and steps back. "With this, you are bound."

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"We're legitimately tied together for the rest of the night?" Phainon's fingers are too warm around his. Between them, they're starting to grow slick with sweat. Letting go doesn't help much, aside from making this look terribly awkward, since they're tied up to the elbow. Mydei can't be further than half a pace from Phainon at any time without the ribbons digging painfully into them both. Of all of the traditions Mydei has been made to put up with over the course of the last month, none can begin to contest this one as the worst.

"Yes," Phainon answers. "Romantic, isn't it?"

He's closer than Mydei would like him. Much closer, gold lining his eyes, Mydei's braid in his hair. It doesn't help that he's basically dressed in Castrum Kremnos' colors. It's… distasteful, the pleasure Mydei gets from this.

"Romantic," Mydei echoes, dropping Phainon's hand and pulling them both so he can dry his palm on his leg. "What if I need to relieve myself?"

Phainon's lips part. Soft red, his tongue peeks out to wet them before Mydei can stop looking. "I… avert my eyes and try not to listen?"

Mydei scoffs. "HKS."

Phainon frowns. "Hai— What did you just call me?"

"HKS," Mydei repeats. He turns to face forward, uncomfortable with the wanting, almost possessive feeling in his chest. *Husband,* he thinks. *Equal. Mine until the black tide takes us all.* His braid in Mydei's hair. Mydei's in his. Nikador's strife. "It's a Kremnoan word."

Phainon raises an eyebrow. Mydei is looking at him again. Too close, tied together. He doesn't smell like pine, just like powder and something unpleasantly floral. Mydei too. "It sounds like an insult."

"Yes," Mydei agrees. "That's because it is."

An incredulous laugh bursts from Phainon. He starts them walking, the pull on Mydei's arm forcing him to move too. "You sure do know how to charm a man, husband of mine."

An odd sensation climbs his neck. Phainon pulls them along, out from behind the stage so they have no choice but to join the festivities. More song and dance, more feasting, more small talk. All while tied to this much too friendly man Mydei is now married to. He can already feel the headache building in his temples. Phainon's fingers curl back around his, if only because it feels more natural than whatever they were doing before. Mydei glances between their hands and the hint of a smile on his face.

Are you happy? He wonders. The vision of a boy in the rain. He can't be, can he? What does he have to be happy for?

Am I *happy?* A stranger question still. Mydei is bound by duty and nothing else. Attraction isn't strong enough to make a miracle of this.

In moments, they're swarmed. Mydei can barely hear his own breath amidst all the congratulations and greetings and Phainon talking to a dozen people he seems to know like his best friends. He laughs that laugh that Mydei has memorized. It plays on repeat in his head. Over and over. *Equal, are you happy?* Softly, Phainon squeezes his hand. It isn't a no, at the very least.

△

Nightfall comes with a torchlit procession back to Okhema, to what will become Mydei's new home and his… for lack of a better term, bridal bed. There are no candles this time; attendees hold brightly blazing torches as they march alongside them. Mydei and Phainon, still bound together and sweating profusely at the palms because of it, walk in front.

It's anything but quiet, the air filled with conversation and laughter. The sound of joy, of people coming together. Mydei breathes in sweat and smoke. It's been a long, long day.

"One more day," Phainon says, turning to him, "and then we're free of this." He's shiny with sweat and oils, powder worn off. His eyeliner is smudged, a bit of gold smeared on one temple, and his lips are chapped and red from the way he keeps chewing on them. In this moment, at least, he does look happy. "And the day after doesn't involve nearly as much partying."

"Big commotion, just for us," Mydei notes. It's a strange thing, being beloved by people he doesn't even know. They love Phainon, and in turn, love him. It almost makes him feel guilty. If not for his need of aid, he wouldn't be here at all.

Phainon laughs. "It's like this any time anyone even a little bit important gets married here," he says. "Maybe not quite on this scale, but Okhema loves its parties."

Soft, high laughter. Behind them, the Maiden of War laughs at something one of the ladies Tribios says. Lady Aglaea looks on with a smile. Back to Phainon, torchlight and shadow dancing on his face. "Are you having fun, at least?" he asks.

Mydei has a lot to worry about. The fate of an entire city on his back. Still, he looks at Phainon and considers. "Yes," he decides. "I suppose I am."

"I'm glad." Phainon smiles a little wider. They keep walking, shoulders brushing every few steps. "And then after all this, we'll march to Kremnos."

"Are you coming with us?"

Phainon blinks. *"Am* I? I thought that was a given."

In Kremnos, equals never leave each other alone on the battlefield. Mydei purses his lips. “I made aid negotiations with Lady Aglaea, not you.”

Somehow, this gets a laugh. “So you think I’d marry you to help your people, but draw the line at actually fighting for them? No, Mydeimos, I’ll be right there next to you, watching your back. With the love your people have given me… I could hardly forsake them now.”

Him, in Kremnos red. Bloodstains on his cuffs. Gold on his cheek. Guarding Mydei’s back. Even the littlest things he does spark unwarranted heat. Mydei untangles their hands to wipe his palm again, loathing the warmth of Phainon’s forearm against his. How he can’t wait to untie this damned ribbon. “There is no word for love in the Kremnoan language,” Mydei reminds him.

“Sure,” Phainon agrees. “So what do you call it, then? Because I know you feel the emotion.”

“That…” A trap Mydei set for himself. “That is none of your concern.”

“One of these days I’ll have to find a Kremnoan dictionary,” Phainon muses. Their shoulders brush. He takes the opportunity to wipe his palm too. Mydei’s knuckles skim his leg. All they’ve done today is touch. His skin is beginning to prickle.

It’s another twenty or so minutes before they reach Marmoreal Palace. At Phainon’s—Mydei’s now too—quarters, the people halt, turning from a parade into a clump. Together, they pray to the Titans to bless the newlyweds, and then they throw rice. Handfuls and handfuls of rice. Mydei squeezes his eyes shut and only manages not to slip away or fight someone because he’d been warned.

Thunderous cheering. Mydei opens his eyes to a thousand smiling faces and tries to shake the rice from his robes. Phainon’s hand folds back around his and pulls him inside.

When the door shuts, he sighs, and then goes silent. Rice skitters to the floor with each tiny movement they make. It’ll be a pain to clean, Mydei can already tell. He starts picking at the ribbon binding them, undoing the first tie, then the second, third. Phainon doesn’t speak. There’s an odd tension about him. Mydei opens his mouth to say something as the ribbon drifts to the floor between them. Then, a fist hits him straight in the face.

He stumbles back, reeling, but next is a hard kick to his side that he doesn’t manage to dodge. Another punch that he just ducks under, the pain in his jaw from the first not even finished blooming. “What are you—!” Another hit. He blocks it with his forearm. One to his ribs, connecting hard. He grits his teeth and steadies his weight, guard raised, sweeping one foot out in an attempt to trip Phainon.

He’s too steady, now that he has momentum. He hits hard and fast, forcing Mydei on the defensive. “Rematch,” he pants in a moment between blows. He backs Mydei far too close to the wall for comfort; Mydei growls and refocuses, hitting back, clipping Phainon’s shoulder as he regains ground.

Things only devolve from there. Phainon kicks and Mydei catches his boot, slamming into the door and yanking him forward. They slip on rice, tumbling to the ground with a hard

thump, breath hissing through teeth, limbs colliding. Mydei gets Phainon pinned—sees his gritted teeth, the feral look in his eyes—and raises his fist. He's shoved off by a foot to the ribs and rolled, grunting as his back hits the ground, shoving Phainon's face away as a knee digs into his gut, trying to kick, catching a handful of fabric between his fingers and *pulling*—

Something rips. Phainon stumbles forward, catching himself on one forearm. Mydei tries to take advantage to switch their positions again, but when he moves his head he finds his hair caught beneath Phainon's arm and grunts, trying to change tactics too late before knees lock around his and a strong arm pins his to his chest.

There's rice sticking to Phainon's cheek. When he grins, catching his breath, a couple of grains fall. One hits Mydei in the chin. "Yield," Phainon says. The silence between them is deafening. Slowly, Mydei tests the strength of the hold Phainon has on him, flexing his legs, pushing against Phainon's hand. Phainon only tightens his grip in response, his other hand joining the first to hold Mydei's arms down.

There's a fresh bruise blooming beneath his eye where Mydei must have clipped him in their scuffle on the ground. His makeup is still smudged all over. He's still covered in rice, smelling more like sweat this late into the night than anything else. He's molten everywhere they touch. There's a tear in the front of his robe, bisecting that carefully embroidered sun. Lady Aglaea will not be pleased.

"Yield," Phainon insists, staring him down. He looks like an ocean at midnight. The taste of blood and dirt on Mydei's tongue.

Again, he tries to shift, finds that he cannot move. "Did you not spare a thought for the fact that your entire city is listening right outside that door?"

"I don't think they think we're fighting," Phainon says. His smile slips into something more serious, something Mydei can feel between his teeth. Heat, from his body and something else. Palpable want. Phainon slips a hand into his robes and produces a dagger, that same one from before in the baths, and presses the dull edge to the base of Mydei's throat. He doesn't ask again, only raises his eyebrows expectantly. Mydei can't stop looking at his mouth. The red of it, the way it would look smeared with the gold of his blood.

Kremnos red and gold. *Equal,* he thinks with a hot kind of passion. All the blood in his lower half. "I yield," he says, tipping his head back.

Nikador's strife, if Castrum Kremnos could see him now. How far he's fallen, to have his throat bared for the first man to match his strength. It wasn't even a fair fight.

Phainon tucks the knife away and releases Mydei, climbing off of him, wiping the rice from his cheek.

He sits. Mydei breathes, willing his blood to cool and his heart to calm. Slowly, he pushes himself up, brushing off his now rumpled robes, scattering rice to the floor. Phainon picks at the tear in his own clothing, holding the pieces together with his lips pursed. A soft laugh. "Lady Aglaea isn't going to be happy."

Mydei's fault, but still. "You made the choice to fight."

Phainon shakes out his hair, messing up the slicked side, making himself look like some kind of dog in the wind. "You know," he says, "I finally found a source on Kremnoan courting tradition."

Mydei barks a laugh, still battling his own blood, dragging his legs into a seated position. The tension in his trousers is terribly conspicuous, but he hardly cares. Phainon already knows; they've been here once before. Post fight, sweat slick, adrenaline pumping. He's felt Phainon's want against him. "Then you know," he says, "what happens after the battle on a Kremnoan wedding night."

Phainon doesn't have the decency to blush. "Yes," he agrees. "I imagine that part of tradition is the same from culture to culture." He stretches closer on his knees and one hand, the other reaching out. "You have rice in your hair," he says. "May I?"

Mydei studies him and wonders if he's really this clueless. To read up on Kremnoan tradition and ask to touch Mydei's hair anyway. Did he forget, or does he mean it?

Slowly, like walking himself to the edge of a cliff, Mydei tips his head in the direction of Phainon's hand. Fingers slip through his hair, lightly ruffling it to shake the rice out, then smoothing it back down. It tickles the slightest bit, sending a chill down the back of Mydei's neck, trying to halt the breath in his throat. Mydei is still so terribly unused to being denied what he knows another wants too. It wrings him out like a rag left to dry.

"You read up on my culture," he says, "and still choose to partake. I wonder, are you cruel or foolish?"

A soft laugh. Phainon falls back onto his shins. "Foolish, I think," he admits. "I'm afraid of things I shouldn't be, but I want to…" Words seem to fail him. He wets his lips, parts them, swallows. Mydei can still feel the phantom of his hand in his hair.

"Take a risk," Mydei finishes for him.

"Maybe," he confesses.

"And what of the people?"

A chuckle, more air than sound, more nerves than amusement. "Not out there listening still, I hope, but if they are, I'll handle that embarrassment tomorrow."

Mydei shakes his head. "You know what I meant."

Phainon sighs. "I'm not worried anymore, if that's what you're asking," he says, trying to sound firmer than he really is. "You were right. I trust us."

"What do you want, then?"

"I…" Mydei waits as Phainon struggles for the words. Long enough that his blood cools, heart calms. Slowly, he stands and dusts himself off. He undoes the ties on his outer robes

and strips out of them, wrestling with the straps on his glove and pushing up the sleeves of his linen undershirt. He holds out a hand, raises an eyebrow when Phainon only stares.

“Were you planning on staying there?” he asks.

“What are you doing?”

“Resting,” Mydei answers, and waves his hand. “It’s been a long night, and I would like to recuperate.”

Phainon exhales but clasps his hand. Mydei pulls him up, and then he’s struggling out of his ruined robes too, tossing them to the ground, leaving him in a white under robe. “I suppose I could be amenable to that,” he says, and sighs. “You’re too patient with me.”

“Hardly,” Mydei says. “We have a lifetime.”

△

It's with a laugh that Mydei notices their wedding bed. It's made neatly with creamy white sheets, the bedspread scattered with flower petals, money, and a handful of jewels. Candles line the bedside tables, and there's a pungent, too sweet smell in the air. "What is this?" he asks.

Phainon steps in beside him, scratching the back of his neck. His fingers slip around his throat, looking for a choker that isn't there, and he lets out an awkward chuckle. "Ah, I believe the Ladies Tribios and Castorice are responsible. It's tradition for friends and family to decorate the wedding bed in Okhema."

Metal coins and pointy jewels. Again, Mydei can't help a laugh, rough and wheezing, as he picks up a particularly angular gemstone. "Practical," he says. "Quite comfortable to consummate a marriage on."

At this, Phainon laughs too. Together, they gather up the hard things in the bed, piling a small wealth of them on the nightstands, and then Mydei collapses amidst soft sheets and flower petals. He sighs, hands folding over his stomach, eyes slipping shut. The bed dips as Phainon settles in beside him. Mydei peeks at him, white hair spread on his pillow, staring at the ceiling. When he feels Mydei's gaze, he looks back.

"You know," he says, kind of quietly, "I usually sleep on that side."

Slowly, Mydei blinks. "We can fight for it next time."

Airy laughter. "I won today," Phainon reminds him. "This is my bed."

"Mine now too," Mydei says, quirking an eyebrow, "husband."

Phainon's eyes narrow. It's beautiful on him, like blood on snow. "I'm going to wash," he says, and slips out of bed, petals stuck to his back. Mydei watches his back as he goes, the width of his shoulders, the way he thins at the waist. And then he shuts his eyes again,

breathing in that too sweet air. Just a couple of days from now, he'll be back in Castrum Kremnos, back on the battlefield. All of this will come to fruition.

When Phainon comes back, the smudged makeup is washed clean from his face. The ends of his hair are damp, his feet are bare, and he's kept Mydei's braid in. "Your turn," he says, falling with a huff into the bed. "Down the hall to your left." Mydei sinks his teeth into the insides of his cheeks and stands. As soon as he's gone, Phainon takes his spot on the bed, petals slipping over the edge.

As Mydei leaves the bedroom, he studies this home that's now meant to be halfway his. Cool stone floors, an abundance of windows and warm lighting from wall sconces. Pictures on the walls of Phainon and the other Chrysos Heirs and people who must be his friends. His smile, his laughter caught in time. Everything is clean in a way that feels recent and rarely maintained. It’s a homey, lived in place.

Mydei washes his face, water slipping down his forearms to soak the edges of his sleeves. He runs his wet fingers through his hair, finding a stray petal, a grain of rice. His eyes are tired when he meets them in the mirror. He feels too much strange emotion. His own want like a pit in his stomach, an ache in his teeth, beneath his fingernails. He heaves a sigh and pulls off his shoes to wash his feet before he pads back to the bedroom.

One of Phainon's eyes cracks open from where he's laying in Mydei's spot. The corner of his mouth twitches at the look Mydei gives him, and then he rolls onto his side, turning his back to Mydei. "Goodnight," he says.

"HKS," Mydei murmurs. Briefly, he debates shoving Phainon out of bed. Fighting him for it. But he's tired and achy, and he knows that if they do, if he has to see the intensity in Phainon's eyes again, or worse, the laughter, he'll only drive himself insane. He doesn't really care about what side he sleeps on anyway. "Goodnight."

"You said that's an insult," Phainon says to his back when he lays down. He reaches out, one finger snagging in the fabric of Mydei's undershirt. He tugs lightly, the tickle of fabric sending a shiver down Mydei's spine. "But you almost sound affectionate when you say it." His knuckles skim the center of Mydei's back, flooding him with sensation all the way to the base of his neck.

What did I say, Mydei thinks. *What did I tell you?*

He rolls over, catches Phainon's hand as it tries to retreat. "Does silence offend you?" he asks. "Or do you simply enjoy playing with fire?"

"I..." Honest, oblivious bewilderment. The beginnings of that bruise blooming beneath Phainon's eye. He isn't even aware of his own effect. Maybe Mydei really is too patient with him.

"You already know," Mydei says, "that I want you with a vengeance.”

Phainon’s lips part. Somehow, he doesn’t blush furiously or run into the next room. He just… studies Mydei, then turns his trapped hand palm up. “That’s the first time you’ve really said

it."

"I've said it a dozen different ways by now."

"Maybe," Phainon admits. He shifts, cheek on the pillow. "But I'm a fool, remember?"

"So what?"

Their palms brush. Phainon slips his hand up Mydei's forearm, tracing a marking there with his fingertips, eyes following it. He looks like he's wanted to do that; many of Mydei's lovers do. And then his gaze snaps back up. "Maybe it means I need things spelled out for me," he starts, pausing, eyes half lidded with a lazy challenge. "Just what exactly do you feel for me, Mydeimos? If not love, then what?"

"Lust," Mydei answers, pillowing his head on his arm. With the free one he catches Phainon's again, pulling it to his chest, flat against the space where his undershirt splits deeply so it wouldn't show beneath his wedding robes. There, his heart beats. Phainon's breath hitches. "Rivalry. Frustration. Annoyance, bemusement, friendship. A modicum of respect."

Phainon's mouth twitches. He lifts an eyebrow, but his words are too shaky to give any effect to his attempt at a smirk. "Only a modicum?"

Mydei sighs. The word he barks next is a Kremnoan one.

"What?" Phainon asks helplessly.

"Equal," Mydei translates. The significance of such a thing is lost on Phainon, he knows. "Mine."

"Your equal," Phainon echoes, and as it dawns, a shiver runs through him. His fingers spread, pressed flat over the beat of Mydei's heart like he can feel it beneath bare skin. "Oh. You really… Oh."

"You fight like a dog," Mydei tells him. Dirty, he means, with tricks and vigor, but Phainon takes this as a compliment.

"Thank you."

Mydei makes a frustrated sound. "It's not—"

"I'm your equal," Phainon breathes, pushing himself up, pushing Mydei flat with that hand on his chest, staring down at him. Radiant in that way he's been since the wedding without the makeup, without the robes that make him look more like a prince than Mydei does. He looks like victory. "You can't take it back."

"You—"

Phainon kisses him, one hand on his chest, the other in the pillows.

He does it too fast and with too much pressure, clipping Mydei's lip with his teeth before he softens it, hand slipping between the folds of Mydei's shirt along his collarbone to grip his shoulder. His breath puffs in Mydei's face, and he seems to regret this as soon as he does it, swiftly pulling back with wide eyes and a parted mouth.

"I should have asked if that was okay before I did it," he says. "I apologize—"

It's with a hiss that Mydei grabs him by the shirtfront and pulls him back in, Phainon falling onto his forearms, mouth stiff and surprised before he begins to relax. He is, by all accounts, a terrible kisser, slow to react and too tentative, unwilling to fix his bad angles. Mydei slips a hand around the back of his neck, squeezing tight, moving him into a better position. His heart thunders beneath Mydei's thumb, and he makes this little sound in the back of his throat, and he— his eyes are open.

Mydei shoves him back with hands on his chest and laughs, rough and startled out of him. Phainon laughs too, and then he realizes that perhaps he should be angry, folding his legs beneath him and sputtering something out. "Are you laughing at me?" he asks, and when Mydei doesn't stop, "You really are! What a horrible, unkind husband I have. I can't believe —!"

"I'm giving you a chance to redeem yourself," Mydei says, sitting up and pulling him in again with both hands on his collar.

His mouth is still open, lips parted and wet to match Mydei's half smile. This one is better after a brief adjustment. Phainon unfreezes, remembers to kiss him back, to touch him. One hand props himself up on the bed beside Mydei’s hip, the other slips around his waist, up his chest to grip his shoulder. It’s push and pull, heat, tongue and teeth.

The fabric of Phainon’s under robe is silken. His body is hot when Mydei grabs his waist instead, drinks the sound that spills from his mouth, squeezes, pulls. Rigid muscle and soft flesh— Phainon is balance and contradiction, good and bad at this both. Mydei checks and his eyes are closed. He tastes like the charcoal he must have used to clean his teeth, feels like conquest.

His hand slips over the nape of Mydei’s neck, into his hair, nails skimming along his scalp, fingers tangling in the strands. He presses closer, kneeling, practically stretching into Mydei’s lap, firm between his hands. They part, breathe. Phainon’s teeth sink into Mydei’s bottom lip, just the right amount of pressure, a natural or not as inexperienced as he seems to be. Mydei groans into him, presses into him with greedy, long waiting fingers.

“Are you going to stop me again, Deliverer?” he wonders, mouth smearing along his cheek, grabbing him by the nape of his neck as he sucks at the point of his jaw. He feels Phainon’s breath hitch as much as he hears it, brings a mark to bloom beneath his teeth. Phainon heals fast, but not so fast that no one will see it, and who else will they conclude it belongs to but the new husband after their wedding night, after—

“I want to take a risk,” Phainon pants, “I want—” He cuts off as Mydei pushes him into the sheets, hair spread on the pillows, mouth red and spit slick. He stares, the light reflecting off his eyes, and finishes, “this.”

Mydei kisses him again, shoving a thigh between his, pressing hot and hard against him, moving to mouth at his neck, the sun devoid of its choker, the thump of a heartbeat.

"'I want you with a vengeance,'" Phainon gasps. "It— It's enough for me, in essence."

Mydei pauses. "What?" he says into skin. Phainon swallows, and he can feel it right against him.

"Husband, soldier, king." Fingers on his shoulders, gripping tight. "I'll trust us with everything."

Poetry. Mydei exhales, presses his brow into Phainon's throat.

"Don't love me, but see me as an equal." Phainon wraps Mydei's braid around his thumb and keeps going, "Because all is fair in this and war. And something about you is more than lethal. I'm with you until the end of… Nikador?"

Mydei sighs and pushes himself up, finding Phainon quite proud of himself. "Again with rhyming," he mutters. "Did you write that yourself?"

"Yes," Phainon says, lips twitching into a smile. "Just now." Phagousa's ocean in his eyes.

"Just like a dog awaiting praise," Mydei notes. "Were you expecting me to enjoy that?"

"Well… Did you?" Phainon's terrible poetry. The way he's far too proud of it. "I don't think that one was half bad, considering I came up with it on the spot. With a bit of time to workshop—"

"Just *shut up,"* Mydei tells him, one hand balling in the front of Phainon's shirt, pressing into him with half his body weight as he kisses him again. An inhale. One hand slips around Mydei's waist, Phainon settling in, parting his lips, tugging Mydei's braid between two fingers. It's maddening, the way he does that so easily, nothing to it at all, even though he knows, and he's read up on Kremnoan tradition. When Mydei tries to swat him away, their hands only end up tangled, pressed into the sheets.

"Sorry," Phainon says as they part for air. "I should've asked if that was okay too." His chin tips up and Mydei catches his mouth, kisses him and kisses him, mapping the shapes of his teeth and his tongue. A wet sound as they separate. Phainon's hips tilt up. He groans properly when Mydei rocks down against him, head falling back to expose his throat. The sun there, Mydei's burgeoning red mark. "How I'm glad you're not in armor this time."

Mydei barks a laugh. Phainon's hands slip inside his shirt, hot on his low back, encouraging as he grinds hard into Phainon's thigh.

"Is this much alright?" Mydei pants.

Planting a foot on the bed, Phainon rolls them over, pushing Mydei into the sheets to sit astride him, one hand on his abdomen, staring at the place where they meet, where Mydei's shirt rides up above his naval. Curiously, he pushes it further, palm flat, dragging up until he reaches the center of Mydei's chest. His fingers drift back down, tracing the markings on

Mydei's ribs as he rocks them together with slow, maddening pressure. Mydei can only lay there and watch, his hands on Phainon's thighs before a blue gaze flicks back up to meet his eyes. A breath. The almost pleasure of this not enough friction.

"Did you want to go further?" Phainon asks.

The heat of him, his weight pressing Mydei down. The way this memory is sure to play over and over in Mydei's head as soon as it's over. The way the last time has haunted him ever since. Phainon under Mydei, above him, inside him, around him. Mydei knows lust. Whatever this is, it's bone deep. *Equal,* he thinks, spelling out his own mistake. *Strife.* "I wasn't the one who wanted to stop before."

A parted mouth. A hand that slides slowly to his waistband. "Well, then," Phainon starts, wetting his lips as he undoes the button. He doesn't show the anxiety Mydei expected of him, just slight hesitance before he settles on his choice. Determined as he is once he decides something needs to be done. Flawless, as he is. Amphoreus' perfect vessel. He cups Mydei in his palm, firm and brave, and says, "It's our wedding night after all."

Chapter End Notes

poet Phainon so real he spits rhymes in bed

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> I'm guessing there will only be about five or so more chapters after this, but don't quote me on that.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon wakes first, which surprises him for some reason or another. He'd expected Mydei to be an early riser or a light sleeper, but even as Phainon stretches and shoves the blankets off, he doesn't stir. Just sleeps, his bare back to Phainon, side rising and falling. He's... built quite nicely. Muscled and scarless. Warm all over.

Phainon lingers a little longer, tracing the red lines of Mydei's tattoos with his eyes, getting this too strong impulse to touch the place where they converge in the dip of his spine. To press his mouth against Mydei's shoulder and work his way down. *My husband,* he thinks, studying the way Mydei's hair covers the nape of his neck. It shouldn't mean much, not when they're arranged as they are, but… *Equal,* he thinks. That clipped Kremnoan word on Mydei's tongue. *Mine.*

Heat floods south. He forces himself to get up, still a mess from last night, desperately needing to wash.

He bathes in near scalding water, scrubbing until his skin is raw and pink, improper things swirling in his head the whole while. Mydei, the feel of him. Rigid muscle and smoother than expected skin, the roughness of his voice, the near softness of his hair tangled in Phainon's fingers. The heat of his mouth, the press of his teeth, the firm lock of his legs around Phainon's hips. His breath, his grip, his tongue on the shell of Phainon's ear.

Phainon hides his face in his hands and curses once, softly. He wraps a hand around himself and feels filthy enough to make himself stop. He curses a second time, with feeling, and gets out of the bath.

When he's dry and clothed, he slips back into the bedroom. Mydei is still asleep, light spilling over his shoulder onto the sheets. Phainon looks at him and breathes, awed and almost afraid. The bone at the base of his neck, the dip of his waist, the slight protrusion of his shoulder blades. Maybe he feels Phainon's gaze on him, because he turns onto his back and mumbles something under his breath, one eye cracking open to squint at Phainon. He's… Titans, is he beautiful. This isn't what Phainon meant when he said he wanted to take a risk.

"Good morning," he says, a bubble in his throat. His voice comes out all weird. Mydei reaches up to scratch at his chest, grumbling and shutting his eyes again. On his finger, Aglaea's string glows entirely gold.

△

Festivities the day after are much more relaxed. There's music, but they aren't expected to dance until their feet fall off. The streets are still lively and decorated, but Phainon doesn't get swept up as much. He's still congratulated and pulled along for free gifts of bread and sweets and fruits, but it's more like a particularly booming market day than anything else. Phainon squints in the sun and waves at acquaintances and strangers alike, blushing at the occasional catcall. When he reaches Marmoreal Palace, he finds it bustling. Servants running back and forth carrying bundles and dragging carts of supplies. People talking, soldiers preparing. Phainon takes a breath and looks around for Aglaea.

He finds her in the courtyard, supervising a group of men running through sword forms as she talks with Castorice. He clears his throat as he approaches. Both turn to look at him, and something about the weight of their gazes unsettles him. They don't usually look at him like this. He glances down and finds his clothes in order, a hand coming up to rub at his neck, uncertain. Between the straps of his choker, he comes across a tender spot. A bruise, most likely, left by Mydei's teeth. Heat floods his face as he pushes the straps together in a futile attempt to hide it.

"Phainon," Aglaea greets him. Castorice gives a small bow.

"Lady Aglaea, Lady Castorice," Phainon says, swallowing. "Hello."

Aglaea averts her gaze from his neck. "Aren't you going to join the festivities?" she asks. "There were dancers in Marmoreal Market earlier, they put on quite a lovely performance."

"I'm sure," Phainon says. "Listen, um. About Kremnos—"

"We're sending our forces tomorrow," Aglaea says. "Three thousand men at our disposal, alongside the Kremnoans. I imagine that should be enough. Do you have any concerns?"

A breath. "No," Phainon says. "No, I just… wondered if you're coming with us." Aglaea is far more powerful than the designation of her coreflame might suggest. Romance isn't the soft thing it sounds like. In Aglaea's hands, it can be wielded for blood. That, and Phainon has never really been in charge before.

Aglaea smiles, one part regretful and one part apologetic. "I am not," she says. "I can't afford to leave Okhema to the jurisdiction of the Council of Elders alone." Her threads hum softly, and she turns to Castorice, who stands like she feels she should no longer be here. "I'm sending Castorice with you. With her help and that of your newfound husband, I have utmost faith that you will return home victorious."

"I appreciate your confidence," Phainon breathes. He's been a Chrysos Heir for a long time. The perfect vessel for divinity. A prospective hero. But all this time, all throughout the flame chase so far, he feels as though he's done nothing at all. Just worn this prophecy over his head, waiting for it to pass and garnering attention he's never felt he deserves.

Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. Bearer of the Strife coreflame. It doesn't feel right, but perhaps it's the push he needs, the proof he needs. The strings hum louder.

Aglaea sets a hand on his forearm and says, “I trust you, Phainon. You would do well to trust yourself. I think you’ll find that you won’t need me there at all.”

△

They travel to Castrum Kremnos via dromas. It's a long, slow ride. Phainon doesn't bring much, just a bag of clothes and equipment. Armor he hasn't worn in a long time and his sword, freshly cared for and sharpened by Chartonus.

The day they leave is a warm one, Kephale's sun bearing down on them, making him squint, making him sweat. There's nothing to help by way of a breeze, and Phainon doesn't even have the relief of getting to complain to someone else. He's alone on his dromas, leaning back with an arm over his face to block out the sun. He peeks out from under his wrist, finding Mydei riding beside him, too far to talk without raising his voice, but close enough to look at.

He doesn't look as disgruntled and miserable as Phainon presumably does. He's sitting straight, dressed in his golds and reds with too much skin showing, looking every bit a prince off to war. His face is expressionless and strong, red lining his eyes, hair pulled half back.

He looks regal, wears it the way Phainon wears his coat, with an intrinsic, inherent ease. He’s had little opportunity to grow up as a prince, Phainon knows, but he is one. A king in everything but name. He’s… Titans, why is Phainon the one married to him? Why not someone better equipped to stand at his side?

And yet his hair is still braided by Phainon's hand. One step back from soft. He’d asked Phainon to redo it this morning, stating tradition, grumbling something about equals and refusing to look at Phainon while he did it. The tips of his ears had been red.

Phainon remembers what the strands felt like between his fingers. The inherently Kremnoan significance of Mydei asking Phainon to do such a thing. The look of him, the feel of him, the roughness of his voice. And now Phainon is thinking about things he ought not to on the back of a dromas, in the company of thousands of marching soldiers. Mydei catches him looking and raises a brow. Phainon has the unfortunate memory of what it's like to kiss him. He lifts a hand and smiles. Mydei makes a rude gesture back, so he clasps a hand to his chest and pretends he's been stabbed. Mydei doesn't laugh, but his lips quirk.

The rest of the ride is slow and uneventful. They stop for lunch halfway, searching for shaded spots along the path to eat meat and cheese sandwiches. Grapes after, as a treat. And then they're back on the road in time to arrive before nightfall. Phainon watches the scenery for a while, makes faces at Mydei for a while, and then gives up and falls asleep. When he wakes, it's to a pebble in the face.

He jolts upright, rubbing the spot and turning to the source. Mydei, with an unimpressed stare on the next dromas over. He taps the corner of his mouth. Phainon wipes a spot of drool in the same spot and curls his lip at him. Mydei taps his head next, where it seems a chunk of Phainon's hair has chosen to stand on end. He smooths it down, then checks his clothes with mild embarrassment. He can hear Mydei laugh at this, a faint, wheezing thing, and he looks up to scowl. Mydei only points ahead.

A mile or two away is Castrum Kremnos, standing in all its golden glory. From here, at least, it doesn't look like a crumbling, war stricken country. The black tide hasn't taken the gates, and they're as resplendent as ever. Mydei's kingdom, Mydei's people. It dawns on Phainon that now they're his people too.

Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, Prince Consort of Castrum Kremnos, to be bearer of the Strife coreflame. Kephale above, that sounds strange.

He looks at Mydei again. Red and gold. *Husband, equal.* Aglaea's thread on his finger.

Crowds have gathered outside the gate, and as they get closer, their cheers are deafening. Swords clatter on shields, people shout. They chant the Kremnoan words for Nikador's virtues, Phainon recognizes them from his contests with Mydei and his warriors. A send off to battle or a homecoming. To these people, the sound of hope. Something bubbles up in Phainon's stomach. He's almost nervous. He knows what he is to these people, and while he has no doubt about his ability to do what needs to be done, to save those who need to be saved, it still makes him feel a little bit shaky to think about.

As they approach the city, Phainon makes himself sit tall, ignoring the stiffness in his body from the long ride. He smooths his hair down once more and tries to look like someone these people can trust. Someone worthy of standing beside their crown prince. They ride into the city unimpeded. Phainon waves to the people that catch his eye and feels this deeply.

You're going to be a hero, he thinks. It comes in a soft, feminine voice. *I always knew you would be.*

He dismounts, smoothing out his robes and coming to stand before the crowd inside the gates. Mydei comes up beside him, shoulder to shoulder, and lifts a hand. With that easy command, the people go quiet. Weary, weathered faces. Men and women in armor, children holding swords too big for their bodies. Tired, fighting people. Phainon commits their faces to memory and swears to himself that he won't let them down.

He listens as Mydei delivers a speech in Kremnoan. The words are sharp on his tongue, but they sound right coming from him. It isn't a beautiful language, not in the way the words are formed or the sounds used to create them, but in the way he speaks it. Like a commander, like a king. Phainon doesn't understand a word he says, but he listens raptly regardless, half certain there are stars in his eyes.

And then Mydei grabs his hand and lifts it skyward, saying something even stronger. *Equal* , he says, *mine* . The city erupts in cheers, and all Phainon can do is stare.

△

The battlefield makes Phainon's blood sing louder than it should, run hotter than it should. There's too much energy in his muscles. His sword feels too light; swinging it is almost satisfying but not quite. He carves through titankin like air, and with each body that falls his bloodlust grows. It's maddening, a feeling like an itch, pressure he can't soothe unless he cuts and breaks and destroys, but even that isn't enough. He grits his teeth and thrusts his sword and hisses as his foot gets stuck on a corpse.

Nikador's war cries drown out everything. Phainon has pressed further than the rest of the army has. They've long since left their soldiers behind. The pressure is enough to drive a man mad. He’s afraid he won't be able to stop when the battle is over.

Focus , he thinks. There are so many of them. Beside him, Mydei tears a head from shoulders, splattering himself with gold. He's almost crazed, the same as Phainon is, so much power in his furious hands. Titankin fall by the dozens. Nikador grows louder and louder until Phainon's head is throbbing and his vision tunnels. He thinks he's shouting. He sweeps his sword until his arms scream; but the pain only makes him angrier and angrier and—

There's nothing left to cut down. He stands in a sea of dead titankin, soaked in golden blood, shaking with the fury that flows through him with no outlet. *Focus* , he thinks. His hands slip on the hilt of his sword. It falls out of his grasp. He's trembling with tension. He needs—

A gauntleted fist to the face, a spiked, armored knee slamming into his side. His vision blurs, refocuses on Mydei, hair matted with blood, eyes blazing. Nikador's voice in his head. Mydei's hands on his shoulders, trying to pull him down, to slam his head into the hard plate on his thigh. Phainon crosses his forearms between Mydei’s to block the blow, gritting his teeth, seeing red.

"Fight back," Mydei growls, and he sounds furious and terrified at once. "I can't—"

Phainon doesn’t wait for him to finish talking. He slams his head into Mydei's chin and pinches the soft part on the inside of his elbow to make him let go, winding up a punch that connects hard with flesh, the impact climbing his arm into his teeth. The feedback scratches that itch, gives him the relief felling the titankin had not.

Mydei grunts and clips him in the shoulder. A second blow is blocked by his wrist. His gauntlets scrape and draw blood. There's so much of it, covering them both. Phainon’s fingers slip in it when he grabs the bare skin above Mydei’s gauntlet, smearing, leaving prints. He pushes Mydei back, making him stumble on a corpse, using the opening to kick him in the waist.

Mydei grunts and twists, recovering swiftly and coming at Phainon’s flank. He grips one of his own wrists and elbows Phainon in the jaw, making him bite his tongue and recoil. Stars dance in his vision. Blood roars in his ears and tastes metallic in his mouth. It takes a moment for his sight to clear. A few more hits. The pain makes his head start to clear too.

"Don't listen," he grits, reaching out. Mydei catches his wrists, pushing him away before he wrenches free. "It's Nikador, Mydei, don't—" He steps wrong on a titankin's hand and stumbles, snagging Mydei by the robes as he topples. He hits the ground hard, knocking the breath from him, making his head spin and those stars come back.

"I can't," Mydei is saying, and he's shaking against Phainon, hands clenched into fists, teeth gritted. He looks scared. Kephale above, he's scared of himself. Phainon is shaking too. He covers Mydei's ears with his hands and pulls him down against his chest, fingers snagging in bloodsoaked hair, pressing hard enough to drown out the noise.

"Don't listen," he says again, pushing Mydei's face against him. The spikes on Mydei's knee armor dig painfully into his inner thigh. The war cries don't stop; his hands shake with the urge to crush, the effort not to. Mydei struggles weakly against him. Teeth sink into his collarbone, but he doesn't budge, keeping his hands where they are. Just curses, just waits this out, tense and straining, head throbbing, violent energy flooding him. Mydei is too heavy against him, too hot, his hair in Phainon's face, his teeth in Phainon's clavicle, his armor near to drawing blood. Phainon can hardly breathe.

And then Mydei's hands creep to Phainon's ears too, covering them, the metal of his gauntlets almost painful. Just that, and his focus starts to come back. He breathes raggedly. Mydei's jaw releases, and his brow presses into Phainon's neck.

"Titans," Phainon pants. He stares at the sky, the too darkness of it. The top of Mydei's head, his tangled hair, gold all over. Their position hurts, but Phainon doesn't move, doesn't know if he can, crushed under this weight, exhausted as the bloodlust leaves him. He sweats in his coat. Mydei is hot as a furnace. His breath is damp. Phainon's collar bone aches with the imprints of his teeth. It's still hard to breathe. "We need ear plugs."

Mydei can't hear him, he knows that. He stays in place long enough to catch his breath, then nudges Mydei in the side with his knee. Slowly, he stirs, pushing himself up on his forearms. His hands fall away from Phainon's ears, the sound of the war cries coming back. He's too tired now, though, for them to do anything more than give him a pounding headache. Mydei is covered in blood and dirt and sweat, streaked with it. He looks just as worn as Phainon feels. His fingers snag and pull on bloodied knots in Mydei's hair as he lets his hands fall away. The pain or the sound earns a wince, and then Mydei is pushing himself up with a hand flat on Phainon's chest, winding him all over again as he stands and covers his own ears.

He studies Phainon on the ground, eyes dark, and jerks his head in the direction they came. It's a long moment before Phainon drags himself to his feet and follows, pressing the bits of cartilage in front of his ears down with blood slick hands. He knows he must look like a mess. Mydei does, but Mydei wears it with strength and purpose. He looks regal, even like this. AA warrior in every sense of the word. Phainon probably just looks like a beaten, stray dog. He stoops to lift his sword from the carnage.

His head throbs as they walk back, dragging themselves further and further from Nikador's cries, stepping over the bodies of dead titankin until they start to see the bodies of soldiers too. They're the only ones that made it this far. Nikador will be even further, their war cries stronger. Phainon worries they'll go mad.

After a safe distance, he unplugs his ears. When he wets his lips, pain pulling at his tongue, he tastes salt and iron, and spits it out. He'd wipe his face, but there isn't a clean inch of fabric on him. Mydei is the same. It's been a long time since Phainon was on a battlefield like this.

"It won't be safe to bring men here without earplugs," Phainon says. "They'll kill each other, we need... Hand signals, or something. Otherwise we can't command them."

Mydei looks at him but says nothing. He turns away, but Phainon keeps watching him. The muscle that tics in his jaw. The tension in his expression, like he's holding back from saying

or doing something. Maybe he's just sick of the war cries like Phainon is, but he seems worried about something.

"Mydei," Phainon says.

"It won't be safe to bring ordinary soldiers this far at all," Mydei tells him. "I asked for men to save people, not to condemn them all to the madness of Strife."

Phainon grabs his elbow, tacky with drying blood. They stick to each other, and Mydei looks at him again intensely, furiously. "So what, then?" Phainon asks.

"If it had been anyone else," Mydei starts. "Anyone else back there, I would have ripped them to shreds. I would've had that blood on my hands just because the voice of that titan is too… I am stronger than most. Even with earplugs and hand signals, do you really think—"

Phainon pulls him to a stop, turns so they face each other. Beaten, stray dog against dog. "You can't mean you intend to fight Nikador alone?"

"They can die," Mydei says, looking at each of Phainon's eyes in turn. "I can't. I will not ask the soldiers to go this far. Nikador's presence alone will likely be enough to drive them mad, regardless of the measures we take."

Phainon studies him. His steadfast, protective, vengeful determination. The bloodlust of an army but the compassion of a man. Perhaps these things don't exist in contrast, but because of each other. Maybe Mydei fights so others won't have to. "I'm coming with you."

"You're not."

"And what if you're the one who goes mad?" Phainon asks, perhaps impassioned more than he should be over this. They're Mydei's people, sure. This is Mydei's fight, but he's the one who asked for help. He's the one who dragged Phainon into it, who *married* him on top of it all; he can't just shove him away now. "Who's going to stop you?"

"Deliverer—"

"You married me," Phainon cuts him off, staring him down. "You're stuck with me, whether you like it or not. We fight together."

Perhaps loyalty like this is unearned. A marriage like theirs is little reason to die for someone. The favor he's been given by Mydei's people is shallow and unfounded. He owes them nothing but what's in their contract, and yet…

Mydei once told Phainon he fights like a dog. Perhaps he's right.

"Stubborn to a fault," Mydei says under his breath. "HKS."

"Only when it matters," Phainon tells him. They hold each other's gazes a little longer, and then Phainon lets go, their skin sticking with blood. He resumes walking. Behind him, Mydei catches up, then cuffs him around the head, ignoring Phainon's disgruntled noise and attempts to shove him off.

He tugs hard on Phainon’s ear before he lets go and says, “Even when it doesn’t.”

△

Castrum Kremnos doesn't have baths like Okhema does. Rather than large communal pools, bath houses are rooms with rows of individual stone basins, frequently emptied and refilled as the water gets dirty. Mydei leads the way when they return, barely stopping to grab a clean set of robes before they're storming down the halls to get to the dimly lit, humid chamber. It smells slightly medicinal from the herbal concoctions soldiers mix into the water to soothe muscle aches and injuries. The waters are not blessed by Phagousa here; Phainon too is given a sachet as he enters, despite the fact that he doesn’t intend to soak so much as simply cleanse himself.

Still, he strips and steps gingerly into the bath he adds it to, bloodied and covered in grit from sweat and dirt. His clothes lay in a filthy, torn heap on the ground. He isn't sure how salvageable they are.

Mydei grunts as he sinks into a neighboring basin, immediately beginning to scrub himself clean. He doesn't say anything. Phainon probably shouldn't watch him, but he can't help thinking.

Nikador's war cries are going to be a bigger problem than they thought. He remembers the look in Mydei's eyes, clouded by bloodlust but afraid of that. The fear in his voice as he asked Phainon to fight back. Anyone else, and Mydei would have ripped them apart. He doesn’t know how close they’d gotten to Nikador at that point, but he can only imagine it’s a dozen times worse right next to the source. Enough to bleed through any kind of ear protection. Enough to drive a man truly and honestly mad.

Mydei notices Phainon looking and narrows his eyes, spreading oil from a bottle on his arms and scraping it off with a stirgil, gathering all the blood and dirt. "What?" he asks.

Phainon purses his lips and focuses on cleaning the blood from beneath his fingernails. "Nothing," he says, and his voice comes out weird. "I just... I don't know. I'm thinking about it."

What happens if Phainon goes mad too? He doesn’t think they’re capable of honestly hurting each other. For all their rivalry, for all their sparring, they would both stop before any real injuries occurred. He’s sure of this, and yet…

"Having second thoughts, Deliverer?"

"Not a chance," Phainon says, trying to sound confident, trying to laugh. "We're in this together, husband of mine. I'm just debating how best to get you on your back if need be."

Mydei rubs his wet hands over his face, loosening the filth there. It runs down his temples in gold-brown rivulets. “Innuendo, like poetry, is not your strong suit.”

“Inn—” Phainon laughs for real this time. “That isn’t what I meant. I don’t… or, well, I *do,* but…”

Mydei sighs visibly. Phainon trails off and finds his gaze avoided in favor of wall or the floor or the edge of the bath. Mydei doesn't speak for a while. A lump forms in the back of Phainon’s throat. He takes this to be the end of the conversation. Reluctantly, he returns to his own bath, scooting forward so he can lean back and wet his hair.

Finally, Mydei speaks into the silence between them. "I suppose you should know, should the worst come to worst," he says. The drip of water as Phainon squeezes out his hair. It runs brown. "I have a weak point."

Phainon pauses, looks at him. "You... Have a weak point?" he repeats. There's a nick on his forehead. It stings from the drips spilling from his hairline, same as the scrape on his forearm from Mydei’s gauntlet. Mydei still isn't looking. Damp hair clings to the nape of his neck. The metal tip of his braid dangles where he looks down as he scrubs himself clean. Firm muscle in his arms and back. Thick red markings. Phainon should stop looking at him. He reaches for a bottle of soap, spilling some into his palm to wash his hair.

"There's no such thing as true immortality." Mydei clears his throat, a rough sound. "If... If I go mad, you'll need to be able to stop me."

He's... awkward, almost. Phainon's little finger heats. A thin gold string drapes over the edge of each bath, connecting them. It’s gold on Phainon's end too, where it hadn’t been before. For some reason, his heart gives a hard thump. "Kill you, you mean," he breathes.

"If it comes to it."

Phainon rubs the soap into his scalp, collecting grit beneath his fingernails. He wets his lips and wonders why it feels like he’s shaking. He clears his throat. “You’d trust me with that?”

A splash. “Are you planning to murder me in my sleep?”

“No,” Phainon says, all airy. He squeezes the suds out of his hair and dunks his head again, running his fingers through the strands. When he comes back up, Mydei shifts in the bath, turning so his back is to Phainon. His hair is filthy; he hasn’t washed it yet. Phainon… wants to do that for him. He doesn’t ask. “Mydei.”

“My tenth thoracic vertebra,” Mydei says, pulling his hair to the side. Somewhere in the dip of his spine, it sits.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon gasps it.

“Remember it well,” Mydei says, and his voice is carefully, artificially level. A pulse of heat through the string between them. Phainon can’t see his face. “I won’t say it again.”

To tell Phainon such a thing. His one vulnerability on an otherwise immortal body. Titans, Phainon doesn’t even know where that *is.* He’d have to count the knobs of his spine, he’d have to trace his fingers down Mydei’s vertebrae one by one until he finds it, and then he’ll know exactly how he needs to watch Mydei’s back, exactly—

“You’ll strike if need be,” Mydei says, like this is nothing, and Phainon… Phainon doesn’t think he can. It sticks in his throat. It’s like he can feel his heartbeat in their string. He won’t use this knowledge against Mydei. He can’t.

“If need be,” he gets out. “I hope you’ll do the same.”

“I will,” Mydei tells him. It comes out too softly. “So don’t go mad, Deliverer. I’d rather not have to wash your blood from my hair.”

△

Lady Aglaea,

Our first battle in Kremnos has been a success. With our numbers, pushing the titankin back has become far easier for the Kremnoan army. Casualties are low, and we’ve managed to reclaim a dozen neighborhoods. At present, our largest concern is Nikador’s war cries. They amplify and induce bloodlust in those who hear them, and the closer we get, the more they drive the soldiers mad. Earplugs work to an extent, but the soldiers can’t hear, which is a vulnerability.

We aren’t sure if many soldiers will be strong enough to control themselves in Nikador’s presence, so Mydei and I have made the decision to leave the army to battle the titankin while we handle the titan ourselves. Castorice has pledged her help; she is oddly unaffected by the titan’s cries, so she’ll be indispensable in this fight. I have no doubt we’ll reclaim the coreflame soon.

I had another question unrelated to the flame chase, perhaps one that I should have asked in person. When you tied Mydei and myself together with your threads, you mentioned the significance of it turning gold. It has, and I would like to know if I have anything to be concerned about. If you would inform me of the meaning, I would be grateful.

Best,

Phainon

Chapter End Notes

I like the thought of Mydei actually being very proud of pulling Phainon, like...
Mydei: This is My husband, My equal, look at how strong and perfect and beautiful he is
Kremnos: *loud cheering*
Phainon: ??

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

new summary same great fic or whatever it says on the orange juice carton

It takes a long time for Mydei's hair to dry, thick as it is. Hours after his bath, he picks through it with the comb Phainon gifted him. It's clean but tangled, and the knots don't want to come undone. An ache forms in his scalp where he rips at them.

He meets his own tired eyes in the mirror. Behind him, seated at the foot of Mydei's bed—their bed—is Phainon, polishing the knife he keeps at his waist. He's clean and fluffed up like a dog in the snow. Mydei pulls harder at the comb until he rips this tangle free, tossing a clump of hair on his desk.

"Okay," Phainon says, standing and setting the knife aside. He's barefoot and dressed in cottons worn soft and threadbare, chokerless, throat on proud display. Mydei's mark from their wedding night healing green and brown, stark between the rays of his sun. A cut on his forehead, a scrape on his wrist, bruises speckled here and there. The aftermath of a battle. If he were Kremnoan, Mydei might taste the triumph in each of those marks. But he isn't, so Mydei keeps those kinds of thoughts to himself.

Phainon comes up behind him and plucks the comb from between his fingers. "I don't think you can be trusted with this," he says, picking strands of hair from between the prongs.

Mydei grunts. Seated, his head comes up to Phainon's chest. They make eye contact in the mirror. "And you can?" he asks, and his voice comes out perfectly level but he curses himself for goading, for wanting Phainon to do this for him. Fingers skim the base of his throat as Phainon collects his hair back.

"Yes," he answers, and then pauses after that light brush, removing his hands and looking at Mydei through the mirror again. "If that's okay."

Please, Mydei thinks. *You don't have to ask.* He's uncomfortable with his own want. It's easy to want someone carnally, but this is something different. He has no business finding peace in Phainon's palms. They're equals in strength, not in weakness. "HKS," he says, "don't waste your time."

He can hear the sound it makes as Phainon's lips part, see the way his expression softens as he almost frowns. He's so obvious with his feelings. He holds his heart out in the open for anyone to see, to take, to crush in their fist, to gouge their fingers into. And then he huffs a breath through his nose and says, "I wouldn't be."

“Fine, then,” Mydei grunts. *Please.* Why is he so fragile? Why does he want this from Phainon? The way it felt to not be in control of himself. Anyone else and he would have ripped them apart. But Phainon is strong enough. He’s… Mydei shouldn’t finish that thought. “Suit yourself.”

“I will, then,” Phainon says, pulling all of Mydei’s hair back and beginning to work the comb through the knots. He’s far gentler than Mydei had been, starting at the bottom, holding the knotted sections so they won’t tug at his scalp. His gaze stays turned down, so Mydei has the chance to look at him. He’s softened here, almost painfully so, dressed down and brushing Mydei’s hair. The quiet side of an equal, after the bloodshed is over, when all that’s left is to pick up the pieces and clean the blood from beneath his fingernails.

Strife, Mydei could spit his heart into his palms and find it chewed like a bone tossed to a dog. He could squeeze it in his fist and leave nothing more than pulp. He thinks he can feel Phainon’s body heat behind him, but maybe that’s just his imagination.

“You have beautiful hair,” Phainon tells him. “Like… a lion’s mane, or something.”

Warmth rises to Mydei’s face. “HKS,” he grumbles, but musters little heat. Why does he want so many things? Why could he turn himself inside out with the way his skin aches?

Phainon breathes a laugh. He’s close enough that Mydei can feel it on the crown of his head. “You’ve grown quite fond of calling me that,” he notes. “Was that an inappropriate thing to say?”

He rakes Mydei’s bangs off his forehead, giving him shivers, unaware or unapologetic of the effect he has. He’s always like that. It’s like he doesn’t even *know.* Mydei is sick with the want and sick of the way Phainon doesn’t seem to notice. “You embarrass us both.”

“I’m not embarrassed, though.” A smile in his voice. Mydei can only see the edge of it in the mirror. He’s beautiful smiling. Mydei could lean back, rest his head against Phainon’s chest to look at him. Maybe Phainon would fold an arm around his shoulders. Maybe he’d brush the rest of the hair away from Mydei’s face and smile again. Fuller, warmer. His body heat fills the gaps between them. Mydei does not move, looking at his hands in his lap, the gold of their string too bright, too warm, pooling in his lap and trailing over his shoulder.

What is this? he wonders. The ache in his chest. The way he can feel each beat of his heart. The way he could close his eyes and just *stay* for a moment. When did this stop feeling like a cage? Did it ever, really?

“Perhaps you should be,” Mydei replies, because hair is an intimate thing to a Kremnoan, and Phainon knows that, but he still acts clueless.

Phainon pauses to scratch an itch, letting Mydei’s hair fall back into his face, shifting the collar of his shirt a little. Mydei blinks strands out of his eyes and notices the imprints of his teeth purpled around Phainon’s clavicle. “Did you pause to consider that maybe you just need to learn to take a compliment?” Phainon asks. “Why would it be embarrassing that I like your hair? It’s nice hair.”

He likes it, Mydei thinks, and feels like some starved, beaten creature. Begging for scraps, holding on tight enough to bruise. Healing green and brown from Mydei's mouth, purple from his teeth. Phainon's fingertips on the shells of his ears, the prongs of the comb against his scalp. *Mine,* Mydei thinks. *Husband, equal, match bound by thread.* What's wrong with him? He's tired from the battle, still sore from his injuries, that has to be it. He'll stop feeling this way in the morning.

"Shut up."

Phainon laughs. He's still smiling, Mydei can hear that, can practically *feel* the way it shapes his voice. "Somehow, when you say something like that, I get the inexplicable urge to do the exact opposite."

Through gritted, self-restraining teeth, "HKS."

Phainon's fingers curl over Mydei's bare shoulder as he leans forward to swap the comb for the metal cuff Mydei uses to secure the braid in his hair. His abdomen against Mydei's back, his chest against the back of Mydei's head. "I still think that's a pet name," he says, and doesn't step away. "At least the way you use it."

"Would you keep a hyena as a pet?" The backs of Phainon's fingers skim the underside of his chin. He's too close, all living heat and the smell of pine resin. He gathers the section of hair behind Mydei's ear to braid it upside down, his arms a cage around Mydei's head. It would be so easy to bite him again, to tilt his face down and sink his teeth into Phainon's forearm. He wants to, wants to do *something.* His skin itches with Phainon so close.

"Is that what it means?" Phainon chuckles. He fumbles horribly, braiding like this. Mydei doesn't know why he stays still, other than the way his heart roars in his ears. "Well… They're a little bit cute, aren't they?" A pause. "Did you know they give birth through their penises?"

"What?" Mydei tips his head back to glower at him.

Phainon's laughter shakes him. "The females have a fake one that they give birth through. It sounds very painful, actually. A senior at the Grove told me." He loses his hold of one of the sections of the braid, the strands tangling together and becoming unsalvageable. Mydei shoves him off and undoes it with his fingers, scowling.

"You're a fool," he says, but finds his incredulity shifting into laughter. Phainon laughs too, an easy, wheezing, unfairly contagious thing. Mydei has it memorized, has for weeks, and that's… He doesn't know. He rubs his fingers into his forehead and finds the laugh stilling in his throat. He braids his hair and turns to pull the cuff from Phainon's loose fingers, putting them face to face. He has to look up to meet Phainon's eyes. They're both silent, and Phainon's smile shifts into something softer. The fluff of his hair. He doesn't wear Mydei's braid anymore. It would be strange to ask him to, when the tradition doesn't belong to him. His hair is far too short for it anyway.

He watches Phainon's gaze fall to his mouth, feels the brush of fingertips on the outside of one parted knee. Phainon fits between them, more than close enough to touch. "Hey…"

“Do it, Deliverer,” Mydei says, tilting his head up like a challenge, and Phainon bends to kiss him.

It’s gentler than he meant it to be, just a press of lips and not teeth and tongue. Phainon’s tentative hand on the back of his neck, fingers slipping into his hair. His eyes are closed. His inhale is soft through his nose, softer through his mouth as he exhales when they separate. And then he kisses Mydei again, tilting his head just so, parting his lips, stumbling closer when Mydei tugs him in by a hand fisted in his shirt. He breathes a laugh, fits his free hand on Mydei’s hip, drawing back with half-lidded eyes before he kisses Mydei properly, licking shallowly into his mouth, fingers slipping all the way into his hair.

And yet he’s still too gentle. Mydei is used to the roughness of a spar, the way a bedding is tantamount to a battle, but in this, unlike in everything else, Phainon doesn’t bother with competition. He hadn’t much the first time either, but Mydei had written that off as inexperience. Maybe not. Maybe he’s just—

“Titans, you’re beautiful,” Phainon murmurs against him. “Did I tell you that? You’re a sight to behold at war, and here it’s like—” Mydei tries to shut him up with a kiss, but it only works for so long before Phainon’s hand on his hip slides up his ribs to his chest, pressing him lightly back. “—It’s like I’m the only one who gets to see the aftermath. My husband, my—”

“Don’t,” Mydei says before he can finish that thought, the tip of his nose brushing the side of Phainon’s, parted mouth stretching to his. They kiss, slowly, deeply. Mydei’s fist never loosens in Phainon’s shirt. Phainon holds him by the shoulder, but doesn't stop Mydei from trapping him between his thighs.

“Why can’t I say it?” he asks, too breathy, too wanting when Mydei has hardly touched him at all.

Mydei’s teeth on his lip. “You don’t know what it means.”

“I do,” Phainon protests. His hand is back on Mydei’s leg, sliding up his knee, thumb digging into his inner thigh. *“Equal,”* he says.

“Don’t,” Mydei grits.

“You called me that,” Phainon says into his mouth. Mydei’s legs part wider, he presses closer, hand winding around Mydei’s back to splay at the center of his spine, fingertips like stars for their heat. “In front of all of your people, you claimed me as that. Why can’t I use it too?”

“You don’t understand it,” Mydei insists, grabbing his arm, the back of his neck. Their foreheads press. Phainon looks at him, his mouth, and back.

“It means you're my equal,” he murmurs, and presses their lips together once, pulls back. “It means you match my strength, my weakness.” Another kiss. Mydei finds himself robbed of breath. “It means we fight together on the battlefield and off it. It means I’ll watch your back, it means I get to see you in the aftermath, to comb your hair and—”

“Shut up.”

Phainon closes his eyes and softens his hold. “I won’t say it again, if you really don’t want me to.”

No, Mydei thinks, and curses himself for it. *Say it. Please.* “Fool,” he says aloud. Fearing the wrong things. Mydei wants him with a vengeance, would claim him as his equal in front of every soul in Amphoreus if he could.

“Sorry.” Phainon laughs softly.

“It means more than you think it does,” Mydei tells him. “You can’t use it for someone who’s only a lover.”

“Then why,” Phainon starts, palm shifting an inch up Mydei’s back, “would you use it for me? If that’s all I am, if you see me as nothing more than…” He trails off.

Mydei doesn’t have an answer to that question. Phainon looks at him so intensely, searching each eye in turn, gaze dipping back to his mouth. His hair tickles Mydei’s forehead.

“Mydei,” he breathes. They kiss. He paws at Mydei’s hip.

“Don’t, Deliverer.” He’s too airy; he sounds like he wants it. He does. Titans, he does.

“Equal.” He swallows it up. Phainon presses into him, squeezing his thigh tight enough to bruise, rocking them together and making a low, starved sound. “Did I say it right?”

“HKS.” Mydei crosses his legs behind Phainon, trapping him close, cursing him when a hand winds into his hair and tugs, pulling his head back, making him bare his neck. Phainon’s mouth on his throat. The heat of him, the friction where they meet. He fists one hand in Phainon’s shirt, the other tangling in his hair, silken in his fingers, holding Phainon to him.

“Do you hate it?” Phainon asks, nosing the underside of Mydei’s jaw, breathing him in, kissing his pulse point. He’s unreasonably earnest, the insecurity bleeding into his voice in a way that makes Mydei nauseous. Sick with the thought of him worrying, sick with the words he’ll have to say to reassure him.

“No,” he grits, face hot. He twists his fingers in Phainon’s hair, pulling on it. “Does it seem like I hate it?”

A pained, breathy laugh. One of Phainon’s hands slips between them, fumbling at their waistbands. “So can I—?”

“Can you face the consequences?” Mydei pants, reaching to help him, groaning at the touch of skin on skin. Phainon wraps around them both, face pressed hard into the side of Mydei’s neck.

“Consequences?” He tries to laugh, but he’s too shaky, body tight and trembling. Mydei’s hand folds over his, and Phainon shifts to look down, to watch the way they move together. “Titans,” he breathes, more of a moan than a word.

“The consequences,” Mydei repeats, holding the back of his head, petting through his hair, arching into him, “of calling me your equal.”

“I already married you,” Phainon reminds him. “I’m already in this for life.”

The gold thread tangles between them. “We married to ally our people. You didn’t choose me.”

“Neither did you.”

“And yet,” Mydei says. *Equal,* he thinks. *Do you want this? Are you happy?*

Phainon shudders, grips them tight. His breath is hot against Mydei’s neck. “And yet.” He curses softly under his breath, and then there’s silence between them. Just the passage of air and the rhythm of their hands. A little longer; Phainon comes to completion and whispers it. *“Equal,”* he says. “Titans, Mydei.”

“Do you mean it?” Mydei asks him.

Phainon slumps against his torso, just breathing, heart thundering in his chest hard enough for Mydei to feel. He slides his fingers through Phainon’s hair. Over and over, gentler than he knew himself capable.

“I want to,” Phainon tells him. “I really do, if you’ll let me.”

“Alright.”

Phainon’s hand is sticky and slow. Mydei’s thighs twitch and clamp. He holds Phainon like a vice as he finishes too.

“I don’t know what this is,” Phainon says, trying to clean himself up. “And I’m scared, sure, but why don’t we make the best of it?”

Mydei’s cheek against his hair. He shuts his eyes and breathes. “You’re so sure, suddenly.”

“Because…” Reluctantly, Phainon pulls back. His expression is horribly, painfully open. “Who knows how much time we really have left?”

△

At night, Mydei sleeps with his back to Phainon. Strange how easily they’ve settled into sharing a bed and a space.

Mydei has long been used to sharing tents and fires with the men in the Kremnoan detachment. This isn’t much different than that, he tells himself. Phainon is just another body in proximity, and yet Mydei is aware of him like a troublesome beam of light at bedtime.

The sound of his breath, the shift in the mattress when he moves. The fact that he’s here and he’s warm and he’s a repeated source of Mydei’s pleasure.

Mydei stays still for a long time, steadying his breathing. Four counts in, four counts out. His eyes open, and he stares at the wall. Sighs, softly. Thinks of blood on his hands.

This is what my world has come to, he thinks. A war he's only half certain he can win. A husband he can't wrap his head around. An empty throne and a blood slick spear in his hands. What does he do with the people when this is all over?

The tentative touch of fingers on his back, climbing one shoulder blade, tracing the stark lines of his tattoos. He stiffens, but Phainon still wanders up until he brushes the ends of Mydei's hair, the knob at the top of his spine.

"What are you doing?"

"One," Phainon whispers. Down an inch. "Two."

Shivers. Mydei could quake the earth with them. Phainon's fingers pass over each of his vertebrae as he counts them with more breath than voice. He stops in the middle of Mydei's back and murmurs, "ten." His touch is barely more than air. "It's here, then?" he asks, and his voice is soft and weary. Sleepless, like Mydei. Worn down by the images of war, the sensations of it in his hands.

Maybe not. Maybe he just happened to stir awake, or maybe other things cause him to struggle with sleep. Mydei doesn't know him well enough to have knowledge of these things. Not yet. He comes to the realization that he doesn't really know Phainon at all.

"Yes," he admits, a lump in his throat from the vulnerability of it. "Stab me there and I will die."

Phainon's palm presses flat over the spot. Warmth in his hands. Mydei is hyper aware of it, a psychological sensitivity attuned to that spot. The mattress shifts. Phainon's brow presses against the nape of his neck as he slides closer. He yawns softly, sniffles, softened by proximity to sleep.

"I'll guard it," he whispers. Too warm, too close. There's nothing to look at but the wall. Mydei's hand fisted in the sheets. Phainon couldn't fight off a kitten right now. Perhaps that's the part that sticks. Equals in weakness, not only in strength. Phainon falls asleep, tucked close and trusting, and Mydei lays awake with a too loud heart trying to beat its way out of his chest.

△

They rally the soldiers over the next two weeks. Mydei's are long weary, but Phainon's are fresh, and it's contagious. Morale is as high as it's been since Eurypon died. The men are training with hand signals and ear plugs, and they're determined. They're ready to be heroes, every one of them.

The Kremnoans have started calling Mydei king. It gives him an odd, stomach turning sensation. He reminds them that he hasn't taken the throne, but it does little to quell the flood.

It's hot out; dry, heavy heat. Mydei watches the soldiers train in the palace's courtyard, practicing sword and spear forms. Their breathing is labored, their bodies shine with sweat. Hundreds of them, thousands of men dedicated to fighting this war at his side. Each one has a family and friends to come home to. Each one has only their life to give, and war is cruel in honoring that. Valorous death before glorious return. Many fight with the expectation of dying, with the near want of it. So little do they see the value of a life.

The Maiden of War sits on a stone bench in the courtyard under a scant amount of shade provided by a tree. Her scythe rests at her feet. A needle glints between her fingers as she works on a bundle of fabric in her lap. Her face is downturned. Her hair sways with the breeze.

Mydei approaches, and she looks up. "Lord Mydeimos," she greets, hands pausing their work. It doesn't seem to be clothing. It's bright, colorful felt. Red and blue. Eyes and a thin line for a mouth embroidered into it. A deflated... seal, perhaps. She scrunches it up and folds her hands over it.

Mydei nods to her. "Lady Castorice," he greets back. An odd silence between them. "How do you find Castrum Kremnos?"

"It's a grand city," she answers, meeting his eyes only briefly. She shifts on the bench, seeming to try to put more space between them. Mydei remembers the way she'd flinched upon almost bumping into him, and takes a step back for her comfort. He can't imagine what it would feel like to kill with only a touch. To regard your own skin as monstrous. She sighs as she notices him giving her space. "I apologize," she says.

"Don't," Mydei tells her. "I understand, but if it helps, I can't die."

She smiles slightly, sadly. "I'd rather not take my chances." One of her hands comes down to adjust her shoe, revealing blisters on her heel before she fixes it. She notices Mydei looking and answers his question before he can ask it. "I can't ride the dromases, so I walk."

"I see," Mydei says. She sits on the far edge of the bench. Slowly, he takes a seat on the opposite side, space enough for five between them. He folds his arms and watches the men train, pairs of them sparring. One thrusts his sword, another parries. Castorice returns to her sewing, and Mydei peeks out the corner of his eye to get a better look at it. Unstuffed, the fabric is loose and unshapely, but he can make up what must be a tail, a wider section for the body. A seal indeed. It's... cute. Castorice pricks her finger on the needle and brings it to her mouth.

"Are you prepared to lead them?" Mydei asks her.

"Ah..." Her hand withdraws, gold blood welling at the tip of her index finger. "I'm not much of a leader, but I will try with the help of your officers."

"They respect you."

A sigh or a huffed laugh. "They fear me."

Mydei remembers her on the battlefield. The scythe in her hands, a fitting weapon for the Servant of Death. The way she wields it is graceful, felling titankin without getting so much as a drop of ichor on her skirts. Perhaps she's feared in Okhema, but Mydei can't see his people watching her with anything but admiration. "Not mine," he says. He's caught wind of whispers from his soldiers about her. She doesn't reply.

"Why don't Nikador's cries affect you?" he asks. She hums and rethreads her needle after she has to adjust a stitch.

"I guide the dead and the dying," she says. "I don't want to be the one to create them."

The war cries amplify bloodlust, not create it. Perhaps Castorice doesn't contain a single seed of Strife to grow. "What will you do when you find Thanatos?" Mydei asks her. "When you assume their divinity?"

"I don't know," she says, shaking her head. "If I can, perhaps I'll rid the world of death."

"Without death, there is no value in life." She stills, and the set of her shoulders is tired. She's seen more bloodshed and death than Mydei can dream of. Studying her now, seeing that in her and the way she's still here to do everything she can to help, he respects her terribly.

"Perhaps," she says faintly. "And what of you? What do you intend to do when Nikador falls?"

When the bloodshed is over, and all that is left are the pieces to stitch back together. The black tide has taken so much from them. Swept land into eternal night that he doesn't know how to get back. Perhaps, after it all, Castrum Kremnos will still be lost. "I only wish to guide my people to something more peaceful," he answers. She seems to understand this.

△

Phainon wears armor today. Silver next to Mydei's gold. Smooth, shining plate on his legs and arms. His breastplate is engraved with a sun to match the one on his throat. The light glints off of him. The daylight gives him a halo as he stands at Mydei's side, a little taller because of his boots, looking every bit a prince's equal. Their men wait, straight backed, standing in neat formations, waiting for orders. They're silent and disciplined, and Mydei looks at the rows and rows of bodies, and swears to himself that they're going to win this. If not for him, for them, for their families. If not for glory, then for the right to rest.

A hand claps his back. Krateros, scarred and weathered, gives him a firm nod. He's lost vision in one eye, but his gaze is strong, and he's the closest to a father Mydei has ever had. "Are you ready, Son of Gorgo?" he asks. "Will you lead us to victory?"

Mydei holds his gaze. Nods once, firmly. "You have my word."

Krateros holds out a hand, and Mydei clasps it. He squeezes hard enough to hurt. "I'm proud of you, boy."

"Save it for when Nikador has fallen," Mydei tells him, not liking the way his throat threatens to choke. Krateros smiles, and for a moment, Mydei feels like a child again, fresh from the River of Souls and lost. Born a prince but not raised one. Wholly unprepared to lead. When this is over, Krateros will ask him to take the throne again, he knows. Mydei will have to disappoint him horribly. But it's in his destiny, isn't it? To lead Castrum Kremnos to its fall. Mydei was never meant to be king.

"After we win, then," Krateros agrees, squeezing a little harder. His gaze falls behind Mydei to Phainon, where he's begun talking to Castorice, confident and gleaming in his armor. He finally lets Mydei's hand go. "I was doubtful, at first," he says, nodding in Phainon's direction. "But you've chosen well."

"He's..." Mydei looks at him too. Watches him laugh with the sound of it memorized. Watches him smile with the sight of it imprinted on the backs of his eyelids. Watches him take half a step and make himself stumble over nothing. Castorice hops back with her eyes wide and a hand over her mouth. Mydei takes a breath and breathes it out as a tired laugh. "He's a fool," he says, "but there's nothing I can do but be drawn to him."

Krateros lays a hand on his shoulder and laughs too. "Gorgo and Eurypon were the same," he says. "Equals in everything, yet at odds in everything. You've never known anyone who matches you so well, have you?"

Phainon recovers, laughing it off. The sound of it is terribly contagious. Castorice kisses her knuckles as her eyes crinkle, as Mydei's stomach turns. "No," he admits. "He's the only one."

What an odd coincidence they are. To meet like this, to be bound like this, and still end up equals like they had done it by choice. Maybe in another life, they would have. Maybe in another life, Mydei would have chosen him over anyone else in the world. Despite his foolishness, despite the way he loves to push Mydei's buttons, despite his titansdamned *poetry,* Mydei probably would.

"Do you love him, then?"

Krateros speaks in the Kremnoan language; the word he uses for *love* is a borrowed one. Mydei looks at him, almost startled to hear it. "We don't have a word for that," he says.

"No," Krateros agrees. He gazes at the soldiers, then back at Mydei. "But you call him equal. Many would argue that it's the same."

"It's not," Mydei protests. Krateros only shrugs and pats his shoulder before letting it drop. Mydei takes a couple of breaths in silence. It prickles at him. Love. Phainon's palm at the center of his back. "I don't know what it's supposed to feel like," he says.

Krateros smiles. "And I do?" His voice is a gruff, amused thing. "No, I just thought I'd ask."

Mydei frowns and folds his arms. "Why?"

Krateros doesn't respond, just gestures vaguely and changes the subject. "They've been waiting a long time, lad. Are you ready to bring them victory?"

“Yes,” Mydei says, leaving it alone.

Krateros nods, holding his gaze. Proud of him, perhaps. “Go, then.”

So Mydei takes a breath and nods back. *Love,* he scoffs, making his way to Phainon. He’s surprised at the touch of Mydei’s hand on his shoulder, eyes wide, mouth parting. *Love.* It almost makes him angry. Mydei drags him into a kiss, hard and pressing, and shoves him off. “Are you ready, Deliverer?” he asks.

Phainon’s mouth opens, closes. He lets out a soft, stunned *uh?,* one hand lifting to his mouth before he drops it swiftly. “Yes,” he says. “Yes, I’m— Never been readier. I’m the most ready you’ve ever seen, uh…”

“HKS,” Mydei mutters. Phainon still looks lost. He meets Castorice’s wide gaze over Phainon’s shoulder, and feels his ears heat. He turns away, facing the men waiting to march. “Let’s go then.”

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

> warning for blood, violence, and what could probably classify as PTSD symptoms in this chapter. I don't think it's too explicit, but please let me know if I need to add any tags or a graphic depictions of violence warning.

They march. Mydei, Phainon, Castorice, Krateros, and the soldiers. The breeze carries the scent of people sweating under the sun. It takes them an hour to get to the battlefield, to the place where the streets divide, one side touched by sun, the other by eternal night. They halt before the divide, before the sound of Nikador's cries will become audible, before the end of this war begins.

Mydei turns to face the men. He looks at Phainon, just briefly, and the resolve in his expression is almost tangible. Phainon nods. He nods back and levels his gaze on the crowd, posture changing. His feet plant, spine straightening, head tall. Nymphs in Phainon's stomach. His palms sweat.

"Soldiers," Mydei says, voice raised. He repeats it in Kremnoan, delivering this speech in two languages. One for his people, one for Phainon's. His language is sharp and passionate, and with each phrase, he gets a shout from the Kremnoans, metal clattering as they slam swords and shields together. The sight of it, the sound, the glint of armor in the sun and the rows of determined faces. Phainon gets chills. Mydei switches languages.

"Okhemans, this may not be your homeland, but this battle is a part of your purpose." He turns, meeting the eyes of the soldiers in the front, each one in turn. "Today we fight for a purpose," he shouts. He turns to Phainon, lifting a brow in question. Phainon grins back.

"Today," he says, reaching for Mydei's wrist. "Together with the Kremnoans, we claim Nikador's coreflame!"

Mydei, "Today we save lives!"

Phainon wrenches their hands into the air, toward the sky. "Today we further the flame chase and lead us closer to the new era!"

Cheers, metal on metal. They're ready, all of them. Phainon breathes out a laugh, lets Mydei's wrist go. It's Castorice who silences them, lifting her hands. They're disciplined enough to listen. He knows she'd been worried. When she gives them the signal to put in their earplugs, they listen to that too. He watches her shoulders relax, smiles when she meets his eyes.

"Think you can kill more titankin than me?" he asks Mydei, pulling his earplugs from a pocket in his pants, wedged a bit awkwardly under his armor.

Mydei's lips quirk. "By a landslide," he says, and puts one earplug in. Phainon grins back.

"You're on," Phainon says. "Tally it up. Make sure you count correctly."

That earns him a scowl, and then they cross into the eternal night. With his ears plugged up, all Phainon can hear is his heart beating in his chest. Mydei and Castorice at his sides, the soldiers behind them. They're walking for no longer than ten minutes before they find the titankin, gathering into ranks. Their army holds. Ten bated breaths. They turn to each other and nod, and then Mydei gives the signal to charge. Phainon grips his sword and runs off his nerves. The titankin meet them in the middle.

The first kill is Mydei's. He grabs a titankin and rips its head from its shoulders, tossing the body aside as he blocks a blow from the next one, splattering himself with blood. Phainon grits his teeth and stabs one through the chest, kicking it in the abdomen to rip his blade free. Around him, the soldiers and titankin clash. Castorice fights in her own wide bubble, felling them with her scythe, neatly stepping around bodies and dodging blows. It's a wonder she doesn't make a mess of herself. The soldiers give her a wide berth.

He counts. *Two, three, five.* Golden blood coats his sword, he can hear his blood rushing in his ears, but he’s clear headed. He doesn’t crave cruelty, only sees it for the necessity that it is, and the memory of the way Nikador’s cries corrupted him makes him feel almost monstrous. The titankin aren’t people to be reasoned with, with lives and families at home, otherwise he might feel a bit monstrous now.

He kills another, and one after that. His tally goes up to eight. He doesn’t know what Mydei is at, both of them lost in the sea of bodies. A projectile nicks him in the eyebrow, making him bleed into his eye, gold swirling in his vision. He swings his sword with his body braced for the collision, lifting it again to block a blow, knowing he’s making some kind of noise but unable to hear himself. His teeth grit. He nearly takes a hit from behind before he twists and kicks hard, taking a titankin in the abdomen and slicing it in two with his sword.

Ten, he thinks. A flash of red. Mydei, bloodsoaked and burning. His expression is feral and furious, and Phainon wonders what’s going on in his head. What it feels like, to march toward your fallen god. To be the one to kill them.

He thinks of the way Kremnos reveres Nikador. The way they chant their virtues before battles and dedicate themselves to fighting for love of their god. Are they heartbroken? Or is this another trial, another war to be won? Is it betrayal they feel, or inevitability? Their kings are crowned in the blood of those before them and beloved regardless. Are their gods the same too?

Phainon’s muscles begin to burn, but he’s adept at pushing past that, breathing heavily and continuing to fight. His tally climbs to fifteen, then twenty. He swings his sword, stabs, ducks beneath blades and kicks away grabbing hands. Every body that falls is replaced by another. Sometimes his men are the ones to fall. Still, he presses forward.

It takes a long time to break through the wall of titankin, but he and Mydei do, leaving the men behind as they press further and further into the opposing forces. Phainon finds himself surrounded, but he cuts the titankin down like branches, carving out a path and keeping count. Soon, his tally climbs to fifty. His breath comes in harsh pants, but he fights, because for every monster he kills now, he keeps one of the men from having to fight it instead.

He stumbles over the rubble of ruined roads and houses, uneven, unkempt fields. He tramples laundry ripped from clotheslines and dead flowers from overturned window boxes. He finds the remains of people's livelihoods underfoot, and it's a grievous thing. He knows what it's like to watch a city burn and crumble at the seams. But this… this is terribly lonely.

Aedes Elysiae had been alight with flames. These neighborhoods of Castrum Kremnos are shrouded in darkness and ground to dust. Perhaps this is what the ashes looked like, after the fires went out.

A hand grabs his wrist, and he startles, lashing out with an elbow before he sees who it is. Mydei catches the blow before it can connect. Phainon relaxes and makes a face at him, pulling free. Mydei makes a face back, then points with his thumb to a clump of shadows in the darkness. Titankin in wait. Phainon squints to see in the dark. They go the opposite direction, Mydei pulling him along and inside of a mostly intact building. It's darker here without so much as the stars to provide light. A tiny flame bursts to life as Mydei strikes a match. Phainon watches him use it to search along the walls until he finds a sconce to steal the candles from. He lights these too, and comes back. The fires flicker on his face. He pulls out one of his earplugs and winces. Phainon hesitates, but he does too. The war cries flood his ears immediately, not as loud as they'd been the last time, but still deafening outside of a fight, still enough to make his limbs itch.

"What's the plan?" he asks, taking one of the candles when Mydei holds it out to him. It flickers rapidly against the breeze of his breath. Wax drips over the backs of his fingers. "We follow the noise," Mydei tells him. "We find Nikador, and we put an end to this." His voice is rough. There's blood on him, but his hair is miraculously clean, if tangled from wind and motion.

"And what about the titankin?" Phainon asks. They're a hindrance at the very least. A genuine threat at worst. "They're everywhere, hiding in the dark. Is this a stealth mission, or are we brute-forcing our way through?"

Mydei's lips quirk. Perhaps the war cries are getting to him, but his expression is wicked. "What's your tally at?"

Phainon smiles back. He can feel the blood in his veins, the way it starts to sing. "Fifty-six," he answers. "Yours?"

"Fifty-nine."

Three more. How had he killed three more? Phainon had been terribly fast. How had Mydei been faster? "Brute forcing, then," he says. "I'll take that as my chance to catch up. I hope you're not mixing up your numbers."

Mydei scoffs. "I can count just fine, Deliverer. You'll just have to handle watching the gap between us grow."

"Yes," Phainon agrees. "There will be a huge gap by the time we're done with this. One in my favor. Just wait, Mydeimos. You won't be so cocky when I'm the one who wins."

"Show me, then," Mydei tells him. "Follow the noise. Meet me where the god is, and we'll see who's the real winner."

△

Gradually, Phainon's eyes adjust to the dark. He isn't used to it; at first he's overly cautious as he walks, squinting into the night for fear of things he might stumble over or uneven ground. This wastes precious time, and soon he realizes that there's little hope of catching up to Mydei if he's afraid of the dark, so he presses on and keeps an eye out for titankin.

His tally is up to sixty-three before the sound of the cries grows loud enough to leak through his earplugs. It starts by making him anxious. The titankin are sparser here, most of their ranks having made their way to the battlefield, but they still lurk in the darkness. Phainon can't hear them coming. Fight or flight is a precipice, and he stands right on the edge.

His tally climbs to sixty-seven. The cries get louder. His heart in his ears gets faster. The air feels thin. He has too much energy and not enough to fight to quell it. He takes deep, slow breaths as best as he can. Tries to drown it out, tries to halt his will to fight. Mydei had suggested that as the cause. He said Nikador's cries only amplify bloodlust, not create it, so maybe if he can make himself relax he can loosen the hold it has on him.

One breath in. He imagines a smiling face and a hand ruffling through his hair. Her laughter, her promises, the sound of her voice when she sang.

A titankin breaks through the shadows. He growls and wrenches his sword up, cleaving it in two. Sixty-eight. Her blood shed. His town on fire. The feeling in his chest is enough to raze a town.

He runs, feet pounding, needing an outlet for the energy, the hopelessness, the fury, the loss. At the racket he makes, he attracts titankin like moths to flame. Six more of them fall to pieces under his sword, and then he's left, panting and blood splattered in a ring of corpses. Seventy-four. He drops his sword and covers his ears with his hands, hoping to ease the sound, the sensation.

Deep breaths. He's trembling. The titankin here did not kill his family. Castrum Kremnos is not his home. He rubs his knuckles into his brow and forces himself to calm down.

He can work with this, he thinks. For now, he needs his head, but bloodlust will be good. He'll need it. He'll need the drive, the extra strength in his bones.

Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, to be bearer of the Strife coreflame. He breathes. Can't shake that monstrous feeling. Is that what Strife feels like? Will he have to carry that with him for the rest of his days?

He squeezes his eyes shut. When he opens them again, the gold thread on his finger has manifested, stretching ahead and to the left, glowing just enough to illuminate his path. His breath stills. He stops thinking, and the feeling is gone. Slow, he bends for his sword and follows it.

He doesn't know what it means. Mydei is… what, thinking about him? In danger? Their string has appeared in proximity, when Phainon wills it to, or when his thoughts turn to Mydei more than in passing, but never like this, and he doesn't think he's ever willed Mydei's side into being.

But their strings turned gold, and Aglaea has yet to reply to him in earnest. *It would not be my place to speak on the change,* she'd written in her latest letter. *It's between you.*

He'd almost taken it for a joke, albeit a bad one, but he's still left without answers. Maybe the change in color means changes in function too. Maybe… He doesn't know. He just follows it, using the glow to find his way, focused enough that the cries that leak through his earplugs don't affect him more than a bad headache.

At the end of it, he finds Mydei covered in gold. His hands to the forearm, his clothes and armor splattered in it. His face, his hair. Their thread winds around his arm to the elbow, leading Phainon to him. He has a boot against a titankin's chest, his hands on its head as he breaks its neck and kicks the body aside.

He doesn't notice Phainon until he's left standing, chest heaving, shoving his hair out of his face. And then he turns to follow the string, finding Phainon standing there. His body makes an aborted motion, and then he stills, fists clenching at his sides.

Nikador is close, Phainon thinks. They can both feel it. As he steps closer, Mydei holds up a hand to stop him. It curls quickly into a fist, lowers as he shakes. In the light from the string, with dark adjusted vision, Phainon watches Mydei's eyes squeeze shut. He's afraid of himself again. The things he could do if he listened to the voice in his head. He needs to cut off the will to fight, to make it so there's nothing for Nikador to amplify, but how?

There's nothing left to slaughter here. Would gentleness help, or would coming closer only make it all worse?

Trust is a strange thing. Phainon takes a breath to steady his nerves and steps up to Mydei, whose eyes are still closed, unable to see or hear as he approaches. He flinches when Phainon cups his face in his hands, eyes snapping open, glinting with panic in the glow of their string. He tries to pull back, but Phainon follows, shaking his head and miming a big breath. Mydei's hands land on his waist, gauntlets scraping his plate, gripping him too tight. Shaking. A mirror of that first battle, of them on the ground.

He holds himself back, and he breathes. Phainon gives him a smile as he starts to relax. Slowly, he lets go to remove one of his own earplugs. A bit hesitant, Mydei follows suit. They both wince at the sound.

"You were right," Phainon tells him. "It only works if there's something to amplify. You just… need to not want to fight."

Mydei's laugh is rough and shaken. He'd really been scared, hadn't he? It's that monstrous feeling. The possibility that he might be capable of hurting someone he cares about. He's lucky he met Phainon for a match.

"Easier said than done," Mydei says. "I always want to fight you."

Phainon laughs too. His doesn't come out quite right either. "I'm at seventy-four," he says. "What's your tally?"

A frown. Mydei kicks the body of the broken-necked titankin again. "Seventy-four," he answers. "We tied." They share a flinch under Nikador's next cry. The ground shakes with it. "They're close," Mydei murmurs. He's gravely sober. Phainon studies him in dim gold light.

"Our string," he says. "Why did it appear?" Now, proximity and attention to it keep it manifested, but earlier? "Were you thinking of me?"

"No," Mydei says, and frowns. "I thought…" He trails off. He thinks it was Phainon's doing.

"It wasn't me," Phainon says.

Mydei shrugs. "Perhaps it knew that I needed you."

△

Nikador's divine body is in a temple, high ceilinged and grand, with stained glass windows and stone spires. It towers over everything amidst the rubble, and if Phainon were the titan gone mad, perhaps he'd hole up here too.

The earth rumbles as they approach, quakes as they pull the wide doors open. The entrance is dark and gaping, and Mydei's step only falters for a moment before he presses inside. Phainon keeps pace, not stopping to ask if he's ready, if he's worried. This has been Mydei's mission for months, since before they met. He isn't going to slow him down now. He just stays steady, careful with his footing, using the light of their thread to guide him, following the roars.

He steels himself for the battle ahead, hands curling into fists, the anticipation spiking the bloodlust, letting the cries into his head. It's all he can do to calm himself. Mydei too. But they need clear heads now more than ever. When the fighting starts, then, the fervor will help. For now, he only hopes to watch Mydei's back, to save the people. Together, he realizes, they're going to slay a god.

Mydei's hands are in fists. He's wound the thread around the length of his arm for the illumination, a dozen times around his hand so it's like he's holding a lamp. Phainon's head splits from the force of the cries. His heart pounds like nothing else. They push the doors to the main room of the temple open, and Nikador is there amidst broken and upturned pews, an altar cracked down the center, beautiful stained glass windows shattered across the floor.

There are fires lit in sconces along the walls, blazing dangerously bright, white hot at their cores. The contrast in light levels hurts Phainon's eyes, and as he squints, gripping his sword,

Nikador rises, tall enough to match three men standing on each other's heads even as they stoop, supported by the lance in their hands. They're long limbed, towering, and faceless, with a body like stone or armor or some kind of carapace. Strife, in the flesh.

Phainon cranes his head to look, ice in his veins. A deep, slow breath. He fixes his footing, hefts his sword. Mydei takes a step forward as Nikador hauls themself up with their lance, voice booming. He glances at Phainon over his shoulder, eyes steely. He nods. Phainon nods back, and together, they charge.

Nikador roars as they approach, brandishing their lance, swinging it when they come close. Mydei rolls under it, keeping his momentum as Phainon is forced to swerve. It means Mydei gets there first, slashing at the titan's leg before he has to retreat from a kick.

Phainon comes to Nikador's flank, but he's met with little success as the titan swings the butt of their lance at him. He dodges and comes back, cutting into Nikador's leg, drawing ichor before the wound seals right back up.

A careful retreat, a comeback. Seconds pass. Mydei has the same problem; they don't have the reach that they need, or the power to cause wounds of any significant scale. They're like ants with toothpicks, poking and prodding. Each time, the titan bats them away and grows angrier, calling weapons from the sky and the earth. Phainon takes a cut to the upper arm. Mydei nearly loses a hand entirely.

They need to get higher. A little bit longer, and an opportunity presents itself.

"Foothold!" Mydei shouts, spinning away from Nikador's sweeping hand. The ground shakes as Nikador calls their lances up from the earth, the floor groaning as it splits. Phainon dodges the points of two, a third catching his cloak, creating a tear. Phainon hisses as he focuses on getting closer, tucking his sword close to his side as he runs, catching the shaft of one of the lances and using it to change his course, charging the titan.

Mydei encases Nikador's foot in crystal, distracting them long enough for Phainon to stab his sword into their hip, pushing it in as far as he can. Nikador's body doesn't cut like flesh, it cuts like stone. His sword gets stuck, but that's what he wanted. Gritting his teeth, he uses it to haul himself up, scrabbling for purchase as he gets a foot on the flat of the blade, fingers finding the ridges at the titan's joints to hold on. He fights a wave of vertigo as the titan tries to shake him off. A colossal hand descends toward him, but Mydei yells and knocks it aside.

Phainon pushes himself up, clinging with sore fingers, and climbs onto Nikador's back, holding tight with his legs, slipping the knife he keeps at his waist free from its sheath. He slams it into what must be Nikador's neck savagely and yanks it back out. Ichor spills. *Please,* he thinks, and does it again. The titan screams, splitting his head from the inside out, blurring his vision as he fights the onset of numbness to *carve—*

He's thrown off, knife clattering to the ground, slamming back first into the ground. It knocks the wind from him, stars in his vision, ears ringing. Bruises. He'll have plenty of those. Fighting the nauseous, dazed feeling, he pushes himself up, wiping a tear from his eye to watch Mydei climb the broken altar and kick Phainon's sword out of the titan, slicing through

it on the way out. The spray of gold reaches all the way to Phainon on the ground, hauling himself up and seizing his knife and sword both.

As he races back into the fight, Nikador's voice booms and they run their lance through Mydei's stomach. Mydei barely stumbles back a handful of steps, hands circling the body of the weapon. As Nikador pulls it out, he falls to his knees, bleeding through his fingers over the hole in his abdomen.

He won't die from it, Phainon knows, but the feeling rips through him like watching his hometown burn all over again. A cry tears from his throat. He throws himself in front of the titan's next blow, blocking it with his sword as Mydei recovers. The weight is enough to bend him; he falls to one knee and Mydei curses him from behind.

"HKS," he grits, rough and bloody. The titan presses harder, trying to squash him. Mydei heals, stands up. "I'm fine," he says, and Phainon barely spares a glance to make sure he's out of the way before giving under the pressure and throwing himself through the gap between the titan's legs.

He expects them to turn, but they don't. They're uninterested in Phainon, focusing on Mydei, backing him up against the wall. His footing is steady. Nikador advances on him, forgetting Phainon in the moments it takes to corner their prey, lifting their lance. Mydei doesn't move, freshly healed and standing his ground amidst firelight and cracked pews. He waits, just a little longer. Phainon runs like his life depends on it—and maybe it does, maybe Mydei's does too — and reaches Nikador's back.

The lance comes down just as Mydei leaps out of the way, momentum sending him skidding and falling to his knees. The wall crumbles like nothing more than packed dirt and Phainon thrusts his sword into Nikador's leg, carving like he might hamstring the god. The sound is deafening: the roar Nikador lets out, the crash of rubble, Mydei screaming for Phainon to *move.*

Heart thundering, sight gone red, entire body thrumming with adrenaline and sheer terror, Phainon yanks his sword free and moves out of the way before the wall or the stumbling titan can crush him under their weight.

A breeze blows in from the hole in the wall where Nikador's lance tore through it like paper. Fire flickers beneath piles of stone, catching the edges of a pew and setting it alight. Nikador kneels, their leg wounded, dazed by the consequences of their own demolition. Phainon pants for breath. His hands are numb where they grip the hilt of his sword.

Mydei is on the ground, dragging himself up as a wound in his head from a rock hitting him crystallizes and heals. They need to run, Phainon knows. They need to take advantage of the time they've bought, of the titan's brief vulnerability, but his body won't move, too stubborn, too scared. He curses himself.

And then, under the rubble, there comes the sound of human suffering. Two soldiers, a third crushed under piles of stone that the first two struggle to lift. Where had they come from? Who are they and why are they *here?* But it doesn't matter; at that moment, the plan changes. Phainon is closer to them, but Mydei is running, and as he passes he pulls Phainon along too.

Nikador struggles to pull their lance free from the destroyed wall, buying them precious seconds.

Together, they lift, but the wounded soldier does not crawl out when given the chance. Breath coming fast, panic and adrenaline seizing his chest, Phainon looks down. Where the rubble had rested is a mutilated, bloody excuse for a back. This man is dead; Mydei realizes it too, because he drops the stone and stumbles back.

"Go!" he shouts to the remaining two soldiers. They're closer to boys than men, wide eyed and fearful in a way that shows that this is their first run in with a battlefield. One is Kremnoan, the other Okheman, and he wonders what they'd been thinking. Of glory, perhaps. Of helping the Chrysos Heirs in slaying a god and coming home heroes. One's arm hangs down with a dislocated shoulder. The other appears to have been gouged in the leg. It's a miracle he can stand at all.

And then Nikador shouts, furious, pulling their lance free with enough momentum to send themself stumbling. And again, Mydei roars, "Go!" But the soldiers are on the ground tearing at their ears and letting out screams like the pressure is enough to split their heads.

Sharp pain in Phainon's temples. His vision tunnels, and he doesn't know what to *do.* Nikador lumbers toward them. These boys are in no position to run. Helpless, he turns to Mydei, whose expression reminds him of the men in Aedes Elysiae, and the sensation he's flooded with isn't overwhelming bloodlust but sheer, crippling terror. The cries, it seems, amplify that too.

"Go." This time Mydei addresses him. "Take them, Deliverer."

No. A lance through his spine. His head on the ground, hair matting in a pool of liquid gold. Eyes lifeless and empty. *You're going to be a hero.* A laugh. Blood on Phainon's hands. "I can't," he says. *No. What about you?*

"You *can,"* Mydei insists, furious with him. A blood vessel has popped in his eye, darkening the white. So much screaming. So much fire, blazing on the walls and catching wooden pews and wreckage where the wall coming down sent the torches flying. A city burning down. Phainon is there, and everyone he loves is dying.

Not you too, he thinks, and watches one of the soldiers draw blood as the screaming turns to pained whimpers. *Not you too.*

A gauntleted hand grabs his face, sharp points digging into his cheeks as Mydei seizes his chin and forces him to look. Behind him, Nikador stumbles and straightens up, leaning heavily on their lance, still roaring.

"Phainon," Mydei says, and Phainon finally looks. The urgency in his eyes. The fight still there. He isn't afraid, not of this. "I can't die. They can. *Take them."*

Lives in his hands. His breath comes too fast, too shallowly. "What about you?"

Mydei's grip softens. Their thread glows hot as he forces a smile. "I'll be fine."

Phainon kisses Mydei hard, just once, just enough to cut his lip on teeth before he shoves Mydei away, letting him loose to save them. “I’ll be back!” he shouts as Mydei turns to face the enemy.

One more glance spared over a bare shoulder. Mydei grins and sets his feet. “You’d better,” he responds, and pushes off the ground into a sprint, charging Nikador before they can think to come this way.

Phainon turns away from the fight, crouching to the soldiers, maddened and still clutching their heads. “I’m sorry,” he murmurs, and strikes each in the neck, hard enough to incapacitate but not to kill. He catches their heads before they can fall, and drags each by the armpits to the exit, hauling them each through the first set of double doors and pushing them shut.

The ground shakes beneath them. The clamor of the battle inside is enough for Phainon to choke on. His head pounds with his heart. He can’t lift two men at once, but he forces himself to take turns dragging them down the hall and outside of the temple.

They’ll die if he leaves them here, bleeding out, lost in the black tide, titankin roaming and ready to kill. He’ll have to take them all the way back, but *how?* This is too slow, and every second he wastes is another Mydei has to fight alone.

With some deliberation, he tears a flag from the window of an abandoned home. It’s thick, sturdy fabric, and he cuts notches into one side with the knife at his waist so he can tie it to a plank he finds somewhere in the rubble.

One of the soldiers stirs as Phainon sets him on the flag. Pained and delirious, he accepts the handful of fabric Phainon stuffs into his hand. “Hold this,” he says, and then gestures at the other soldier, still asleep. “Make sure he doesn’t fall out.”

With that, he lifts the plank, setting it on his shoulders so he can drag both the men at once. It’s back breaking, unideal work, but he can’t find a wagon or a cart in the dark, destroyed neighborhood. Until he spots one, or until the men can walk, this is what he’ll have to work with.

One step at a time. His lungs strain. Sweat drips down his everything. Splinters dig their way into his palms. But without him, these men will die, injured and exhausted and corrupted by the sound of the war cries. Without him, Mydei’s sacrifice will be for nothing.

It rolls over and over in his head. As he stops to fight a group of titankin, it’s all that he can think about. As he picks up the plank again after, it’s all that lets him return to the rhythm of labored steps. Every bit of him burns. Is Mydei in worse pain? He heals in an instant, but Phainon knows he still feels the hurt. He can’t die, but for one spot. He’ll be careful to guard it in Phainon’s absence. Phainon will come back, and he’ll still be fighting as strong as ever, a mess of blood and sweat and dirt, but alive all the same.

Phainon grunts as he presses harder. The ground inclines just slightly, making this a dozen times harder, but he can’t afford to slow down. The soldiers are dead weight. The next time

he pauses for a fight, he steps around the corpses of titankin and checks to make sure they're still breathing.

The one with the dislocated shoulder stares at him with confused, clouded eyes. He's breathing, but blood leaks out his ears, and he doesn't respond when Phainon speaks to him. The one with the wounded leg is similar, bleary but alive. He replies in a weak voice. The fistful of fabric Phainon gave to him is still clutched in his white-knuckled hand.

He drags them all the way back to the battlefield, pausing to move the bodies of titankin and men alike out of the way to clear a path. It feels like he's been pulling them for so long that he can no longer feel the pain in his muscles, just the rubbery, mechanical sensation of strain. One foot after the other. Minutes, seconds, hours pass. He stumbles into the crowd of remaining soldiers. There, he finds Castorice kneeling, skirts tucked under her, hem blotted with blood. She has the head of a boy no more than seventeen in her lap, his body mutilated beyond repair, blooming with purple flowers as she slides her fingers over his closed eyelids. Gaze downturned, she guides the survivors in prayer.

When she's finished, she looks up from the ash in her lap, tears streaming down her cheeks, and finds Phainon. The men around her kneel, heads bowed to the dead and the dying, and somehow Phainon begins to weep too.

△

Phainon is given water and dried meat and cheese while he explains the situation to Castorice, Krateros, and a group of their highest ranking generals. The soldiers he'd dragged have been carted off to the healers, and as much as Phainon wants to race back now that his task is done, his body won't let him.

After a chance to rest, he trembles as he walks, legs weak and unsteady, feet blistered and aching, chafed all over from his plate. He can barely lift his sword, let alone swing it, and the headache that splits his head is enough to make his vision swim and his stomach turn.

He'll be of no use to Mydei like this, he knows. So for now, he nibbles on jerky and tries to be patient with his own recovery. On his finger, the string blazes gold, leading into the distance where he knows Mydei fights. Still alive, still fending off the titan.

"You need help," Castorice says. Her eyes are swollen and tearstained, hands folded in her lap.

"Ordinary soldiers can't follow," Krateros reminds them. "Just look at what happened."

She wipes her eyes with the back of one gloved hand. A gentle soul. The opposite of Strife. "I'll go," she volunteers.

"Lord Phainon is out of commission."

"I'm not!" Phainon protests, slamming a fist into his thigh. "I can fight. After a bit of rest I'll be fine. I'm not leaving them to face a god on their own. I promised Mydei I would come

back.” Silence stretches. Phainon’s face heats, but he doesn’t know what he has to be embarrassed for. Just the way they look at him.

Krateros laughs softly, but his expression is still sober. “Headstrong boy,” he sighs. “He would choose you.”

“I…”

“Phainon will see the healers and rest a bit longer, and then we will go,” Castorice says, clearing her throat. Leadership is awkward on her shoulders, but she’s trying. A lump forms again in Phainon’s throat; he’s terrified he might cry again.

“Every second we waste here,” he says, “is another that Mydei fights alone.” His hand stretches back for the hilt of his sword, needing to squeeze something, needing— He looks down. What he finds is not his sword, but a coin. Gold, emblazoned with the shape of a cat. “I…”

“It sounds like—” comes a voice. Heeled shoes come next as their owner flips delicately into their circle. She fumbles with Phainon’s sword for a moment, finding it too tall or too heavy, before she chooses to lean on it, long tail flicking, free hand adjusting the hood on her head. Cipher smiles when Phainon looks up, the points of her canine teeth sharp. She bends a little, fingers around the hilt of Phainon’s sword, her other hand folding behind her back. “—You need a messenger.”

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

warning again for violence, gore, and injury

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Child of Strife.

The lance catches him in the side, tearing through muscle and flesh, spraying ichor. Mydei catches the shaft and stumbles back. One step, two. The pain is blinding. Nikador rips the weapon free and he falls to his knees, clutching the wound as his body knits itself back together. His head throbs. He only goes through the motions on autopilot.

Fight, fall, force yourself back up. Crystal falls away to reveal untouched skin, pale and clean against the blood and dirt crusted on the rest of him. Nikador waits for him to stand, shaky on overused muscles, on fragile, freshly formed flesh. The pain stays long after the wound does. Mydei is immortal, but he isn't impervious.

One foot, then the other. He rises, tilts his head up, fixes his stance. Nikador raises their lance, shouts something the splits Mydei's ears and makes the ground rumble. Rubble falls from cracks in the ceiling. The air smells like smoke from the blazing pews set alight by fallen sconces.

Mydei dodges the titan's strike, entire body protesting every moment. The pain slows him down, the throb in his head, the way he can barely think. Energy deserts him. The war cries do nothing more than bleed his ears and make him restless. He takes another hit, this one to the thigh, cracking his armor and sending him crashing back to the ground.

Child of Strife, comes the voice again. He looks up. Again, Nikador waits. Maybe that's their Honor, to not kick an opponent while they're down. Mydei's hands curl into fists on the ground. Dirt, ash, splinters. His thigh spasms as it mends itself. Vision swimming, he undoes the straps on the broken piece of plate and pulls it off. Beneath, his pants are torn and stained with gold. Again, he stands. The titan lifts their weapon, and he charges, timing it just right, jumping in time to kick off the hilt of the lance and catch Nikador across the chest, drawing blood with his gauntlets, roaring with some kind of tired satisfaction before the titan shoves him off and sends him flying.

He hits his head on the way down, skin lacerating as he skids on the ground. He's blinded briefly, robbed of breath. Again, Nikador waits for him to rise.

Why do you fight your destiny?

An image behind his eyelids. A red, crystal throne. When he opens his eyes, it's gone. He pushes himself up. Charges despite the pain, the exhaustion, and trades a handful of blows with the titan. And again, the lance cuts through him and he falls, bruising his body on rubble, a piece of the wall cracking him straight in the forehead.

Child of Strife, the voice insists. Deep, gravelly. Nikador's voice, or the voice or whatever is inside of them.

I'm not, he thinks back, and feels them make an inquisitive sound in reply.

Laying there as he heals, he's almost tempted to stay down. He's never endured this kind of agony in his life. Not even floating down the icy River of Souls felt like this. But pain is always forgotten with time.

He thinks of the people. The villages Nikador will crush if Mydei isn't here to distract them. Slowly, he drags himself upright.

So much blood in a body. He watches his torso turn to golden gore. Slams into the wall and slumps, eyes cast down as the mess crystalizes and crumbles to reveal new flesh. He almost doesn't feel the pain. He's made of it. A little more is nothing at all.

Chosen of Strife, the voice says this time. *You are strong. Why don't you kill?*

I've killed plenty, Mydei thinks back. His spear in his father's chest. His boot against a soldier's skull. His gauntlets tearing through throat after throat. The path behind him is stained in red and gold alike.

He stumbles as he stands. Nikador strikes him down again. Stands there, looming. *A hundred deaths,* they seem to say, *how many more will it take to make you crumble?* The image of a town leveled. Bodies broken, children crying, blood pooling in the streets.

No, Mydei thinks, and catches the titan's lance before it can connect again, gritting his teeth, screaming his throat raw as he snaps the thing in half, slicing through himself for leverage in the process, falling to his knees and cradling the metal point, laughing as the titan roars and splits the sky to rain him into pulp.

It takes a long time to heal from this. As he waits, he listens to fire crackle, smells the smoke. Realizes he's burning alive amidst the pews as he smells his own cooked flesh. He drags himself on charred, torn limbs. Lays there and wants nothing more than to never get up. Still, the titan waits.

You fight to protect? The voice asks.

Yes, Mydei thinks.

The image of the throne again. Red crystal, gleaming in firelight. *Become stronger, and you can protect anything.* The sound of a laugh in his ears, wheezing and contagious, long memorized. A gold thread on his finger, still manifest and furiously glowing when he peels

his eyes open to look. His whole body is a scab. His hand twitches, and pain floods him, so he stays down a little longer.

Become stronger, the voice says again. It shows him Kremnos on fire. It shows him the men in the Kremnoan Detachment, throats slit, eyes empty, limbs broken and twisting in ways they shouldn't. It shows him Krateros with his good eye gouged from his face, choking on his own blood. It shows him the children, it shows them—

Stop, Mydei thinks. "Stop," he says it aloud, voice like sandpaper, throat sore and destroyed. Crystal flakes from him as he pushes himself to all fours, then to his feet. Everything in him screams with pain. Nikador comes at him bare handed, and he *fights.* Still, he falls, gurgling as a claw punctures his neck. He can't breathe as it turns to crystal; the healing is its own kind of agony. He chokes, asphyxiates, tears spilling down his temples as he spasms.

Protect them, the voice demands. More bloodshed. Friends, new and old, crumpled and twisted and mutilated. *You're too weak. How will you protect them?*

He gasps for breath as the crystal flakes away and allows him his lungs again. He rolls onto his knees, propped on his forearms as he spits blood and saliva to the earth. Nikador roars at him and pins him back down with one heavy hand as soon as he manages to right himself. Blood leaks out his ears at the noise. He watches his tears mix with dust as cringes away from it.

The weight of the titan fractures both legs and some of his ribs. More of the wall comes crumbling, too far to bury him, but close enough that he's hit with some of the rubble too. This next death is just as agonizing as the last. Nikador stalks off as he heals, growing bored or restless or tired of him.

Weak, the voice curses. It shows him Phainon next. His smile, and then his body broken beneath the titan's hands. *Protect this one, Chosen, or we will tear him limb from limb.*

Why? Mydei thinks. His bones scream, freshly mended, as he stands and throws himself at Nikador again, drawing blood even as he's knocked down again.

He's not strong enough yet, the voice tells him. *We don't want him, Chosen. We reject him. He is meant for other things.*

Stop calling me that.

The next death, he's crushed under rubble. He dies three more times digging himself out.

Chosen, the titan says again. He tears their arm from its socket, laughing as they screech and stumble back, finding the broken hilt of their lance and throwing it straight through his chest.

Chosen, they roar as he chokes on his own blood. *He will fail our trial, should he take it. We will break him from the inside out. He isn't strong enough, but you must be.*

No, Mydei repeats, over and over. He tears the wood out of his chest, nearly falls on his face as he waits for the wound to heal again. *No.*

Chosen of Strife, Child of Strife. Son of Gorgo to be crowned in blood, Undying Prince—

A flash of light, enough to blind him and Nikador both, the titan armless and screeching as a girl in a dress adorned with butterflies brushes past Mydei, her shin brushing his elbow, a field of flowers blooming beneath Nikador's feet, holding them in place for golden threads to bind them, tying them down, pinning them to the earth for a screaming boy with a greatsword to climb onto their shoulders and sever their head.

And then it's over, and there's a flash as the coreflame lifts from the dead, divine body, golden threads receding, flowers fading away. The ladies Tribios shut the Gate of Infinity. Castorice lowers her scythe. Aglaea clasps her hands behind her back and steps toward the fallen titan. Her hair curls around her neck. Her shoes clack softly. It's finally quiet.

Phainon falls off the back of the titan, slipping in ichor and cursing, coreflame in hand, and Mydei… Mydei is crushed with relief. His knees, aching and exhausted from holding steady, give beneath him. He crashes, graceless, and watches the heads that turn his way.

A soft tail brushes his shoulders. A gray haired girl bends to look at him, ears twitching atop her head. "That must've hurt," she says lightly.

Castorice comes next, kneeling close but not nearly close enough to touch him. "Lord Mydeimos," she says, visibly worried. "Will you be alright?"

The ladies Tribios next. "De!" one exclaims. "We'll make sure you're right as rain in no time," comes the next. "Does it hurt?" asks the last.

Aglaea watches him with careful, calculating eyes.

Behind them all, Phainon struggles to his feet, slips in blood again, and stumbles all the way to where Mydei is kneeling, rambling the whole way until he's there, crashing to his knees and looking Mydei over with more warmth and worry than he's ever had directed toward him in his life.

"Kephale above," he says, and his voice is a horribly shaky thing. He curses, and his eyes are glassy and watering with emotion. "I'm sorry," he says, fretting. His hands flutter, trying to find somewhere safe to touch like he knows the pain stays even after the wounds are long gone. He's a mess of blood and sweat and dirt, and his fingertips brush Mydei's cheek. "I wish I could've come sooner, I—"

"I'm fine," Mydei murmurs. His voice is like broken glass. He tries to address everyone, but his gaze won't stray from Phainon. So much gold. His cheek is gooey and scabbed. His hair is matted in places and fluffed up in others. So gentle, he brushes Mydei's bangs from his eyes with the hand tied with the string. Gold, until suddenly it's shot with red on his end, rapidly spreading.

"Titans," he breathes. "Are you sure, I…"

Safe, finally, in the aftermath. Mydei's entire, aching body caves. His head falls against Phainon's shoulder, too tired to care about their audience, too tired to be strong. "Deliverer,"

he says, shutting his eyes. Phainon reeks of blood and sweat. Mydei is no better. “I’m fine.”

He can feel the way Phainon shudders against him. Feel the hand that settles so lightly in his hair, not even carding through it for fear of pulling on knots. “I really wish you wouldn’t call me that,” Phainon says, so softly.

“It’s not a jab,” Mydei tells him. The words hurt, everything hurts. There isn’t a wound on him but he feels like one raw nerve, tortured and abused and beaten again and again. He lost count of how many times he would have died, were he mortal. “Not anymore. It means I believe in you.”

“I—”

“Get me home safe,” Mydei says, the last bits of strength leaving him. Out of adrenaline and exhausted, he gives his weight to Phainon, who catches him. “I’ll kill you if you don’t,” he adds, but there’s no heat behind it. He’s too weak, too…

He loses his train of thought. Forgets everything but the aches and the sensation of being lifted. His head against an armored chest. An arm around his back, another beneath his knees. He might lose consciousness. Stirs to rocking, to the sound of voices.

“You’re exhausted, Phainon.”

Heavy breathing. A thundering heart beneath his ear. When he cracks one tired eye open, a sun engraved into metal. A red and gold string. Glowing firelight. Old, uneven cobblestones, the worn facades of broken buildings. His eyes slip shut again.

“I can do this much,” someone pants. A cheek against Mydei’s bloody hair, a mouth against his forehead. “I have to do this much.”

△

He wakes slowly. A breath first. The sensation of sheets against his skin. The smell of indigo and pine.

The pain is still there, though it’s dull and aching rather than sharp. The memory of each wound still sits, even if the scars do not, and Mydei is long accustomed to hurt, to healing, but he’s never felt fragile like this. His eyes are dry and itchy when he cracks them open, crusted at the corners.

First he sees the ceiling, the window. His room in Castrum Kremnos. His crimson sheets. His gold string, glowing softly under his nose until he moves his hand and turns his head slowly, gingerly for the pain in his neck. It’s a strange gradient now, gold on his end, red on Phainon’s. The glow it emits is warm and bloody. Mydei meets Phainon’s eyes, finding him intense and unsmiling, cheek propped on his arm as he lays on his side beside him.

“Hey,” he murmurs. He has the blankets puddled around his waist, dressed down and soft, hair clean and tousled. Mydei is clean too; he notices this now. He’s dressed in some of his

own sleep clothes, hair washed and rebraided. Phainon's work. Mydei must've slept through it.

It's strange to imagine that. His own helplessness. His equal's kind hands.

His entire body still aches. "You brought me back," Mydei croaks. His voice is a frightening thing.

Phainon still stares, not smiling, not doing anything but looking. His gaze flicks between each of Mydei's eyes in turn, then to his chest, his bare hands, and back up. "Of course I did," he says. "You asked me to."

He hadn't meant it in a way to create this kind of intensity. They could have strapped him to a dromas or tossed him in a cart, but he remembers being carried. Phainon carrying him. Mydei is not small or light, and they were a long way from the healers' tent. He's almost embarrassed.

"I took the liberty of washing you too," Phainon tells him. "I figured you wouldn't want to wake covered in gore, but… forgive me if I was presumptuous."

At this, Mydei gives a rough, painful laugh. "I don't care, Deliverer," he says. "It's not like you haven't seen it all already."

Phainon's lips part and close again. His expression is complicated, serious. But even now he looks like some wet dog in the rain. "Still," he breathes, reaching out to brush away Mydei's bangs and touch the backs of two fingers to his brow.

"I can't get sick," Mydei reminds him. He reaches up to take Phainon's hand, even as his muscles protest. Red and gold. Phainon's fingers are long and thin, calloused at the joints and the palms. Mydei's thicker and shorter, fingernails squared. Strangely, his palms are softer. Phainon seems to notice this too, running his thumb over the lines on the inside of his hand, gaze dipping in that direction.

With his eyes downturned, Mydei sees the emotion in his expression. Guilt.

"I'm sorry," Phainon whispers. "I wish I could've—"

"Shut up," Mydei cuts him off. Phainon does, gives a weak laugh.

"I should've figured you wouldn't want to hear it," he says, meeting Mydei's eyes again, his still big and wet with emotion. "But still, I just… I wish I could've come back a little sooner and spared you even a little bit of the pain. My body gave out after I brought those men back to camp. I wanted to go back but I could hardly stand and—"

And yet you carried me all the way home.

"Equal," Mydei hushes him. "Your body is not immortal. You did everything I asked of you."

Phainon exhales a shuddery breath. His throat bobs as he swallows, fingers curling tighter around Mydei's. "Does it still hurt?" he asks.

"Yes," Mydei answers honestly. "But my people are alive and the titan is not. That's enough."

Phainon must see the truth in his face, because he lets this go. "Okay," he says, and quiets. He pulls Mydei's hand to his mouth and kisses the back of it, eyes sipping shut. He's beautiful when he isn't talking. The light catches his hair, his cheek. The way he's bruised and scabbed and softened in the aftermath. Mydei's husband, his equal. His teeth ache. He wants him, but he isn't sure if his body will hold out.

"Why is it red?" he asks, eyeing the string.

"I don't know," Phainon admits. "One minute I was panicking and the next it was like this."

Mydei grunts. He pulls Phainon's hand closer, unfolding it so his fingers are spread. Phainon goes quiet and watches, doesn't speak as Mydei brings his hand to his mouth and bites the place between his thumb and index finger. Not hard; he gets Phainon's knuckle where he's hoped to find flesh, but he still leaves the imprint of a tooth or two.

"Wha—?"

"Shut up," Mydei tells him, and kisses the side of his hand. Down more, the side of his wrist. Still bony, but he's able to pull skin away with his teeth, biting and letting go, moving a bit further up and sinking his teeth in again, not enough to bruise but enough to interlock a second ring with the first, then a third a bit further up. He stops there, looking at his handiwork.

"What are you doing?" Phainon asks, seeming at a loss for words. Mydei has chosen an idiot for an equal. He sighs and slides his tired body closer, pulling Phainon's arm around his back, pressing his face into his throat.

"Mydei?" Phainon says, searching. Tentatively, he settles, arm relaxing and sliding to a more comfortable spot, chin resting on Mydei's head. His heart beats so fast; Mydei laughs a little, but that hurts too, so he quiets.

"Stop thinking," he says, and sighs. Relief bows him even now. To fight for so long and wake up safe. Phainon is terribly warm; Mydei slides an arm around him, too exhausted to do anything other than *stay.* "None of it matters."

A shaky laugh. Phainon's palm covers his weak point, breath ruffling his hair. "Mydei," he says again, "we killed a *god.* That kind of matters."

Mydei grunts unhappily. "Shut up."

"The trial is in three days," Phainon tells him.

And that gives him pause. He opens his eyes to the sun on Phainon's throat, the opening in his shirt pulled awkwardly to show his collarbone. The marks from Mydei's teeth are gone from it. "Are you ready, then?" he asks. "To bear the coreflame of Strife?"

Hesitation. Phainon's thundering pulse. Mydei breathes him in, pine and exhaustion. *We don't want him, Chosen. He will fail our trial, should he take it. He isn't strong enough.*

Phainon is gentle as much as he is strong. Mydei hasn't given it much thought. Phainon as the incarnation of Strife. He just pushed that on him without thought for the consequences.

We reject him. We will break him from the inside out.

He's strong, certainly. But he isn't vengeful. Strife doesn't fit.

Suddenly, Mydei feels sick.

"I'm ready," Phainon tells him. An obvious front. His voice wavers. He presses a little firmer on Mydei's back. "I can do it."

His stomach flips and turns. He swallows around a painful lump, twists sore fingers into the fabric of Phainon's shirt. "Do you want to?" Why is this the first time he's thought to ask?

More hesitation. "I want to save people," Phainon answers. "I want…" A breath. "To be a hero. If this will help me do that, then yes. I want it. I'll do it."

△

They deliver the coreflame together after a day of rest. Phainon carries it, resolute and determined as Aglaea brings them to the Vortex of Genesis to restore it to its place. Mydei is still sore and aching just standing. It's all the way in his bones, the consequences of regeneration, so he stays back and stays still when he can, not wanting to bare his weakness to the world.

Still, Phainon hovers about him. He frets and offers little things like water and candies, and it's both amusing and aggravating. Their shoulders brush too often for it to be accidental. In reality, Phainon just stands far too close, inches closer whenever Mydei tries to put a bit of space between them.

Just like an overeager dog, Mydei thinks with both fondness and annoyance. He takes a step back and stretches an arm out to stop Phainon from following. Phainon glances at his hand, his face. Mydei raises an eyebrow, and he scrunches his nose back.

Aglaea stands before the basin with the Ladies Tribios, who pray on the waters together. Mydei turns his attention forward, to the glimmer of the water in the dark, the way the sky lights up, a constellation forming for each coreflame already recovered. The Lance of Fury's spot is empty. He lets out a breath.

Aglaea steps back. "Come forward," she says, turning to Phainon. "Return the coreflame."

Phainon meets his gaze, seeking reassurance or permission or something else, Mydei doesn't know. All he has to offer is a short nod. Phainon nods back, and then steps up to the basin, feet sending ripples through the shallow water on the floor. He exhales visibly, shoulders setting, and produces the coreflame of Strife in his cupped hands. It seems smaller than it should be. The authority of a god and the cost of Mydei's country contained easily in two

palms. It lifts from Phainon's hands as he holds it out, hovering slightly until he draws back and it drops into the water with a splash, swallowed up and sucked in. Phainon returns to his side, reaching for his wrist. This time, Mydei lets him.

The sky changes and shifts as they watch, and when the blur calms, a new constellation is lit. Nikador's voice echoes briefly in the language of the titans, and then all goes still. Aglaea turns to him, gold-green eyes unreadable. "It's been a successful cooperation, Lord Mydeimos," she says. "I believe your debt is paid in full."

She doesn't ask him again to join their cause, even if his blood runs gold like the rest of them. She turns to Phainon next. "I hope you'll be ready when the trial opens," she says. Phainon's grip tightens around his wrist.

"Believe me," he says, too lightly, "I will."

We reject him, Mydei hears in the titan's voice. *He is meant for other things.* The perfect vessel for divinity. He would be wasted on Strife. *Protect this one, Chosen, or we will tear him limb from limb.*

Crimson and gold thread. A fabricated smile. A burden like the one on Kephale's back. Still, Mydei can't bring himself to say a thing.

△

The black tide does not recede. Mydei walks through the lost pieces of his city, neighborhoods gone dark, homes reduced to rubble. The war cries have quieted. What titankin are left are few in number, but black tide creatures have begun to replace them instead.

He goes alone, fights alone with a weary, immortal body, and comes to realize that he'd been foolish to hope. Nikador's madness was a symptom, not the cause, and little by little, Castrum Kremnos will continue to fall until the flame chase is complete and brings with it a new dawn.

Tonight, his people celebrate. They cheer for their salvation, and alone in the rubble of what was once a library, Mydei allows himself to weep for them. For the loss of their livelihoods, their homes, their safety. For their failure of a prince who wants nothing less than the throne.

Later, he picks himself up and dusts himself off. As he returns home, he finds Castorice under a tree.

"Haven't you gone home yet?" he asks.

She looks up, squinting in the sun that still reaches these parts of the city. Her feet are bare, still blistered, shoes tucked neatly next to a bag filled with fabric and thread and stuffing. She's sewing another plush, a chimera this time, finished but for the embroidery she does on its face.

“No,” she says softly. “Not yet.” Her eyes are as tired as he feels; perhaps that’s why he decides to sit with her. She makes room for him, tucking her legs beneath her, giving him more space than he needs, but less than she’s likely used to.

He remembers the brush of her shin at the end of the battle. So light it could’ve just been the fabric of her dress, accidental as she came through the Gate of Infinity, but he knows it wasn’t. And yet here he is, alive and breathing.

“What about you, Lord Mydeimos?” she asks.

He’s home, and he’s tired. In the aftermath, what is he meant to do?

He extends a hand. “Lady Castorice,” he says, “during the battle, I’m fairly certain you touched me.”

Her eyes widen. “What? No, I couldn’t have, or you’d be…”

“I can’t die,” he reminds her. He gestures lightly, hand still outstretched. “May I?”

Her expression is intense, cautious. And yet, as the body yearns for comfort, she reaches out. Their fingers brush, just lightly, and she withdraws her hand, waits with bated breath. Flowers don’t bloom across his skin. He doesn’t crumble to ash. “It doesn’t hurt?” she asks. “You don’t feel like… sleeping, or…”

“No,” Mydei tells her. “It’s safe.”

Her lip trembles. She purses them and reaches out again, setting her hand properly in his. Her palm is cold and small, and when nothing happens, when he doesn’t die, she pulls away again. “Pardon,” she says, and her voice is a bit shaky. “I apologize, I…”

Small comforts. Mydei still remembers the first warm touch after dragging himself from the cold of the River of Souls. He’s so tired, still aching. She gets it, he knows. “Would it help if I hugged you?” he asks.

“No,” Castorice says, and again, the calm of her expression wavers. “I don’t think so, but I’d like it if you would anyway.”

She’s terribly small when Mydei wraps his arms around her. The first friend he’s made in a while. Her hands ball into fists at his back, clinging tight, breathing unsteady, and she lets herself weep.

Small comforts. At least Mydei can do this much. He’s a bit unpracticed as he pats her back, but she doesn’t complain.

△

Phainon is there when he comes back. He’s polishing his sword amidst Mydei’s armor stands, a cloth in hand, the blade across his lap. He pauses when Mydei returns, eyeing the way he’s a bit bloodied, but he seems to know better than to comment. As the days go by, he seems to understand Mydei better.

With a sigh, Mydei sits in the chair opposite him and begins removing his armor piece by piece. “Why don’t you return to Okhema?” he asks.

Phainon lifts his eyebrows. “And leave you here until the trial?”

Are you ready? Mydei wonders. *Do you want it? Are you strong enough?* He feels like a bruise, inside and out. “I’ll be fine,” he says.

Phainon blinks, hesitates. “It’s not like I have anything urgent to attend to there at the moment,” he says. “Unless you’d like me out of sight for the time being?”

He’s terrible at hiding his insecurity. Mydei pulls his gauntlets off. Fiddles with their string in his hands. His end is still only gold.

It means you’re in love, Aglaea told him when he asked, laughing lightly. *It doesn’t need to be anything overly complicated.*

Why wouldn’t you tell Phainon, if it’s so simple?

She’d smiled at him then, a strange, impartial smile, like everything to her is as it is to an outsider. The consequence of being a little more than human for a long time, perhaps. *Because,* she’d said. *He isn’t the one who’s afraid of it. Not anymore.*

Another word the Kremnoan language lacks. Love and fear. It seems they go hand in hand.

What of red, then?

Aglaea’s deft fingers on her embroidery. Her gaze, knowing and sharp. Mydei’s side of the string, still only gold. Gold for love. Gold for fear. Both are wretched words. *Red,* she’d said, *means Mnestia themself recognizes your devotion.*

Love. Devotion. Mydei leans his elbows on his knees and feels a little bit nauseous. “No,” he says, sick with the honesty, sick with the lack of it. Two days until the trial. Two days since Phainon’s side of the string turned red. And still, Mydei’s bones are aching. “I’d like it if you stayed.”

The clang of metal as Phainon sets his sword aside. He’s dressed down. Collar open, sleeves rolled up. Still healing, still beautiful in the aftermath. *Equal,* Mydei thinks, again and again. He could pound his own heart to mush at the look in his eyes. *Is this love? Is this what it feels like?*

“Alright,” Phainon says, rather softly. “I’ll stay, then. Until you get sick of me.”

Chapter End Notes

only one chapter left! whether you just started reading, or if you've been reading since I started this back in February, big thank you to all of you. your comments, kudos, bookmarks, subscriptions, etc. have been so kind and encouraging. thank you thank you I appreciate every one <3

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

By the time the day before the trial comes, Phainon has hardly slept. It hangs over his head like an executioner's axe, and every time he closes his eyes he's plagued with that *feeling*. The sickening, monstrous one. Bloodlust, cruelty, Strife. The mantle he's meant to take up. The trial he's meant to pass.

He lays in bed as long as he can stomach, willing some semblance of sleep to come over him, if not to escape the feeling than to at least heal and prepare his body for what lies ahead. He dozes in restless flashes, tosses and turns and lays itching when he can't, until Mydei grunts, half awakened by his movement, and traps him in his arms to keep him still.

He can't decide if it's better or worse like that. Smothered in heat, breathed on, circulation cut off, a dull pain in his back from the bruises. And yet he can hear Mydei's heartbeat, steady and slow, feel him alive and warm and safe, press a hand over the untouched, unscarred skin over his tenth thoracic vertebra and breathe in time with him.

Entry hour comes. Daylight slips through a crack in the curtains and pools across Mydei's bare shoulder blades. The muscle, the markings. He lays on his stomach with his face against Phainon's throat, dead to the world and drooling. And still, Phainon lays awake, sticking to him with sweat, nose against his hair, tracing the markings with tired fingertips. Mydei doesn't stir when Phainon pulls the sheet down with his foot so it only covers them to the hips, doesn't stir at the big breath he takes, the exhale ruffling his hair, doesn't stir when he cards his fingers through it and whispers, "Mydei."

Phainon stares at the ceiling for a moment, then looks back at Mydei. The red ends of his hair as they slip through his fingers. The sunlight on his back. Tiredly, Phainon counts vertebrae with his free hand. One, two, all the way to ten. The body above him shifts slightly. He taps the spot, earns a soft grunt. Rubs his thumb in the dip of Mydei's spine and is rewarded with teeth on the junction of his neck.

"HKS," Mydei grumbles, deep and scratchy, more asleep than awake. His hand comes up to wipe his mouth, but he leaves the wet spot on Phainon's neck, shifting slightly before settling into sleep again.

Startled, Phainon lets out a breath. His stomach flips and flips and flips. *For you,* he thinks, struck with the feeling again. One day until the trial. He's still a bit sore, still aching. Numb where Mydei lays on him. *For you, I'll do it.*

The string spirals into being, crimson with the markings on Mydei's back. Phainon realizes, for the first time since he's allowed himself to think about it, that he doesn't want this at all. This coreflame or the power that comes with it. The strength of a vengeful god. But he'll take it anyway, because Mydei needs him to.

“Mydei,” Phainon whispers again. There’s no reply. What a perfect time it would be to tell Mydei he loves him. While he’s asleep and soft enough not to hold it against him. When he won’t even know Phainon said it at all.

He holds his tongue and swallows it down as his stomach demands breakfast. Already having given up on the prospect of sleep, Phainon tries to shift. Mydei makes no move to help, dead weight as Phainon tries to squirm out from under him. Unhappily, he even mumbles, “Stop moving.”

“I’m famished, Your Highness,” Phainon tells him, squirming some more. “This mortal one needs sustenance.”

Mydei mutters something incomprehensible and rolls off, turning his back. Phainon gives a weak laugh and aches. Pins and needles flood his arm, his leg. A sweat damp spot on his shirt cools in the air.

“Would you care to join me?” he asks. A grunt. This time, all Phainon does is watch him, waiting for enough feeling to return to move. When it does, he ducks to kiss Mydei’s shoulder. “Later, then,” he murmurs. “Sleep well, Mydeimos.” And then he stands, heart beating, limping his way to the closet to dress, slipping from their rooms to find something to eat.

△

He meets Castorice over a bowl of yogurt, penning something onto a sheet of paper, her cheek in her hand, hair piled in her lap so it won’t brush the floor. He sits across from her at the table and smiles when she looks up. “Writing reports?” he asks. She blinks.

“Ah…” She straightens up and pulls the paper closer to her. “No… Pardon, Lord Phainon, it’s poetry.”

“Poetry?” he asks. “You write?”

She looks embarrassed at the attention. “I do,” she admits. “Just from time to time. It’s not any good…”

“I dabble a bit myself,” Phainon tells her, stirring fruit and honey into his breakfast. “What do you write about?”

“Just… poems.” She places her arm atop the words she’s written to hide them, though Phainon wasn’t planning on snooping. Tentatively, she asks him as well, “What about you?”

He laughs, a bit awkward, embarrassed now that he thinks about it. “Mydei, mostly. It’s, um. It started as a joke and I’m awful at it, actually, but I’m a bit fond of the ones I’ve written.”

Slowly, Castorice nods. Wordless, she takes a blank page from her notepad and slides it with a pen to the middle of the table, then removes her hands. “Would you like to write something now?” she asks.

He wonders if she can see the dark circles under his eyes. Exhausted, afraid, in love, perhaps he's in exactly the right state to produce a masterpiece. He takes the pen and paper. "Sure," he says, spooning a bite into his mouth and turning his gaze to the empty white of the page. The possibility of it intimidates him. Every other time he's written, it's been tacked on to the end of a letter with the express purpose of serving as an annoyance.

He glances up. Hesitantly, Castorice returns to her own work, writing a couple more words before she pauses and meets his gaze. He can't read her poem from this angle. She looks like she wants to cover it again anyway, but she doesn't, and Phainon finds that an olive branch.

"It's different," Phainon explains, "if I'm trying to write something that's actually good."

Castorice hums, nodding. "Then don't," she tells him. "The more you worry about it, the worse it'll be. Just write whatever."

Like all things, overthinking doesn't help, and yet Phainon can't stop. He takes a breath, exhales a laugh. "You're right," he says, turning back to the paper. "I shouldn't care so much."

Laughing soldiers pass them, speaking in Kremnoan and dressed down before their training, holding bowls or plates and searching for a place to sit. They salute to him when they see him looking. It gives him an odd feeling. He's the husband to their crown prince, the successor to their god, and he doesn't even speak their language.

Back to the page, still blank. Titans, why does he care so much? Another one for Mydei will do, something he'll love and hate in equal measure. Something he'll berate Phainon for as he hides a smile. A little cheesy, romantic in a way that will make him gag. He writes a few lines and pauses. Castorice looks at him.

"Did you figure it out?" she asks.

"I suppose," he tells her, and reads it out. *"You're terribly unfair / with blood in your hair / Gauntlets of gold, a string half red / I'd tell you I love you, but you'd have my head."*

She smiles slightly. "Is it for him then? Lord Mydeimos?" He nods, and she suggests gently, "you might consider not making everything rhyme, just to vary the flow."

He chuckles, watches another group of soldiers go by. It's warm in Castrum Kremnos, lit with day and firelight. He isn't a fan of the smell of indigo, but he's getting used to it. Settling into this second home. "You know," he says, rubbing at the ache in his temples. "Mydei said the same thing."

"Oh…" she says, and doesn't seem to know what to add.

He taps the pen on the table, sets it down in exchange for his spoon. "I'll try it," he tells her. "Maybe rearrange a few things." A few more lines. What does it matter, why does it matter? He's tired enough to stop thinking so much, heavy enough with worry for other things to spare room for worry about this.

The next time he reaches for his spoon, all he finds is another gold coin. He sighs and turns it in his fingers as Cipher takes a seat on top of the table, feet on a chair, taking a bite of his yogurt and making a face. She passes the bowl back, and in an instant, the coin is gone.

“Since when do you have a sweet tooth?” she asks, licking her teeth, tucking the coin in her pocket.

“I…” He doesn’t really, but he had made the yogurt overly sweet, hadn’t he?

“Lady Cifera,” Castorice greets her.

Cipher’s tail flicks against the table, setting a rhythm. “So formal,” she says with distaste. “Weren’t you supposed to leave with Aglaea and Tribios?”

“No, I…” Castorice clears her throat. “I was hoping to find you, actually.”

“Little old me?” Cipher’s eyes widen. She sets a hand on the table and leans her weight into it. “And what, pray tell, do you need with me?”

“Passage,” Castorice says. Her gaze flicks hesitantly to Phainon, then back to Cipher. “To Styxia.”

A slight smile. “And why would you want to go there?”

Castorice swallows. “Professor Anaxa has good reason to believe Thanatos rests there,” she answers. It’s the first Phainon has heard of it. His mouth drops open. “It’s the first real lead I’ve had in a century.”

“Very well,” Cipher says. “And what can you offer me in return?”

“I… I have savings. Not much, but I…”

“Deal,” Cipher says, and hops off the table. She walks a lap around, lightly brushing Phainon as she passes, coming to Castorice’s side. “This sounds interesting. Don’t bleed yourself dry for me, how about… ninety percent?”

“Cipher,” Phainon chides. Castorice looks at him helplessly.

Cipher pouts. “Fine, fine. Eighty, then.” At his expression, she sighs. “Sixty, take it or leave it.”

“I…” Castorice hesitates. “I accept.”

“Tomorrow, then?” Cipher asks. “I’m eager to get out of this place. So grand and for what? There’s barely anything to steal.” She twists something in her fingers. A ring, flashing gold. Phainon frowns, slips a hand in his pocket.

“Yes,” Castorice says. “Tomorrow is fine. I’ll… yes.”

Another coin. Phainon pulls it out, and as the cat engraved on it glimmers in the light, his stomach sinks with dread. “Cipher,” he says, standing, a bit shaky.

“Tomorrow,” she says, nodding. Again, she turns the ring over, studying the signet. “Say, where did you find this?” she asks, turning to Phainon. “It looks valuable. Gorgo’s?”

“Give that back,” Phainon says, voice shaking. She smiles, and the dread fills him to the brim.

“I consider myself a bit of an expert on treasures, you know,” she says, slipping the ring onto each of her fingers only to find it too big for all but her thumb. Even then, it’s loose enough to spin. She holds out her hand to study it, and he considers his options. A fight? No, she’s far faster than him, far more clever, imbued with the power of Trickery. She’ll want a price for it, or a game, and Phainon—

“This one, if it is what I think it is, was supposed to be lost to the River of Souls.” She pulls it off her finger, studies it some more, and he’s so nervous he’s sick with it. Castorice stirs uncomfortably.

“Cipher,” she says gently, “perhaps you should give that back.”

Cipher ignores her, ignores them both. “It’s for him, isn’t it?” she asks. “Did you take a dip just to find it?”

“I went through a lot of trouble,” Phainon says carefully.

“Oh,” she says, and walks another slow lap around the table. “I never did say congratulations, by the way. You seem happy. It’s cute.” She stops in front of him and holds her hand out. When he doesn’t react, she lifts her eyebrows expectantly. “Don’t you want this back?”

More than half certain it’ll be a trick, Phainon holds out a hand. Cipher drops the ring into it and tucks some hair behind her ear. “Good luck with the trial,” she says. “I’d offer some advice, but I doubt Strife is anything like Trickery.”

Phainon curls his fingers tightly around the ring, runs his thumb over the shape of the Lance of Fury just to be certain. But it’s the real thing, and Cipher had given it back without a price. He studies her, wonders briefly if she cares a little more than she lets on. “Thank you,” he says, swallowing. “For, well. Everything.”

She smiles a little, an earnest one, a real one, and straightens up. “Yeah, yeah,” she says, and turns, tail flicking him lightly. “I’ll see you, maybe. Depends.” As she starts walking, she pauses briefly, glancing at Castorice. “Tomorrow,” she sing-songs. “Action hour. Don’t forget.”

Wordless, Castorice nods.

△

Phainon walks about after he finishes his breakfast. He pokes around in parts of the palace he’s never seen before; the armory, the library, what might be a ballroom but is more likely an

indoor arena. It's not as bright and lively as Okhema, but the atmosphere is still warm, still welcoming, still easy enough to grow a fondness for.

He gets smiled at, cried at, bowed at, spoken to in broken common tongue and helpless Kremnoan. They call him King, or King's One, or some Kremnoan word used to refer to the equal of someone they respect. It's strange because he's Prince Consort at best, unless the hierarchy here works differently, and Mydei hasn't even taken the throne yet.

But somehow he's become beloved to these people. Face after face, stranger after stranger, loving him for more than just helping them win the war, but something else too, something he can't put a name to.

The Kremnoans are warm, so much warmer than their reputation suggests. The more of them he talks to, welcoming and human, the less he wants to take the place of their god.

He winds up in the infirmary, though he has no business there himself. His wounds are all on track to healing already, bruises turning green and brown, cuts scabbed over. He'll have a few new scars, but he heals fast.

Inside he finds healers and patients both. Two young soldiers, one with his arm in a sling, the other with his leg wrapped and bulky, propped on a stack of pillows.

"My Lord," the one with the hurt leg says, sounding startled as he attempts a bow from his seat. He shakes the other to get his attention, gesturing slightly. The one with the wounded arm blinks, and then recognition blooms in his eyes and he stands up to bow properly, but doesn't speak.

They're both thin, Phainon notices. Stinking of healer's herbs, tired-eyed. Scabs around their ears, bruises on exposed flesh. "I… apologize," Phainon says. "I never asked your names. Is your recovery coming well?"

The one with the hurt leg rushes to nod. "Yes, Lord. Recovery is coming just fine. I'm called Ermis, and that's Aeson. Forgive him, he… lost his hearing in the battle."

Aeson's hands twitch. He looks between them but doesn't seem to follow along. Phainon remembers blood leaking from his ears. "Oh," he says, and curses himself for having nothing better to say. They're alive, he thinks. At least they're alive, at least it hadn't meant nothing to drag them all the way here, to leave Mydei to fight alone. But they seem so tired, so worn and weary, so sad.

It's like that, though. They lost the other man that got crushed under the rubble. One lost his hearing. They're both hospital bound for at least another week, and that does things to a man, Phainon knows it does. War is a terrible thing.

After a too long moment, Aeson decides to speak, voice scratchy from disuse, a little bit quiet like he's afraid deafness will make him speak too loud. "We're grateful to you, Lord Phainon," he says. "Sorry too."

Phainon looks at Ermis, a helpless lump forming in his throat. “We wanted to help,” Ermis says a bit awkwardly, shrugging. “But instead we made things much harder for you and Lord Mydeimos. So we’re sorry.” Bone deep shame in their words, their expressions. Ermis appears Okheman, Aeson Kremnoan. He knows how they speak of victory and loss. *Valorous death before glorious return.* Phainon doesn’t know if there are words he can say to make it better.

In a way, he is angry with them. Mydei’s suffering could be traced back, blamed on their presence. But it’s pointless, isn’t it? Pointing fingers. In the end, they’re suffering too.

“I’m just glad you survived,” he says, and tries to smile at them both. So much weight. He’s so tired. “It’s okay.”

Outside, he has to sit. Has to breathe, leaning his elbows into his knees and staring at the dirt for a while. Time passes. He takes the folded up poem from before and the pen Castorice let him keep, and writes out the last few lines.

△

Mydei is gone when he comes back. The bed unmade, the curtains pulled open to spill light on everything. Phainon sits for a while, pulling off his shoes, rubbing his aching feet. One more day of freedom. He wants it to feel like it, but instead he’s already in the process of chaining himself down.

For you, he thinks, turning paper over in his hands, worn after half a day in his pocket, creases soft. That monstrous feeling, will it live inside him? Will he spend the rest of his days with too much power, itching for a fight? He doesn’t know what divinity feels like. He supposes he’ll find out.

After a long while, he stands up, tosses the poem somewhere Mydei might find it, and resigns himself to a long, long bath.

△

Gauntlets of gold, a string half red

I’d tell you I love you, but you’d have my head

Foolishly brave or maybe I’m

Bravely foolish

Fearing the wrong things

Counting with fingers down your back

Words, language, love I’ve yet to unpack

Strength and weakness are nothing but dust

Blood, sweat, dirt in your hair

The scent of rust

All's unfair in

This and war

△

When he comes out in a towel to dress, Mydei is there, splitting a pomegranate with a knife, peeling back white membrane to pluck the seeds out and into a bowl. "Your back," he says as Phainon turns away from him to dress.

There's a landscape of bruises there, Phainon knows, from when he'd fallen from Nikador's shoulders. He hasn't seen them, but he's prodded them with his fingers and felt the discomfort when trying to find a way to lay down at night. "Haven't you seen them?" he asks. The soft sound as seeds patter into the bowl.

"No," Mydei says. He doesn't ask if it hurts, doesn't say anything else. There's still daylight. Phainon slips into a pair of trousers and a loose, high-necked, long-sleeved shirt, and goes to sit with him.

Red-stained fingers. The crack as Mydei breaks the shell of the pomegranate to get to a new section of fruit. He pushes the bowl across his desk toward Phainon.

"Thanks," Phainon says, taking a couple of seeds, cool and damp with juice, crisp and sweet when he passes them into his mouth. He watches Mydei work, peeling away the white bits, using his thumb to unstick a dozen seeds at once. His hand stretches out to empty a palm full of them into the bowl, eyes not lifting, not saying anything. His braid dangles, head tipped down, a section of hair escaping from behind his ear.

"You're beautiful," Phainon tells him.

Without a beat, without a reaction, Mydei replies, "You should shut up."

Phainon laughs and takes a small handful of pomegranate, sliding the bowl back to Mydei, who barely spares it a glance, just depositing more seeds into it. "Impervious to my charms, I see," Phainon says, smiling a little. The bath helped. His body is tired in a relaxed way, rather than weary. But his heart still throbs, still crawls up his throat and sits under his tongue like it wants to fall out.

"I'm busy," Mydei tells him, and drops another empty third of the rind to the desk. He's made a mess there, but he doesn't bother with it now. Just works on the last section with pink stained hands and squared fingernails, and pushes the bowl back in Phainon's direction.

Phainon eyes it, breaks the skin of a seed with his teeth. "You haven't had any," he notes. Not even a seed or two as he plucks them from the fruit. Just puts them all in this bowl and gives it to Phainon. Mydei grunts. Glances at him briefly. "You're awfully romantic, you know?"

Now, a glare. “I’m sitting here, telling you to shut up when you call me beautiful. What part of that is romantic?”

Phainon smiles. “You’re opening a pomegranate for me,” he says, and Mydei just looks at him like he doesn’t get it at all. But he does. He’s the one doing it. He’s the one that holds doors open without even realizing.

He plucks the last few seeds and eats them for himself, like that’s spite, like that’s vengeance, and as he cleans up the pieces of rind he’d left on the desk, Phainon watches, and Phainon feels. *Titans,* he thinks. *This really is what love feels like, isn’t it?*

“There’s no word for romance in the Kremnoan language,” Mydei tells him, wiping his fingers clean on a cloth as Phainon watches, cheek propped on his fist, pomegranate on his tongue.

“I’ve accepted all of your Kremnoan things,” he finally says. “Isn’t it only fair for you to let me have this much?”

Mydei’s expression is strange, unreadable but only because Phainon hasn’t had the chance to see it like this before. He doesn’t say anything, just pulls the bowl so it sits evenly between them and takes a couple of seeds. A handful of moments pass in silence.

“Deliverer—”

“I want to learn your language,” Phainon begins. “Would you teach me? I don’t know where to start.”

Mydei stares, stares, stares. “It’s not an easy language,” he finally says. “It’s abstract and doesn’t always follow its own rules.”

“Still,” Phainon says. “Please.”

A pause, a beat, a breath. “Okay,” Mydei agrees. “I’ll teach you.”

△

They ride dromases back to Okhema, though they’re on the same one this time. Phainon feels like a little thing curled inside a too big body. He puts his head on Mydei’s shoulder and finds himself surprised when he’s allowed, when Mydei even winds an arm around his waist to make it more comfortable.

“I read your poem,” he says, and Phainon could shrivel to ash. “That’s what I was going to say earlier.”

“Oh?” Phainon tries, not lifting his head because he doesn’t want to see Mydei’s face, because he doesn’t want to feel real right now. He likes the dying sun on his face, in his lap. He likes the warmth against him, the unpleasant stick of their skin. He knows what he’s marching toward, and he’s resigned himself to it. *For you,* he thinks, and slides his fingers down Mydei’s inseam to his armored knee, resting his hand there. This piece is new, though it matches the rest. He’d broken the old plate in the fight with Nikador.

“It.” Mydei clears his throat. “It was better than the rest of them, but you still have a lot of room for improvement.”

“I know,” Phainon tells him.

“You were right,” Mydei adds, a bit strained. His gauntleted fingers twitch on Phainon’s waist.

“As I tend to be. But what about?”

“I’ve been unfair to you.”

Now, Phainon tilts his head to looks at him. The tense of his jaw, the flushed tint to the shell of his ear. He sighs and settles again, pressing the pads of his fingers softly into the spikes on Mydei’s knee armor, testing the sharpness. “How so?” he asks.

“You let me call you *equal* and treat you as a Kremnoan would, but when it comes to other things, *your* things… I haven’t been quite as accepting.”

Phainon laughs a little. “Is this about that one line… *I’d tell you I love you, but you’d have my head?”* he asks. Mydei stiffens slightly. “So it is.”

Mydei pulls his hand away from his knee, moving it a little higher up, grumbling something like, “You’re going to cut yourself.” Phainon laughs again, wishes he could just stay in this, on the back of a dromas, laughing, leaning against his husband, his equal. Mydei goes quiet. Finally, when Phainon does too, he asks, “Did you mean it?”

“Mean…?” Phainon prompts, skimming his fingers up the inside of Mydei’s thigh until he’s stopped again, Mydei’s fingers curling around his and staying, trapping his in place.

“Love,” Mydei grunts. “You mentioned it a few times in the poem. Are you…?”

“Am I in love with you, you’re asking.” Phainon hums softly. Briefly pictures Mydei throwing him off the back of the dromas in a fit of rage. Chuckles, and tells perhaps the most unconvincing lie of his life. “Probably.”

“Probably?”

“Didn’t I say I’ve yet to unpack it?” But he has. He’s turned it over in his head again and again. The way it felt to leave Mydei to fight alone. The way it felt to come back to him, to carry him home, to lay with him until he woke up. The way it feels to be trusted enough to trace fingers down his spine, to hold him and bring him pleasure. The way it feels to be called his equal, to fight by his side and pick up the pieces together in the aftermath. That’s love, isn’t it? They just have different names for it.

“Phainon.”

“Oh, the real name,” Phainon says, pretending to shudder. When Mydei hisses, he goes quiet. “You don’t like the word *love,* do you?”

“I don’t know what it *means,”* Mydei says. “But if you—”

“I think it’s like being *equals,”* Phainon tells him. “I still don’t think I’m saying that right, but… from what you’ve said, what you’ve shown me, I think they’re pretty similar. Love is… softer, maybe, but similar.”

“Softer,” Mydei repeats. “So do you…?”

“Love you?” Phainon fills in. He swallows his beating heart. Shapes the dread in his stomach into something steadier. *For you,* he thinks, a little more okay with it this time, a little readier. That monstrous feeling is nothing next to this. “Yes, I believe I do.”

Silence.

“I don’t mind if you don’t say it back,” Phainon says. Mydei’s hand is still curled around his, strings tangling, red and gold. The world drags by slowly on the way to Okhema. One more night’s rest, and then the trial, and then his destiny. He can do this much. “I know it doesn’t mean the same thing for you as it does for me.”

“I asked Lady Aglaea what it means when the strings change color,” Mydei says slowly.

“And she told *you?”*

“Shut up and listen,” Mydei chides. He swallows thick enough for Phainon to hear it. “She said that gold means you’re in love. Red is… devotion.”

Phainon looks at the red around his own finger. Red like the blood of mortals. Red like the ends of Mydei’s hair. His stomach flips, flips, flips. *I really would do anything for you, and here’s the proof.* “So I’m much more invested in this relationship than you are. How embarrassing for me.”

“HKS,” Mydei says, and shakes him off. Phainon laughs weakly. “I’m trying to say that if what she said is true… then I must— I—”

Gold. Mydei’s clenched fist. “You love me.”

Mydei looks at him. Flushed with frustration or embarrassment. “I guess so,” he says, and Phainon can do nothing more than smile.

△

“One last time before I become a demigod,” Phainon says. Their bed in Okhema. Mydei in the sheets, his hair undone, makeup washed clean. Phainon climbs to straddle him.

“You’re still injured,” Mydei says, kissing it into his mouth, already undoing his shirt. “You need to rest.”

“So?” Phainon asks, smearing his lips down Mydei’s jaw, reaching for his belt. Then, softly, he’s flipped and lowered onto his back, gently to not upset his bruises, Mydei’s arm slipping

out from under his waist as he moves to sit astride Phainon instead. He shrugs out of his upper layers and looks at him with warm, lidded eyes.

"So," he says, rolling their hips together firm and slow, "relax. I'll do all the work."

△

He wakes up alone the next morning. Perhaps Mydei is only getting breakfast or relieving himself, but it feels oddly like a betrayal. Phainon has gotten used to waking up first.

He dresses, eats, stares himself in the mirror for the last moments he can recognize himself as human. *Where are you?* he wonders. Mydei's fresh teeth marks in his neck. He leaves new ones every time they're together. *Where did you go?*

The string pulses softly. A dim red glow. Devotion. What does that mean, next to love? An endless chant of *for you, for you, for you.* The broken body of a god. The power of it writhing in his chest, making him sick.

He'll still be human. He'll still know love and peace and warmth. An hour until Tribios will bring him to the Vortex of Genesis to become a god. The string on his hand still glows softly. Sighing, he follows it.

It leads him to the Hero's Bath, the site of their first meeting, their first fight. Mydei isn't even bathing, just standing, watching the water fall.

"So this is where you disappeared to," Phainon calls. Mydei doesn't turn, doesn't look at him until they're standing shoulder to shoulder. And even when he does, he's frowning. "What is it?"

Mydei looks at him for a long while. Too intensely. He finally says, "I need to know. Did you agree to this because you want to do it and it feels right, or because I, and in turn Aglaea, pushed it on you?"

Phainon looks at him, almost dumbfounded. "I… don't feel pressured," he says. Not exactly, not quite. There are others who would try in his stead if he refused.

"Phainon," Mydei presses.

"I want to be a hero," Phainon says. "I meant it."

"But are you certain that Strife is the way to achieve that?"

No, Phainon thinks. *Not in the slightest.* He holds Mydei's gaze, frowns back. *It's for you,* he thinks. *I was always going to do this for you.* "Someone needs to inherit the coreflame," he says. "It was your idea for it to be me."

"And I'm asking you now," Mydei says, and his voice shakes, "because I didn't bother to ask you before. Do you want it to be you?"

"I'll do it."

"Phainon." He lifts a hand, curls it into a fist. Sighs and drops it. *"Equal,"* he says. "Husband, I… love you, and I'm asking if you're doing this for me, so I can escape my destiny, or if you're doing it for you."

For you, Phainon thinks. He's so stunned he parts his lips and closes them again. Finally, he croaks, "You. I'm doing it for you."

And Mydei sighs with something like relief and steps closer, cradling the back of Phainon's head and pulling him in, exhaling close to his ear. "Thank you," he says, and it's all Phainon can do to set hands on his waist as he reels in confusion. "But you don't need to let me be a fool anymore."

"I don't get it," Phainon says. "I don't get it at all."

A breathy laugh. "Strife was never meant to be your destiny," he says. "You've another burden. This is the one I'm meant to shoulder. I'll take it from here."

The weight, that heavy, monstrous feeling lifts, replaces itself with a flood of incredulity. "The coreflame?" Phainon asks, pulling back. Mydei's hand falls from his hair, holding his jaw instead, his cheek. "Mydei, you…"

"Your battles are mine," Mydei says. "That's what it means to be equals."

"You're joining the flame chase?"

"It would seem that way." Mydei smiles a little, sharp. "Wait for me, Deliverer. Let's spar when this is all over."

Phainon can do nothing more than laugh. "It's a date, Mydeimos."

△

It's a long wait for Mydei's return. Phainon sits against a rough stone wall in the Vortex of Genesis, feeling a wave of things. Worried for Mydei, yet with full faith in him. Relieved that he won't have to be the one to take up the authority of Strife, yet lost without it. Grateful, and the slightest bit upset.

He knows this was never meant to be his destiny. Strife doesn't fit. But what, then, does?

He slips a card from his pocket. It was Cyrene's, painted with his own visage. *You're going to be a hero,* she would say, cards spread before her, divining something Phainon never seriously believed in until she was gone. *You know how I know?*

A small body settles in next to his own. Trianne, sitting cross-legged, extending an eager hand. "Can we see it?" she asks.

Phainon smiles, chuckling a little, and holds the card out. "Just be careful," he says. And she is, cradling it gently in her hands, turning it over with uncharacteristic reverence. Trianne has always been the mischievous one, but not now. It's like she knows how important to him this is.

“It’s beautiful,” she says. “Is it you, Snowy?”

“It is,” Phainon answers with a light laugh. “Though I don’t think I look quite that cool in real life.”

She looks up at him and squints, studying him, and then the card, and then him again. “Not much difference,” she says, and passes the card back. “Who made it?”

“An old friend of mine.” Phainon takes the card back when she extends it. Turns it over in his hands to see the back. “Her name was Cyrene. She was from Aedes Elysiae too.”

“Oh,” Trianne says. She blinks, cocks her head. “Where is she now? We’d like to meet her.”

“I’m sure she’d love to meet you too,” Phainon says, and feels a little choked. It isn’t anger that he feels now, now anymore. Just something softer, sadder. Grief. “But she’s… at the end of the west wind, now.”

“Oh,” Trianne repeats, quieter. “Will you see her tomorrow?”

“Yes, Trianne,” Phainon says, voice wavering a little. “I’ll see her tomorrow.”

△

Still, they wait. Aglaea comes next. She offers him a small bunch of grapes and stands beside him where he chooses to sit. “He’ll be fine,” she says by way of a greeting. “I can feel your worry.”

“I know,” Phainon tells her. He plucks a grape from its stem. It’s sweet and crisp, cool on his tongue. “I just… wonder what kind of hardships he must be facing.”

“Nothing he can’t handle.” She looks at him. “Strife was always going to be his destiny.”

“So why didn’t you say anything?”

“It isn’t my place to drag people kicking and screaming toward their fates,” she answers, smiling slightly. “I had faith things would fall into place.”

He pulls off another grape. It leaves a bit of flesh still attached to the stem, transparent green, shiny with juice. He rolls the fruit over in his fingers and asks, “Would I have failed if I took the trial?”

“Yes, Phainon. You would have.”

“I don’t get it,” he says. “All my life… I’m supposed to be this perfect vessel, but…” He cuts himself off with a sigh.

“Your time will come,” Aglaea says patiently. “There’s another weight meant for your shoulders.”

“I feel useless.”

“You’re not,” she says simply. “One day, you’ll be exactly what Amphoreus needs.”

How do you know? he thinks. *How does anyone know?* He turns his gaze toward the darkened sky, the constellations lit within. The ones still dim.

“Somehow,” Aglaea says, gazing out there too. “I don’t think you’ll be waiting too much longer.”

△

Time passes. Phainon is left alone. He stands to stretch, walks a lap around the damp, cool cave and takes a seat at the ledge beneath the sky, water crashing below. He listens to that. Watches the constellations flicker and blink. Hears a soft splash, a shaky exhale, footsteps.

Mydei sits beside him, graceless like his legs have turned to rubber, the metal of his armor scraping against rock. He smells like blood, and his expression is frenzied when Phainon looks at him.

“You passed the trial, then?”

“What does it look like?” Mydei grumbles, voice rough and low, hands curling into fists in his lap. Restless, bloodlusting energy, just like the war cries all over again. Whatever he’d seen, whatever he’d been asked to do, it probably still flashes behind his eyes.

Phainon chuckles weakly. “And how do you feel?”

“Like I’m going insane,” Mydei answers. “I want—” A shuddering breath. “It hasn’t settled yet. I’ll get used to it.”

Phainon brings a hand to his cheek, angling his head so they look at each other. “You’re a god now,” he says. A muscle in Mydei’s jaw tics. His gaze dips to Phainon’s mouth and back up, pupils blown wide from the dark or the adrenaline or both. Phainon is half convinced he can hear the sound of his heart.

“Don’t,” Mydei grits. He’s ended up closer, with or without meaning to. The blood smell is strong, metallic and heavy. “I’m… dangerous right now.”

“Dangerous?” Phainon laughs. He grips Mydei’s chin, slinking a little closer, edging his face up, smiling. “To me?”

Mydei grabs his wrist, pulling him off and pulling a punch that Phainon dodges by jumping upright and away from the ledge. Mydei is quick to follow, and they exchange a few blows before Phainon is laughing, laughing, laughing, and Mydei is throwing him onto his back and pinning him down, straddling his waist and bringing a hand to his throat. He’s frowning, gaze still blown and intense, one finger slipping beneath the straps of Phainon’s choker to rest at his pulse point.

“Yield,” he says, a little bit lost as a tear slips from the corner of Phainon’s eye from his laughter. He finally quiets, looking up at this new god, old lover. His braid hanging between them, expression shadowed in the dark. Cold stone beneath Phainon’s back. The hand at his

throat hardly puts pressure at all. The other, pinning his wrist, is tangled in a thread that glows crimson all the way through. Love to devotion. When did it change?

“You’re beautiful,” Phainon says, airy as he steals his breath back from the wind.

“Yield,” Mydei repeats, pulling the choker taut. An arena, booming with cheers. Dirt and sweat and fire. Deja Vu.

Swiftly, Phainon grabs Mydei’s wrist, bucking to throw him off, to roll them, locking his legs around Mydei’s knees and pinning one hand with each of his. “Not this time,” he pants. Mydei jerks under him, dangerously close to kneeing him in the groin before he shifts slightly and squeezes hard enough that Mydei can’t move at all. “Your turn,” he says. “Yield.”

But Mydei isn’t looking at him. He’s looking at something beside his head that gleams slightly in the dim light and rolls to a stop. “What is that?” he asks. A little further and it could have rolled right back into the sea.

“Yield and I’ll tell you.”

Mydei glares. “HKS.”

“Darling,” Phainon replies. “Sweetheart, angel, honeyca—”

Mydei throws him off and he hits the ground with a hard thump, hissing as he pushes himself up to sit. Mydei snatches the ring off the ground and turns it so he can see the signet. Phainon waits as he studies it, as he sits there and doesn’t speak for a good minute.

“This was my mother’s, wasn’t it?” he asks after a long moment. Phainon hums his assent. “I thought it was lost to the River of Souls.”

“It was,” Phainon agrees. Mydei looks at him.

“You did this?” he asks.

“Chartonus was a great deal of help.” They hold gazes for a long while. Phainon clears his throat. “I was going to give it to you after *I* passed the trial, but, well. I suppose now is as good a time as any.”

“HKS,” Mydei curses, slipping the ring on his finger and hauling Phainon in by the collar, kissing him like it’s the last time they’ll get to do it, pulling his lips open with a thumb on his chin, licking into his mouth deeply, hotly, wetly. He tastes how he smells, like blood and teeth and the sweat on his upper lip. Phainon falls back, catching himself with a hand on the ground, kind of gasping, kind of shocked, and then Mydei pulls away from his mouth to fall into his neck instead. Kissing softly, scraping his teeth under Phainon’s choker.

Phainon sets a startled hand on the back of his head, carding through his hair. “So dangerous,” he teases, more than a little baffled. “In the Vortex of Genesis of all places? With all the titans watch— *Ah!”* Mydei nips his throat, yet another mark blooming beneath his teeth as he lets out an unhappy grunt. Phainon laughs. “That hurts, Mydeimos.”

“Good.”

Phainon laughs. Slides his hand back until he can lay flat, Mydei practically on top of him. He stares at the cragged rock above them, the sky, the stars. “How do you feel?” he asks.

“Fine,” Mydei murmurs. “Tired. I don’t want to go back yet.”

“Okay,” Phainon breathes back. He pets through Mydei’s hair. Soft, rhythmic. “We’ll stay here until you’re ready.”

△

They return under the cover of nightfall, taking alleys instead of main streets and ducking behind corners to avoid being spotted. Mydei isn’t ready to be seen quite yet, cheered and lionized as the new God of Strife, so they do this. Hand in hand, Phainon feels a bit like a kid again, hiding from his parents with a giggling Cyrene. An ache of nostalgia. He pulls Mydei behind a tree.

“Race you,” he says, halfway there. “You lose if you get caught.”

Mydei huffs, gives him a half smile. “You’re on, Deliverer,” he says. “Do you need a head start?”

“Not a chance,” Phainon tells him. “On three. One.”

“Two,” Mydei says. They make eye contact, settling into running stances.

“Three.”

They take off, a straightaway in the dark streets. And really, there’s no one out this late to catch them anyway. Phainon runs and runs, and perhaps he has the advantage of slightly longer legs and a more rested body, because he pulls ahead just slightly, Mydei’s footsteps pounding behind him.

“HKS!” he hears, and almost trips on a loose rock. He laughs and loses his breath, heart pounding, panting, running as hard as he can. The gap between them grows as they approach Marmoreal Palace, and as Phainon slips inside he catches a glimpse of someone walking and skids to a stop, pressing himself against the wall. Mydei crashes into him and they fall, tumbling and cursing, right at Tribbie’s feet.

She blinks at them. “Snowy, De?” she asks. “What are you doing? Are you playing some kind of game?”

Phainon bolts upright, smoothing out his robes. He holds a hand out to Mydei, who slaps it aside and gets up without help, huffing. “Lady Tribbie,” Phainon says, sounding like the fool that he is. “What are you doing out so late?”

She opens her mouth, closes it, pursing her lips with a guilty expression. “Trianne was hungry,” she mumbles. “We were… well…”

Phainon laughs. “Tell you what,” he says, bringing a finger to his lips. “We won’t tell anyone we saw you if you won’t tell anyone you saw us. Deal?”

She laughs, high and delighted. “Deal,” she says, and turns to Mydei. “How was the trial, De?” she asks. “How do you feel?”

“I am well, Lady Tribbie,” he says, a little stiff, a little awkward. “Just eager for some rest.”

She nods. “We get it,” she says, and reaches out to take his hand. A big, bright smile. “Rest well, De. We’re so glad you decided to join us.”

“I… Yes, well. Thank you,” Mydei says, and watches as she skips off. He turns to Phainon. “Let’s go. Since *someone* got us caught.”

“Someone?” Phainon repeats incredulously. “Just who crashed into who now? If it hadn’t been for you—”

“Shut up,” Mydei tells him, without heat. They walk the rest of the way back to their rooms, and he falls straight into the bed.

Phainon watches his back, the shift of his side as he breathes, red markings. “Aren’t you going to bathe?” he asks, sitting on the foot of the bed.

Mydei grunts. “Tomorrow,” he says. “We can change the sheets.”

“Alright,” Phainon agrees with a laugh, and begins the process of winding down, starting with undoing the buckles on his shoes. In his peripheral, he watches Mydei sit up, body bowing over itself. He twists his mother’s signet ring around his finger. A red thread twists on the sheets between them.

“I don’t want to be king,” Mydei says after a while. “Every king of Kremnos has been crowned by killing his own father, and I…” He sighs.

“That much can end with you,” Phainon tries.

“But what about the rest of it?” Mydei asks. He’s still spinning the ring, not looking at Phainon. “The black tide isn’t going away. We beat Nikador, but Kremnos is still crumbling more and more each day. My people are still losing their homes, and I… I have to lead them somewhere.”

What’s left of Castrum Kremnos isn’t going to last much longer, even Phainon knows this. They’d hoped to take back the city but it’s still falling. Slowly, gradually, but it’s inevitable. Phainon kicks off his shoes and crawls over the mattress to Mydei’s side. “You can send them here,” he suggests gently, kissing his bare shoulder. “They won’t like it, but they can take their time, and you… you won’t have to be king forever, if that’s not what you want.”

Sighing, Mydei leans into him, head on his shoulder, hair ticking his chin. “It was prophesied that I would lead Kremnos to its fall,” he says. “This is it, isn’t it?”

“Maybe,” Phainon says, and pulls one of Mydei’s hands into his lap. “Is this why you decided to join the flame chase?”

A halfhearted laugh. Mydei’s palm opens, fingers spreading for Phainon’s to fit between them. “It would look stupid for me to stand around doing nothing while you play hero.”

“I’m with you,” Phainon tells him. “Like you said earlier, your battles are my battles. That’s what it means to be equals. So if you’ll stand by me in the flame chase, I’ll stand by you as you guide Kremnos wherever the west wind takes you.”

“You’re terribly sentimental, Deliverer,” Mydei tells him, warm fingers skimming his knuckles.

“Romantic,” Phainon corrects, playing with the red string connecting their hands. Devotion flowing both ways in equal measure. He thinks of Mydei’s pinched expression in telling Phainon he loves him and laughs. “Just call me romantic.”

Chapter End Notes

How embarrassing would it be if there were some gapingly obvious things I forgot to tie up... pls say it isn't so... anyway,
an outtake:

"I don't want to be king," Mydei says after a while. "Every king of Kremnos has been crowned by killing his own father. I..." He sighs.

"That much can end with you," Phainon tries. "I don't think we'll be having any sons to commit patricide." He pauses then, studying Mydei, gaze landing on the hard ridges of his abdomen, expression clouding. "Unless there's something you aren't telling me, that is."

huge thank you to anyone who got all the way to the end of the fic <3 I'm honored with your time, attention, and thoughts. I may not be too chatty in my author's notes but I do love yapping with you all about them. it's been a journey and I've grown very fond of this universe... I'm going to miss writing in it :') but alas, other fics await in my docs

Please look at this beautiful art by rizun!!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!